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1,300 devotees to join Somnath Yatra marking 1,000 years of faith

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

The Delhi Government is organising a pilgrimage for 1,300 devotees to the Somnath pilgrimage to mark 1,000 years of faith in the shrine that was attacked by Mahmud Ghazni in 1026.

Announcing this on Monday, Chief Minister Rekha Gupta said her Government is organising Somnath Swabhiman Parv-Somnath Yatra for Delhiites, which is dedicated to 1,000 years of "eternal faith".

A special train carrying around 1,300 devotees will depart from Safdarjung railway station on April 30 for the shrine of Somnath in Gujarat. The train is scheduled to reach its destination the following morning, said Rekha Gupta. During the three-day visit from May 1 to May 3, the pilgrims will offer



prayers at the Somnath temple dedicated to Lord Shiva and also visit other nearby religious sites, she said. All arrangements for accommodation, food, drinking water and other facilities for the devotees will be made by the Gujarat Government, she said.

The Delhi chief minister said the initiative is not just a pilgrimage but an auspicious occasion to connect

with the Sanatan culture, Indian tradition and spiritual roots of the country. She said the Somnath shrine is a divine symbol of Lord Shiva's blessings, the faith of Sanatan and the eternal cultural consciousness of India.

"This is not merely a journey, but a meaningful opportunity to reconnect with Sanatan traditions, India's cultural ethos and our shared civilisational her-

itage," she said. Highlighting the spiritual significance of Somnath, Gupta said the shrine represents Lord Shiva's divine grace, enduring faith and India's timeless cultural consciousness.

"It stands as a reminder of a legacy that has withstood every challenge and preserved its identity and belief. This yatra is a celebration of that resilience and national pride," she said, adding that the strong participation from Delhi reflects the depth and strength of the country's cultural roots.

She noted that such initiatives not only reinforce religious faith but also foster social harmony and national unity. "This effort will further strengthen the spirit of 'Ek Bharat, Shreshtha Bharat' and provide younger generations an opportunity to connect with their traditions," she said.

CM orders weekly ration camps, sets Diwali deadline for LPG coverage

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Delhi Chief Minister Rekha Gupta on Monday ordered weekly public grievance camps across the capital for the immediate resolution of ration card complaints. The Chief Minister directed a crackdown on corruption in the public distribution system, and fixed a Diwali deadline to extend free LPG connections to every eligible family still left uncovered.

The decisions were taken during a detailed review meeting of the Food, Supplies, and Consumer Affairs Department, where the Chief Minister assessed the functioning of ration delivery, pending public complaints, technology upgrades, and the progress of welfare schemes linked to food security and cooking fuel.



In the most immediate step, the Chief Minister announced that Jan Shikayat Samadhan Camps will begin from May 1 and will be held every Saturday from 9 am to 11 am at all designated centres across Delhi. These camps, she said, will function under the supervision of Assistant Commissioners and will focus primarily on clearing all pending ration card grievances on the spot.

The Chief Minister also warned officials that she would conduct surprise visits to some of these centres to check whether citizens are actually getting relief or complaints are merely being recorded without action. Officials have also been directed to use these camps to spread awareness about the One Nation One Ration Card system and clearly explain that a beneficiary

can lift ration from only one location at a given time.

The Chief Minister made it clear that the Government wants visible improvement in ration services and not just departmental reviews on paper. She expressed serious concern over repeated complaints of under-weighting of foodgrain, delays in delivery, unauthorised deductions, and irregular conduct by ration dealers.

Calling these complaints unacceptable, the Chief Minister ordered that responsibility be fixed not only on fair price shop dealers but also on suppliers and officers involved in the chain, wherever lapses are found. "Strict accountability has to be enforced in the entire supply system. Anyone found indulging in negligence or malpractice will face action," she said during the meeting.

Govt announces 5 dry days for upcoming festivals



PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

The Delhi Government has declared five dry days in the coming months, including on the occasions of Buddha Purnima, Bakrid, Muharram, Independence Day and Janmashtami.

In pursuance of the provisions of Rule 52 of Delhi Excise Rules, 2010, Buddha Purnima (May 1), Id-ul-Zuha (May 27), Muharram (June 26), Independence Day (August 15), and Janmashtami

(September 9), will be observed as "dry day", said an excise department order.

The restriction on the sale of liquor on dry days will not apply to the service of liquor to residents in case of hotels having L-15 and L-15 F license, the order said. All the licensees will exhibit the "dry day" order at some conspicuous place of their licensed premises.

The business premises of the licensee concerned will be kept closed on dry days, it added.

Two youths die in motorcycle crash near Majlis Park Metro

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Two young men were killed after the motorcycle they were riding crashed near the Majlis Park Metro station in Outer North Delhi's Bhalswa Dairy area on Sunday night. According to the police, the bike was later found abandoned near a drain, and no eyewitness has yet surfaced to explain how the fatal accident unfolded.

The victims, both in their early twenties, had suffered severe injuries in the crash and were rushed to the hospital by passersby before police reached the spot. Doctors, however, declared both dead on arrival. The accident took place around 9 pm on the stretch connecting Ring Road towards Wazirabad, close to Majlis Park Metro station, an area



that sees heavy movement of vehicles even during late evening hours.

Police said information was received about a motorcycle lying damaged near a drain in the Bhalswa Dairy area. A team rushed to the location but found no injured persons there, only the abandoned two-wheeler. By the time officers began checking nearby hospitals, they learnt that two critically injured men had already been shifted by the public to Babu Jagjivan Ram Memorial Hospital.

A senior police officer said both riders had sustained grievous injuries consistent with a high-impact road crash.

"Passersby took the injured to the hospital before the local police team could reach the accident point. Both were declared dead by doctors. We are now trying to reconstruct the sequence of events and ascertain whether it was a self-skid, overspeeding case, or whether another vehicle was involved," the officer said.

CIC pulls up NDMC for vague RTI reply on Gole Market demolition

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

The Central Information Commission (CIC) has pulled up the New Delhi Municipal Council (NDMC) for a "vague and non-specific" RTI reply on demolition and alleged reconstruction of shanties near Gole Market, whereas the civic body had cited unavailability of police force and later, the Model Code of Conduct (MCC) for not carrying out further action.

The appellant had sought details on whether around 45 "jhuggis" (shanties) were demolished in March 2022 and how nearly 100 structures allegedly came up at the same site again, along with information on action taken by authorities.

However, the NDMC's central public information officer (CPIO) denied answering most queries, citing section 2(f) of the Right to Information (RTI) Act.

On the issue of reconstructed jhuggis, the NDMC had said demolition action was planned but "due to unavailability of police force, proposed action for removal of reconstructed jhuggies has not been executed. Thereafter, due to enforcement of Model Code of Conduct, demolition action has been



kept in abeyance". Taking exception, Information Commissioner Vinod Kumar Tiwari noted that "the CPIO has denied information on point Nos. 1 to 3 by invoking section 2(f) of the RTI Act in a mechanical manner, without adequately examining whether the information sought is available on record".

Section 2(f) of the RTI Act, 2005, defines "information" as any material in any form—records, documents, memos, emails, opinions, advice, press releases, circulars, contracts, reports, samples or data held by or under the control of a public authority. Tiwari further stressed that the queries were related to "action taken by the public authority which should have been provided to the extent available on record".



Finance Limited
Ghar Ki Baat

Regd. Office: 9th Floor Antriksh Bhawan, 22, K. G. Marg, New Delhi-110001
Ph: 011-23445200, Website: www.pnbhousing.com CIN NO.: L65922DL1988PLC033856

NOTICE FOR SHIFTING OF PREMISES TO WHOMSOEVER IT MAY CONCERN

This is the notice to the General Public that we are shifting Following Office Premises on or before 1st August 2026

CURRENT ADDRESS
PNB Housing Finance Limited, Unit No. 14A & 14B on 14th Floor, Plot No. A-41, Sector-62, Noida, UP-201309

NEW ADDRESS (POST SHIFTING)
PNB Housing Finance Limited, D-2, Ground Floor, Sector-3, Noida, U.P. - 201301

Sd/-, Authorised Officer, PNB HOUSING FINANCE LIMITED



NORTHERN RAILWAY
E-TENDER NOTICE

Sr. DEE-TRS-GZB acting for and on behalf of President of India invites E-Tender against Tender No. 230-TRS-GZB-2025-26-32. The details are as under:

- Name of the work** "Attending and Filling up of dry, screened, clean sand in sandbox after draining out of moist or wet sand if any inside the sandbox along with its disposal at provided place and ensuring free flow of sand in AC Electric Locomotives with supply of sand conforming to RDSO specification No. AARM-916-51 and packed in 10 kg water proof bags for use in Electric Locomotives sanding equipment round the clock' at Electric Loco Shed, Ghaziabad.
- Approx. cost of work** ₹43,31,858.40
- Earnest Money to be deposited** ₹86,600.00
- Last Date & Time of Submission of tender bid of tender** 22/05/2026 (15:00 Hrs.)
- Date & Time of opening of tender document** 22.05.2026 (After 15:00 Hrs.)
- Website particulars where complete details of tender documents can be seen** www.irops.gov.in

Note : (i) The tenderer/s must be registered on the Indian Railway E-Procurement System (IREPS) site i.e. www.irops.gov.in for participating in e-tendering system. (ii) For all terms and conditions please refer tender document. (iii) No manual offers are acceptable. (iv) Cost of Tender document and Earnest money will be acceptable through net banking or payment gateway only. No. 230-TRS-GZB-2025-26-32 Dated: 25.04.2026 1391/2026

SERVING CUSTOMERS WITH A SMILE



DELHI TRANSCO LIMITED
NOTICE INVITING e-TENDERS

Delhi Transco Ltd (A Government of NCT of Delhi Undertaking) invites online tender, for the following work:

Tender No.T25P131641: Internal External Repairing/ Finishing and Renovation of toilet blocks at Prefab building RPH, DTL.

For complete details of the tender please visit following websites :- <https://govtprocurement.delhi.gov.in> (Tender ID No. 2026_DTL_290336_1) and www.dtl.gov.in with Unique No. DTL-9981-240426.

Last date for bid submission: **21.05.2026 at 13:00 Hrs.**

All Corrigendum/Addendum/ Amendments/Date of Extension/Clarifications etc. to this e-tender will be hosted on the above website only. Bidders should regularly visit website to keep themselves updated.



AXIS BANK

Retail Asset Centre: Axis House, Jaypee Green Wish Town, Tower-2, 4th Floor, Sec-128, Noida Expressway, Noida-201301 Corporate Office: 'Axis House', Block-B, Bombay Dyeing Mills Compound, Pandurang Budhkar Marg, Worli, Mumbai-400025 Registered Office: 'Trishul', 3rd floor, opposite Samarthwara Temple, Law garden, Ellisbridge, Ahmedabad-380006 Also at: Axis Bank Ltd. Hinayata House, Upper Ground Floor & First Floor, KG Marg, Connaught Place, New Delhi-110021

POSSESSION NOTICE UNDER SARFACSI ACT 2002

Whereas The undersigned being the Authorized Officer of Axis Bank Ltd. under the Securitisation, Reconstruction of Financial Assets and Enforcement of Security Interest Act, 2002 and in exercise of the powers conferred under Section 13 (12) read with Rule 9 of the Security Interest (Enforcement) rules 2002, issued demand notice upon the Borrower(s) Co-Borrower(s) Guarantor(s) Mortgage(s) mentioned below, to repay the amount mentioned in the notice within 60 days from the date of receipt of the said notice, The Borrower(s) Co-Borrower(s) Guarantor(s) Mortgage(s) having failed to repay the amount, notice is hereby given to the Borrower(s) Co-Borrower(s) Guarantor(s) Mortgage(s) and the public in general that the undersigned has taken possession of the property described herein below in exercise of powers conferred on him/ her under Section 13(4) of the said Act read with Rule 8 of the said rules on the below-mentioned details. The Borrower(s) Co-Borrower(s) Guarantor(s) Mortgage(s) in particular and the public in general are hereby cautioned not to deal with the property and any dealings with the property which is subject to the charge of Axis Bank Ltd. The Borrower(s) Co-Borrower(s) Guarantor(s) Mortgage(s) are attention to attend to provisions of sub-section (8) of section 13 of the Act, in respect of time available, to redeem the secured assets.

Name of Borrower & Co-borrower: 1. Mr. Anand K Vatash, 27 2nd Floor, Gujarat Vihar Near Preet Vihar Metro Station, New Delhi-110092 Also At- Mr Anand K Vatash B-101, Sector-63 Noida, UP-201301 Also At- Mr Anand K Vatash H No 139, Chota Akhara Brahmapuri, Jaipur- 302002 Also At- Noida-201301 Also At- Celeste Tower Plot No-D-003 Sec-44 Noida, UP-201301 [A] [P] [a] [t] [t] 2. M/s Office Pvt Ltd B-101, Sec-63 Noida, UP-201301 (Co-Applient) Description of Property: All That Of Apt. No-22 Europa Aspire Ltd, Celeste Tower, Plot No-D-003 Sec 44, Noida, UP-201301 and bounded as under- As per site plan, West-as per site plan, North-as per site plan, South-as per site plan.

Date of Demand Notice	Date of Possession	Amount in Demand Notice
06/02/2026	24/04/2026	₹. 9,23,06,032/- (Rupees Nine Crore Twenty Three Lakh Six Thousand Thirty Two Nine NINE)

The above-mentioned Borrower(s) Co-Borrower(s) Guarantor(s) Mortgage(s) are hereby given a 30 days' Notice to repay the amount, since the mortgaged properties will be sold on the expiry of 30 days' from the date of publication of this Notice, as per the provisions under the Rules 8 and 9 of Security Interest (Enforcement) Rules 2002 Place: Noida, Date: 28/04/2026 Sd/- Authorized Officer, Axis Bank Ltd.



HARERA GURUGRAM

PUBLIC NOTICE

REGARDING EXTENSION OF REGISTRATION OF THE AFFORDABLE RESIDENTIAL PLOTTED COLONY UNDER DDJAY NAMEDLY "MKS COUNTY" HARERA RC NO. 43 OF 2022 SITUATED IN Sector-2, Sohna, District Gurugram being developed by M/s Metro Technobuild Pvt. Ltd.

It is for the information of the general public and allottees of project namely "MKS COUNTY" situated in sector-2, Sohna, District Gurugram that an application for extension of registration of project under Section 6 of the Act of 2016 has been submitted in the Authority by M/s Metro Technobuild Pvt. Ltd. on 16.04.2026.

The Department of Town & Country Planning, Haryana has granted license no. 42 of 2022 dated 13.04.2022 valid up to 12.04.2027 measuring 12.125 acres to M/s Metro Technobuild Pvt. Ltd. (license holder) for setting up of affordable residential plotted colony under DDJAY in sector-2, Sohna, District Gurugram.

The project "MKS COUNTY" is registered with the Authority vide RC No. 43 of 2022 dated 25.05.2022 valid upto 24.04.2026.

Now, the promoter i.e., M/s Metro Technobuild Pvt. Ltd. has applied for the extension of registration of the affordable residential plotted colony under Section 6 of RERA Act, 2016 vide application dated 16.04.2026. It is noted that the promoter has now obtained the revised layout plan vide DRG No. - GDTCP B894 dated 02.01.2023 and zoning plan vide DRG no. - 9075 dated 16.03.2023. As per the provisions of Section 14(2)(i) of the Real Estate (Regulation and Development) Act, 2016 any alteration or addition in the sanctioned plan of the project requires written consent of at least two third of the allottees. The promoter has submitted written consent of 9 existing allottees out of total 11 existing allottees of the project which is more than two third of the total number of allottees which were sold prior to the revision in the layout plan of the project as submitted by the promoter.

The Authority is considering an application of the promoter to grant extension of the registration certificate under section 6 of the Act for this project and hereby invite objections from the allottees in particular and any other concerned persons in general in this regard.

The relevant application and related documents are available in the office of the Haryana Real Estate Regulatory Authority, Gurugram which can be seen by any concerned on any working day during office hours upto 08.05.2026 from 9.00 am to 4.00 pm. The objections if any, shall be filed in the registry of the Authority before 08.05.2026 upto 10.00 am and may appear before the Authority on 11.05.2026 at 11.00 am during the hearing.

Given under the approval of the Authority and its seal.

Sd/-
Secretary,
Haryana Real Estate Regulatory Authority, Gurugram

Date: 27.04.2026



A notable change was witnessed in the RWA elections of Fortview Apartments, Pocket 13B, Kalkaji Extension, after eight years. The New Professional Group secured a clear and convincing victory, unseating the incumbent team with a substantial margin. The panel, led by Ramesh Pandey, garnered strong support from the residents



MAHARAJA RANJIT SINGH PUNJAB TECHNICAL UNIVERSITY
Batala Road, Batalinda.
(Established by Govt. of Punjab vide Punjab Act No. 5 of 2015)

PUBLIC NOTICE

My clients **Ram Tirath S/o Munshi Lal & Smt. Shanti W/o Sh. Ram Tirath R/o H.No. 137, G-30, Rohini sector-3, Rohini, North West Delhi-110085** have debarred their son **Gaurav Gahlot** and his wife **Smt. Anju Thakur** at Premia along with their children from all movable/immovable properties and severed their relations from them due to their bad-behaviour and conduct. My client's shall not responsible for their act and deed.

Rajesh Kumar Gautam (Advocate)
Ch. No. 127, Old Court, Kashmir Gate, Delhi-110006

PUBLIC NOTICE

My client **Zeenat W/o Late Naseer Ahmed R/o H. No. B-13/97, Gali No. 6, Kabir Nagar, Delhi -110094**, hereby withdraw her public notice dated 03.11.2024 published in Rashtriya Sahara Daily Hindi Newspaper against her son Amir, with immediate effect and now onwards my client has revived her relations with her son only.

Rajan Lal (Advocate) Ch No- F-324 Karkardooma Courts, Delhi-110032



MAHARAJA RANJIT SINGH PUNJAB TECHNICAL UNIVERSITY
Batala Road, Batalinda.
(Established by Govt. of Punjab vide Punjab Act No. 5 of 2015)

No. E-TENDER/MRSP/TPR/PURCHASE/2026/578 Dated: 24 April 2026

SHORT TERM E-TENDER NOTICE

E-Tender is invited for Purchase of Items/Equipment/Apparatus, Rate Contract for Hiring of Vehicles etc.
For details visit: www.mrspu.ac.in.
Corrigendum if any, will be issued on university website only.
Time & Schedule:
Start Date: 29-04-2026 (11:00 AM) Last Date of Submission: 09-05-2026 (03:00 PM)
REGISTRAR

1049/12/2026-27/10925 Dated CHD :- 27/04/2026

कार्यालय परियोजना प्रबन्धक यूनिट-31, कन्स्ट्रक्शन एण्ड डिजाइन सर्विसेज उ०प्र० जल निगम (नगरीय) (उ०प्र० सरकार का उपक्रम)

एस.बी.-90, शास्त्री नगर गाजियाबाद 201002
प्रधान कार्यालय : टी.सी.-38 बी., विभूतिखण्ड, इण्डियन ऑयल के पास, गोमतीनगर, लखनऊ।
Visit us at: www.cdsupjn.org
Email: cdspmun31@gmail.com

निविदा सूचना सं599/Vividh-12/85 दिनांक 15.04.2026

ई-निविदा सूचना

अथवा, उत्तर प्रदेश जल निगम, की ओर से ओरोहसाखरी द्वारा जनपद बुन्देलखर के कन्दूवा गाँवी बस्तिका विद्यार्थ कन्दूवाखर में कम्प्यूटर सेब का निगम कार्य, अनुमानित सामान रूप 15.99 लाख (लीएसएन्डी) रहित एवं लेबर सेस सहित। हेतु सी०एण्ड डी०एन० में घोषित श्रेणी में भवन कार्य हेतु पंजीकृत ठेकेदारों से दिनांक 21.05.2026 के अग्रप्रा 16.00 बजे तक ई-निविदाएं आमन्त्रित की जाती हैं। उक्त कार्य हेतु ई-निविदा प्रपत्र दिनांक 24.04.2026 से दिनांक 21.05.2026 के मध्य उत्तर प्रदेश सरकार की e-procurement वेबसाइट <https://etenderup.nic.in> पर ही उपलब्ध किये जा सकते हैं तथा ई-निविदा दिनांक 21.05.2026 को पूर्वाह्न 16.30 बजे सी०एण्ड डी०एन० यूनिट-31, उ०प्र० जल निगम, गाजियाबाद में निविदा खोली जायेगी। ई-निविदा प्रपत्र का मूल्य रूप 2000.00 + GST (18%) अतिरिक्त देय होगा।

निविदा से सम्बन्धित विस्तृत विवरण विभाग की वेबसाइट www.cdsupjn.org एवं प्रोक्विमेंट पोर्टल <https://etenderup.nic.in> पर उपलब्ध है। समस्त शुद्धि पत्र (Corrigendum) <https://etenderup.nic.in> पर ही उपलब्ध किये जा सकते हैं तथा ई-निविदा दिनांक 21.05.2026 को पूर्वाह्न 16.30 बजे सी०एण्ड डी०एन० यूनिट-31, उ०प्र० जल निगम, गाजियाबाद में निविदा खोली जायेगी। निविदादाताओं को सलाह दी जाती है कि वे उक्त वेबसाइट का समय-समय पर अवलोकन करते रहें।

परियोजना प्रबन्धक

कार्यालय परियोजना प्रबन्धक यूनिट-31, कन्स्ट्रक्शन एण्ड डिजाइन सर्विसेज उ०प्र० जल निगम (नगरीय) (उ०प्र० सरकार का उपक्रम)

एस.बी.-90, शास्त्री नगर गाजियाबाद 201002
प्रधान कार्यालय : टी.सी.-38 बी., विभूतिखण्ड, इण्डियन ऑयल के पास, गोमतीनगर, लखनऊ।
Visit us at: www.cdsupjn.org
Email: cdspmun31@gmail.com

निविदा सूचना सं600/Vividh-12/86 दिनांक 15.04.2026

ई-निविदा सूचना

अथवा, उत्तर प्रदेश जल निगम, की ओर से ओरोहसाखरी द्वारा जनपद बुन्देलखर के कन्दूवा गाँवी बस्तिका विद्यार्थ कन्दूवाखर में कम्प्यूटर सेब का निगम कार्य, अनुमानित सामान रूप 15.99 लाख (लीएसएन्डी) रहित एवं लेबर सेस सहित। हेतु सी०एण्ड डी०एन० में घोषित श्रेणी में भवन कार्य हेतु पंजीकृत ठेकेदारों से दिनांक 21.05.2026 के अग्रप्रा 16.00 बजे तक ई-निविदाएं आमन्त्रित की जाती हैं। उक्त कार्य हेतु ई-निविदा प्रपत्र दिनांक 24.04.2026 से दिनांक 21.05.2026 के मध्य उत्तर प्रदेश सरकार की e-procurement वेबसाइट <https://etenderup.nic.in> पर ही उपलब्ध किये जा सकते हैं तथा ई-निविदा दिनांक 21.05.2026 को पूर्वाह्न 16.30 बजे सी०एण्ड डी०एन० यूनिट-31, उ०प्र० जल निगम, गाजियाबाद में निविदा खोली जायेगी। ई-निविदा प्रपत्र का मूल्य रूप 2000.00 + GST (18%) अतिरिक्त देय होगा।

निविदा से सम्बन्धित विस्तृत विवरण विभाग की वेबसाइट www.cdsupjn.org एवं प्रोक्विमेंट पोर्टल <https://etenderup.nic.in> पर उपलब्ध है। समस्त शुद्धि पत्र (Corrigendum) <https://etenderup.nic.in> पर ही उपलब्ध किये जा सकते हैं तथा ई-निविदा दिनांक 21.05.2026 को पूर्वाह्न 16.30 बजे सी०एण्ड डी०एन० यूनिट-31, उ०प्र० जल निगम, गाजियाबाद में निविदा खोली जायेगी। निविदादाताओं को सलाह दी जाती है कि वे उक्त वेबसाइट का समय-समय पर अवलोकन करते रहें।

परियोजना प्रबन्धक

कार्यालय परियोजना प्रबन्धक यूनिट-31, कन्स्ट्रक्शन एण्ड डिजाइन सर्विसेज उ०प्र० जल निगम (नगरीय) (उ०प्र० सरकार का उपक्रम)

एस.बी.-90, शास्त्री नगर गाजियाबाद 201002
प्रधान कार्यालय : टी.सी.-38 बी., विभूतिखण्ड, इण्डियन ऑयल के पास, गोमतीनगर, लखनऊ।
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निविदा सूचना सं601/Vividh-12/87 दिनांक 15.04.2026

ई-निविदा सूचना

अथवा, उत्तर प्रदेश जल निगम, की ओर से ओरोहसाखरी द्वारा जनपद बुन्देलखर के कन्दूवा गाँवी बस्तिका विद्यार्थ कन्दूवाखर में कम्प्यूटर सेब का निगम कार्य, अनुमानित सामान रूप 15.99 लाख (लीएसएन्डी) रहित एवं लेबर सेस सहित। हेतु सी०एण्ड डी०एन० में घोषित श्रेणी में भवन कार्य हेतु पंजीकृत ठेकेदारों से दिनांक 21.05.2026 के अग्रप्रा 16.00 बजे तक ई-निविदाएं आमन्त्रित की जाती हैं। उक्त कार्य हेतु ई-निविदा प्रपत्र दिनांक 24.04.2026 से दिनांक 21.05.2026 के मध्य उत्तर प्रदेश सरकार की e-procurement वेबसाइट <https://etenderup.nic.in> पर ही उपलब्ध किये जा सकते हैं तथा ई-निविदा दिनांक 21.05.2026 को पूर्वाह्न 16.30 बजे सी०एण्ड डी०एन० यूनिट-31, उ०प्र० जल निगम, गाजियाबाद में निविदा खोली जायेगी। ई-निविदा प्रपत्र का मूल्य रूप 2000.00 + GST (18%) अतिरिक्त देय होगा।

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निविदा सूचना सं602/Vividh-12/88 दिनांक 15.04.2026

ई-निविदा सूचना

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निविदा सूचना सं603/Vividh-12/89 दिनांक 15.04.2026

ई-निविदा सूचना

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Season’s first dust storm sweeps in after 42.3°C temperature

ABHINAV KUMAR JHA
■ New Delhi

By the time the dust storm arrived on Monday evening, Delhi had already spent the day gasping. The thermometer at Safdarjung had touched 42.3 degrees Celsius, the second-hottest day of the month, three degrees above normal, the kind of heat that sits on the city like a weight. Then, without much warning, the western sky turned brown. The first dust storm of the season had arrived in the Capital.

This correspondent was on the road near Connaught Place when the light changed first. The afternoon had been still and punishing. Then the trees along the boulevard began to shiver. A tea stall owner at a corner on Baba Kharak Singh Marg scram-

bled to pull a plastic sheet over his setup, tucking down the edges with practised urgency. A shopkeeper outside a small provisions store near Rajiv Chowk dragged his display rack inside, fruit rolling off the edges as he moved. Within minutes, the dust arrived on the wall, gritty and warm, reducing visibility on the road to a few dozen metres. Then came the wind, hard and insistent.

The national Capital, which had been reeling under near heatwave conditions since morning, was swept by high-speed winds and dust late in the evening amid an ongoing yellow alert for thunderstorms and rain. The abrupt weather turn brought the first real sign of relief after days of relentless heat. Across the city, temperatures

remained similarly severe. The Ridge station logged the highest maximum at 43.8 degrees Celsius, while Ayanagar recorded 43.2 degrees Celsius. Lodhi Road touched 42.4 degrees, and Palam also settled at 42.3 degrees Celsius.

For a city that had been told all morning to brace for another scorching day, the evening shift felt like a release valve finally giving way. “We have been waiting for this since last week,” said Ramesh, who runs a tea stall near Barakhamba Road. “The heat had become unbearable. Even in the shade, it was difficult to breathe.”

A fruit vendor near India Gate, who had been sitting under a tree since midday, said the dust storm had scattered his arrangement, but he was not complaining. “Let it



A hazy view of the India Gate in New Delhi on Monday

PTI

come. Let it rain properly. We can deal with the rest.”

The IMD had said through the morning that a shift was coming, but placed it firmly on Tuesday. “Changing conditions will start bringing

relief from Tuesday,” the forecast read, with overcast skies and rain expected to pull the maximum down to between 40 and 42 degrees Celsius. By Wednesday, temperatures were forecast to ease further

to between 39 and 41 degrees, and an IMD official added that cloudiness would persist on Thursday, with the maximum potentially falling close to 37 degrees Celsius. Mahesh Palawat of Skymet

Heatwave pushes Delhi’s power demand past 7,000 MW mark

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi



On Saturday, it recorded a high of 42.8 degrees Celsius, 5.1 degrees above normal, making it the highest maximum temperature in April recorded in Delhi since 2022.

The BSES discoms are geared up to ensure reliable power supply to more than 53 lakh consumers and nearly 2.25 crore residents across south, west, east and central Delhi, the company official said.

These arrangements include long-term power purchase agreements, bilateral tie-ups, banking arrangements with other States and deployment of advanced technologies such as AI and Machine Learning-based demand forecasting, he said.

Around 2,670 MW of green power will play a key role in ensuring a reliable electricity supply during the summer months in the BSES areas, he said.

CM Rekha announces ORS in schools, rest for labourers amid heat wave

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

As the searing heat wave continues to singe the national Capital, Chief Minister Rekha Gupta on Monday announced a series of measures aimed at tackling it, including providing ORS solution in schools, and ensuring uninterrupted supply of power and water. She also asked the Labour Department to ensure that all outdoor labourers remain off work between 1 pm and 4 pm.

During a review meeting with all the departments, the chief minister directed the Department of Education to make arrangements for the ORS solution across schools in Delhi.

“All children will be given ORS solution before leaving school so that the heat does not affect them while walking back home,” she said.

The chief minister has also directed the transport department to carry drinking water inside a cool box on all DTC buses.

“Directions have been



given to ensure uninterrupted supply of power and water,” Gupta further said.

She added that the Delhi Government is fully prepared to tackle the heatwave this season and that arrangements are in place so that people do not face any problems. Rekha Gupta said that the Government is working with full preparedness at every level under the Heat Wave Action Plan. Clear guidelines have also been issued to all departments on this matter to ensure that people face minimal inconvenience during the severe heat.

While interacting with media persons, the Chief Minister particularly empha-

same time, it will also be the responsibility of employers to arrange water, shade, and other essential facilities for them.

The Chief Minister informed that all ministries have been directed to ensure that these guidelines reach people associated with their respective sectors and are implemented strictly.

The Municipal Corporation of Delhi and PWD have also been instructed to take special care of the health of sanitation workers and construction workers and to halt work during peak heat hours.

She said that health services are fully prepared. Adequate arrangements of medicines and essential facilities have been made in all hospitals to deal with any emergency situation.

The Chief Minister also informed that the fire, power, and water departments have been put on alert mode to ensure an uninterrupted supply of electricity and water across the city. All water resources will also be kept fully operational.

Delhi schools move games indoors as heatwave sears city

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi



To shield students from heat-related ailments amid soaring temperatures and harsh afternoon sun, schools across Delhi have begun taking precautionary measures by suspending outdoor activities, shifting assemblies indoors, and some even considering early closure for junior classes.

From indoor games and hydration breaks to ORS consumption and modified dispersal timings, schools are tightening measures as the city braces for prolonged heatwave conditions.

Sudha Acharya, principal at ITL Public School in Dwarka, said all outdoor activities, including morning assembly and games, have been shifted to the school's multipurpose hall.

“We have issued an advisory to all parents to take precautionary measures before sending their children to school. We are also planning to close the school

from classes 1 to 8 from May 14 onward if the weather conditions worsen,” she said.

Mallika Preman, principal at Tagore International School in East of Kailash, said students have been advised to remain indoors during peak afternoon hours and keep themselves hydrated.

“We have suspended all outdoor activities, and students now play indoor games like carrom and chess. We have also modified the dispersal system so that students are not brought out until their parents arrive at their designated collection areas,” Preman said.

MCD issues heatwave guidelines for 1,500 Delhi schools

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi



The Municipal Corporation of Delhi's (MCD) Education Committee on Monday issued strict guidelines for schools to deal with the rising heat and a possible heatwave in the national Capital, in line with measures taken by the Delhi Government.

MCD education committee chairman Yogesh Verma said the directions have been issued for all corporation-run and affiliated schools, keeping in view the increasing heat in the Capital and the possibility of a heatwave.

“On the lines of the Delhi Government, all necessary precaution-

ary steps are being taken in MCD schools with children's safety and health as the top priority. The decision has been taken considering the warning issued by the India Meteorological Department (IMD),” Verma said in a statement.

He added that instructions have been given to limit outdoor assemblies

in schools and to hold them in shaded or indoor spaces. A ban has also been imposed on holding classes in the open. To prevent dehydration among students, Verma said directions have been issued to implement a “water bell” system, under which students will be encouraged to drink water every 45-60 minutes.

Availability of clean and cool drinking water in schools will also be ensured, he added.

“Schools have been instructed to implement a ‘buddy system’ and encourage students to take care of each other. They have also been advised to keep students away from outdoor sports activities,” Verma said in the statement.

CM targets Kejriwal over remarks on judiciary, absence from court

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi



Delhi Chief Minister Rekha Gupta on Monday launched a sharp political attack on former chief minister Arvind Kejriwal, accusing him of trying to place himself above judicial scrutiny while misleading the public through what she described as a carefully staged political drama outside the courtroom.

In one of her strongest remarks yet against the Aam Aadmi Party chief, the Chief Minister said Kejriwal appears to function on the belief that his own word is final and unquestionable, regardless of what courts, constitutional institutions, or legal procedure may say. “He is behaving as if he is his own lawyer, his own witness, and his own judge. If everything has to be decided only by him, then what place remains for the judicial system?” the Chief Minister said while speaking to reporters in Delhi.

The remarks came in response to Kejriwal's recent

letter to a High Court judge and his public criticism surrounding court proceedings in a case in which a chargesheet has already been filed. The Chief Minister said repeatedly casting suspicion on judges and legal institutions has become part of Kejriwal's political method whenever proceedings do not appear to move in his favour.

She said avoiding personal appearance before the court while simultaneously launching allegations in public raises serious concerns about his intent. According to the Chief Minister, seeking a change of

judge or expressing apprehension over a possible verdict after the filing of a chargesheet cannot be brushed aside as a routine legal strategy. “It is inappropriate to run away from court proceedings and then question the judge in public. Such conduct weakens the dignity of the judiciary and sends a wrong message,” she said.

The CM's attack did not stop at the legal front. She also strongly criticised Kejriwal for invoking national icons such as Mahatma Gandhi and Bhagat Singh in his recent public positioning. Calling such comparisons

objectionable, she said political leaders facing legal scrutiny cannot cloak themselves in the moral language of freedom fighters in order to generate sympathy.

She said if a person believes he is innocent, the only legitimate forum to establish that innocence is the court, not a roadside protest or a media spectacle. “Sitting outside and calling it satyagraha is nothing but an attempt to confuse people. Noise outside cannot replace evidence inside a courtroom,” the Chief Minister said.

Her remarks suggest the Delhi Government intends to keep the pressure firmly on Kejriwal not only politically but also on the issue of legal accountability, an area where the BJP has repeatedly sought to corner the former chief minister.

In a separate but politically loaded comment, the Chief Minister also responded to questions on Rajya Sabha MP Raghav Chadha and other leaders who may align themselves differently in the future.

America's Fentanyl Game: Hypocrisy, Coercion and a Reckless Refusal to Look Inward

(India: Wake Up. You Are the Rising Superpower. America Will Not Forgive You for It.)

Over the past two years, the United States has intensified its diplomatic war on India over fentanyl precursors. This is not a public health initiative. It is the opening salvo of a larger geopolitical assault designed to cripple India's pharmaceutical industry and create a lever for future coercion. Currently, the Trump administration is desperate. Domestic failures are mounting. The midterm elections are approaching. And America — a declining empire addicted to blaming others for its own collapse — needs a villain. India has been cast in that role. Given Washington's long history of manufacturing threats — from Vietnam to Iraq to Libya — any Indian leader who does not see this as a warning shot is dangerously naive.

Let this be clear: America's fentanyl disaster is not made in India. It is made in American boardrooms that overprescribed opioids, porous borders that cartels cross daily, and politicians who refuse to fund rehabilitation while demanding that other nations solve their problems. Not a single American dies because of India. Americans die because America refuses to save itself.

India: Keep your eyes wide open. The United States has overthrown governments for far less. It has invaded countries on lies. To believe that America will treat India differently — a rising superpower that challenges its unipolar world—is suicide.

What India Has Already Done (And Why It Is Not Enough) To be fair, India is not starting from zero. The government has:

- Added 18 new precursor chemicals to controlled lists
- Introduced Unique Registration Numbers for chemical companies
- Secured the first-ever felony conviction of an Indian fentanyl precursor supplier in a U.S. court (Raxuter Chemicals, Surat)
- Conducted major enforcement operations in Telangana and Gujarat
- Diversified pharma exports to Africa, Latin America, and Southeast Asia
- Signed 46 bilateral agreements through BRICS, SCO, and UNODC

These are signs of preparation. **But preparation is not enough.** The United States is a predator that tests every wall for cracks. One regulatory lapse, one unprosecuted offender, one silent response to a U.S. accusation will be magnified into a casus belli. India has done much. It must do more.

Disclaimer: Publish by Hemant Kumar Dixit

What India Must Do Immediately

- 1. Tighten every regulatory gap.** The Raxuter Chemicals case proved mislabeled shipments evaded detection for years. Every export license, every customs inspection must be bulletproof.
- 2. Prosecute bad actors ruthlessly — and publicly.** Throw the book at every offender. Publicly. Swiftly. Deny America the moral high ground.
- 3. Stop apologizing. Start publishing.** Every U.S. accusation must be met with data. Publish enforcement records quarterly.

Force Washington to prove its claims.

- 4. Build alliances that exclude America aggressively.** Expand the 46 bilateral agreements. Create counter-narcotics platforms where American coercion has no seat.
- 5. Prepare for economic retaliation now.** Accelerate export diversification to Africa, Southeast Asia, and Latin America. Do not hold all your chips in America's casino.
- 6. Use the moral high ground ruthlessly.** India produces medicines for the world's poor. America produces addiction. Every time Washington points a finger, remind the world: Who is dying? Who refuses to treat its own citizens?

The Truth No One in Washington Will Say Aloud India is on the path to becoming a superpower. America knows this. And America will not like it.

The United States has spent seventy years ensuring no rival emerges. It destroyed the Soviet Union. It contained China. India is next — not because of fentanyl, but because of economics, demographics, and strategic autonomy. Fentanyl is just the excuse. The real war is over who shapes the 21st century.

Cooperation with the U.S. must be conditional, evidence-based, and always on India's terms. Every American demand must be met with: What will you give in return?

Final Warning

The United States refuses to look inward. Its fentanyl crisis will worsen. Its citizens will continue to die. Its credibility will crumble. None of that is India's problem — unless India allows itself to be dragged into America's death spiral.

India's job is not to save America from itself. India's job is to rise — prepared, vigilant, and unapologetic.

Let America play its blame game. India will regulate its own industries — not because Washington demands it, but because a superpower does not leave its flank exposed.

The unipolar moment is over. India will not be the next victim of American decline. It will be the architect of a new world.

IN FOCUS



A man rides a horse on a hot summer day at Versova Beach, in Mumbai, Maharashtra, on Monday

PTI

India to hold BRICS Entrepreneurs Alliance presidency

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Signaling India's rising prominence as a hub for entrepreneurship and innovation, Dr Bhaskar Jyoti Sonowal has been elected President of the BRICS Entrepreneurs Alliance (BEA) Global Forum for the 2026-27 term.

The appointment marks a significant milestone in India's growing leadership within the BRICS+ economic

ecosystem. Currently serving as CEO and Executive Director of BEA India, Dr Sonowal will lead the Alliance's global strategy at a crucial time, as India prepares to host the BEA Global Summit in November 2026. His leadership is expected to strengthen cross-border trade, foster global partnerships and create new opportunities for Indian entrepreneurs, particularly in the MSME sector.

High decibel campaign ends in West Bengal

Drawing a parallel with his spiritual experience before the consecration of Ram Lalla in Ayodhya in January 2024, Modi said he felt the same divine energy during the West Bengal campaign. "Today, canvassing ends. My last rally of this election campaign has also just concluded. Through this letter, I want to express my gratitude to every family member of West Bengal and also share my emotions," he said. The prime minister said the affection shown by people across age groups during rallies and road shows was the "real wealth" of his life.

During the high-octane campaign, the BJP leadership accused the ruling TMC of turning West Bengal into a haven for infiltrators, while Chief Minister Mamata Banerjee alleged that the BJP was indulging in divisive politics, attempting to bifurcate the State while demonising consumption of fish and eggs. The ECI has put in place extensive security arrangements, deploying 2,321 companies of central forces across seven districts.

Officials said drones fitted with cameras are also being used to monitor the poll process. Kolkata has the highest deployment with 273 companies of central forces. Among the constituencies going to the polls in this phase, Bhargar has the highest number of candidates at 19, while Goghat has the lowest with five, reflecting a varied electoral contest across districts. Key candidates in this phase include Chief Minister Mamata Banerjee, who is seeking re-election from Bhabanipur. She is pitted against BJP heavyweight Suvendu Adhikari in one of the most high-profile contests of the phase.

Modi described his outreach in the State as both spiritually uplifting and politically significant and expressed gratitude to the residents and Several BJP leaders, including Prime Minister Narendra Modi, Union Home Minister Amit Shah, Defence Minister Rajnath Singh and chief ministers of Uttarakhand and Assam campaigned in the state, attacking the TMC over alleged deterioration in law and order, rising crimes against women, political unrest, infiltration and corruption.

Mamata undertook a roadshow in south Kolkata spanning over six kilometres accompanied by party Rajya Sabha MP Sagorika Ghose and candidates Aroop Biswas and Debasish Kumar from Tollygunge and Rashbehari, respectively. TMC flags, festoons, cutouts of Banerjee and banners with slogans in favour of the candidates adorned the roadsides through which the road show passed and culminated at around 5.30 pm. While TMC Lok Sabha MP Abhishek Banerjee alleged that the BJP is distributing money in Assembly constituencies to mobilise support, and asked TMC cadres to accept it but work for his party.

On the last day in Hooghly district, Arambagh Lok Sabha MP Mitali Bag alleged that BJP workers vandalised her vehicle at Goghat while she was on her way to attend a rally of party leader Abhishek Banerjee. Bag claimed that she came under attack near a BJP office and suffered injuries from the shattered window-pane of her vehicle.

In another incident, a CISF jawan was injured in a firing outside the residence of BJP candidate Pawan Singh in the Bhatpara area of North 24 Parganas district late on Sunday night. The injured personnel, identified as Yogesh Sharma, sustained a bullet injury in his leg and was hospitalised. The poll panel has sought a report on the incident. Police said four people, including a TMC councillor, were arrested in connection with the incident.

armed and opened fire outside the venue but did not breach the secured event area.

Trump noted that one security officer was fired upon but escaped injury due to wearing a bulletproof vest. "They really got him," Trump said,

Board exam results: UP CM Yogi urges students to keep moving

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ Lucknow

Uttar Pradesh Chief Minister Yogi Adityanath on Monday wrote a letter to students who appeared for the state board examinations, encouraging them to persevere and keep progressing in life.

Sharing the letter on his official X account, he said the mantra "keep moving" inspires continuous effort and growth.

The chief minister congratulated students on the declaration of the class 10 and 12 results of the Uttar Pradesh Board — released on April 23 — and described this year's performance as "very encouraging".

"Many students have brought laurels to the state through their dedication and hard work. I extend my heartfelt congratulations and blessings to all students for a bright future," he said.

Adityanath said the letter



was particularly meant for those students who could not achieve the expected results, emphasising that success and failure are integral parts of life.

"Success motivates us, but failure can lead to disappointment. We must overcome this despair and move forward with the mantra of 'charai veti, charai veti' (keep moving)," he wrote.

He added that the principle of "keep moving" conveys the message of con-

tinuous effort, progress and never stopping in life.

The chief minister also reminded students that a single failure can pave the way for future success.

"No result is the first or the last in life; rather, it is an opportunity for a new beginning. Gold becomes pure only after being tested by fire," he said.

Citing examples of eminent personalities, he said Thomas Alva Edison conducted thousands of

unsuccessful experiments before inventing the electric bulb, ultimately illuminating the world through persistence.

He also referred to Srinivasa Ramanujan, one of the greatest mathematicians, and other distinguished figures who overcame obstacles and failures to reach the pinnacle in their respective fields.

In his message, Adityanath also appealed to parents to support their children, especially those who may not have secured desired results.

"Children are the future of the nation. If they do not achieve expected results for any reason, encourage them instead of becoming disheartened. Try to understand their interests," he said.

He added that there are numerous fields offering vast career opportunities and urged parents to help children identify such avenues and nurture their talents.

West Bengal polls: Delhi declares April 29 as paid holiday for eligible staff

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

The Delhi government's Labour Department has issued an office order declaring April 29 as a paid holiday for eligible employees to cast their votes in the West Bengal Assembly elections (Phase II). According to the

order, all employees across industrial establishments, factories, shops, and commercial institutions in the National Capital Territory of Delhi must grant a paid holiday to employees who are registered voters in the West Bengal elections.

"The Election Commission of India vide their communi-

cation dated March 16 has announced General Elections for Legislative Assemblies of West Bengal (Phase-II) to be held on April 29 (Wednesday) to be declared as "paid holiday" under section 135(B) of the Representation of the People Act, 1951," the order said.

"Accordingly, all



Employers of Industrial Establishments/Factories/Shops/Commercial Establishments/Institutions operating in the National Capital Territory of Delhi shall grant a paid holiday to their employees who are electors of General Legislative Assemblies Elections. 2026 of West

Bengal (Phase-II) to enable them to cast their vote on the day of polling i.e. April 29 (Wednesday), in case the scheduled day is a working day for the concerned Employees/Electors. Non-compliance of the above directions shall attract action as per the relevant provisions of law," it added.

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from LeT and Hizbul Mujahideen have been eliminated in various provinces, including Punjab, Sindh, Baluchistan and Khyber Pakhtunkhwa, as well as in Pakistan-occupied Kashmir.

Afridi, also referred as Maulana, was a prominent figure within LeT's operational structure in Khyber Pakhtunkhwa. He was widely regarded as a close aide to LeT Chief Hafiz Saeed. Intelligence sources describe him as a key operative who had been actively involved in the group's activities for years. He belonged to the Zakha Khel tribe and followed the Ahl-e-Hadith (Salafi) school of thought.

Khyber Pakhtunkhwa, formerly known as the North-West Frontier Province, shares a porous border with Afghanistan and has long served as a hotbed for militant groups, including the Taliban and Al-Qaeda affiliates. The province's rugged terrain and tribal dynamics have made it a strategic hub for LeT's recruitment, training and cross-border activities.

Just weeks earlier, Amir Hamza, a founding member of LeT and another close associate of Hafiz Saeed, was shot and critically injured in Lahore by unknown attackers. These incidents have reportedly created panic within terrorist ranks, with even previously secure strongholds now appearing vulnerable to such attacks.

Pakistani officials have remained largely silent on the specifics of Sunday's attack, with local media exercising caution in their coverage. As investigations continue, the killing of Sheikh Yusuf Afridi raises fresh questions about internal rivalries, ideological clashes between groups like LeT and ISIS or possible external operations aimed at disrupting terrorist networks. As of now, the precise circumstances and perpetrators remain shrouded in mystery, adding another layer to the complex and often opaque security landscape of Pakistan's border regions.

From textiles to technology: India-New...

He added that initiatives such as agricultural productivity partnerships and centres of excellence would combine New Zealand's expertise with India's priorities to boost rural development.

The prime minister also pointed to synergies with India's flagship Make in India programme, noting that the investment commitments and trade facilitation measures would support startups, innovation, and job creation.

Commerce Minister Goyal said the agreement is India's ninth trade deal in recent years with 38 developed countries, adding that it focuses on exports, agricultural productivity, student mobility, skills, investment, and services.

McClay described the FTA as a "high-quality" agreement that reduces trade friction, provides certainty, and establishes clear rules to help businesses expand and build long-term partnerships.

Negotiations for the agreement concluded in December 2025. The pact provides duty-free access across all tariff lines, covering product categories such as textiles, apparel, leather, footwear, gems and jewellery, engineering goods, and processed foods. It is also expected to boost MSMEs, enhance supply chain resilience, and generate employment by improving competitiveness in labour-intensive sectors.

Officials from both countries say the agreement represents a significant step toward a more integrated and resilient economic partnership, aimed at delivering shared growth and prosperity.

Iran offers US deal over Strait of Hormuz

It has also pressured his Gulf allies, which use the waterway to export their oil and gas. The closure has also had far-reaching effects throughout the world economy, raising the price of fer-

tilizer, food and other basic goods.

The proposal would push off negotiations on Iran's nuclear program to a later date. Trump said one of the major reasons he went to war was to deny Iran the ability to develop nuclear weapons.

The two officials, who had knowledge of the proposal, spoke on condition of anonymity to discuss the closed-door negotiations between Iranian and Pakistani officials this weekend.

Iranian Foreign Minister Abbas Araghchi met with Russian President Vladimir Putin on Monday in Saint Petersburg, Russian state news agency Tass said. Putin praised the Iranian people as "bravely and heroically fighting for their sovereignty," and said Russia would do everything possible to bring peace to the West Asia, Tass reported.

Araghchi said before the meeting in a video interview posted by Iran's state-run IRNA news agency that it was "a good opportunity for us to consult with our Russian friends about the developments that have occurred in relation to the war during this period and what is happening now."

The meeting came as Pakistan has been seeking to revive stalled talks between Iran and the US, and negotiations had been expected in Islamabad over the weekend. Instead, Trump called off a trip by his envoys and suggested the talks could take place by phone instead.

Over the weekend, Araghchi made two stops in Pakistan and a visit to Oman, which shares the strait with Iran. He also spoke by phone with counterparts in Qatar and Saudi Arabia on Sunday.

Iran wants to persuade Oman to support a mechanism to collect tolls from vessels passing through the strait, according to a regional official who spoke on condition of anonymity because he was not authorised to discuss the matter.

Oman's response wasn't immediately clear. The official, who is involved in mediation efforts, also said Iran insisted on ending the U.S. blockade before new talks and that Pakistan-led mediators are trying to bridge significant gaps between the countries.

ED raids ex Punjab DIG Bhullar in PMLA case

"This PMLA action stems from predicate offences registered by the Central Bureau of Investigation (CBI) and the Anti-Corruption Bureau (ACB), Chandigarh. The case centres on allegations that Bhullar, while posted as DIG, Ropar Range, demanded illegal gratification through a middleman to settle a criminal case. It also involves charges of amassing assets disproportionate to his known sources of income", ED sources said.

Bhullar was arrested by the CBI on October 16 last year, along with his alleged middleman, Krishanu Sharda, a former hockey player. The probe began after a complaint by a Fatehgarh Sahib-based scrap dealer, who alleged that Bhullar had demanded a bribe of 78 lakhs (initially 74 lakh plus monthly payments) through Sharda to close an FIR registered against the complainant's business at Sirhind police station in 2023.

A CBI team had caught Sharda accepting 75 lakhs on Bhullar's behalf. Subsequent searches at Bhullar's residence in Sector 40-B, Chandigarh and other linked properties yielded a massive haul: approximately 77.36 crore to 77.5 crore in cash, gold and silver jewellery worth around 72.32 crore, 26 luxury watches including high-end brands like Rolex and Rado, four firearms with over 100 live cartridges, documents related to more than 50 immovable properties, keys to luxury vehicles including Mercedes and Audi and other expensive assets.

Bhullar was later suspended from service. Subsequently, a special CBI court took cognisance of the case in March 2026 and ordered framing

India in talks with US, Iran over Chabahar Port future

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

With the United States' sanctions waiver for Iran's Chabahar Port expiring on April 26, India on Monday confirmed that discussions are ongoing with both Iran and the United States, noting that the evolving regional conflict has added complexity to the issue.

Ministry of External Affairs (MEA) spokesperson Randhir Jaiswal addressed the matter during an inter-ministerial briefing on the West Asia situation, stating that negotiations are actively underway.

"Regarding Chabahar and where we stand, the issue is under discussion with both Iran and the United States. The current conflict is also a complicating factor. We will keep you posted as the situation evolves," Jaiswal said in response to queries about the project's status following the waiver's expiration.

The Chabahar Port project is considered strategically sig-



nificant for India, as it provides a vital transit route for trade with Afghanistan and Central Asia, bypassing Pakistan. It has also been viewed as a key component in supporting Afghanistan's reconstruction and enhancing regional economic connectivity.

The backdrop to the current uncertainty dates to September 16, 2025, when the US State Department revoked a sanctions exception originally granted in 2018 under the Iran Freedom and Counter Proliferation Act, which had allowed India to develop the port for Afghanistan's economic benefit. The revocation became effective on September 29, 2025.

charges under relevant sections of the Bharatiya Nyaya Samhita (BNS) and the Prevention of Corruption Act. The ED had registered its PMLA case against Bhullar in November 2025 on the basis of the CBI's FIR and the disproportionate assets probe.

ED's operation marks a significant escalation in the investigation, focusing not only on Bhullar but also on his network of associates and property transactions allegedly used to launder proceeds of crime. ED sources indicated that teams are examining the management and dealings of immovable properties suspected to be linked to the former DIG, including premises associated with individuals like Krishanu Sharda in Nabha and others in Ludhiana and Patiala.

This case has drawn significant attention as one of the more high-profile cases of corruption, involving a senior Punjab Police officer in recent years, highlighting concerns over blatant misuse of power for personal gain and the laundering of the ill-gotten wealth through benami assets and property deals. The ED is expected to continue its scrutiny and more revelations are anticipated as the agency analyses documents and statements gathered during the raids. Bhullar and Sharda remain in judicial custody in connection with the original CBI case.

Shah declares 60-day CAPF presence after...

The road show turned the streets into a sea of orange, with supporters waving flags, carrying balloons and chanting Jai Shri Ram and Bharat Mata ki Jai. Shah waved from an open vehicle and showered flower petals on crowds.

Later, he addressed a similar rally in Chandannagar, Hooghly district. He claimed a strong pro-BJP wave and warned TMC workers, "Do not step out to intimidate voters on April 29. After May 4, the BJP will punish the culprits and hang them upside down". Shah accused Chief Minister Mamata Banerjee of shielding infiltrators for vote-bank politics and opposing the Special Intensive Revision (SIR) of electoral rolls. "Didi feels pain when we say infiltrators must be removed After May 4, all infiltrators will be identified and removed from Bengal," Shah thundered.

Shah said, "There has been no major incident of violence. Not a single death has taken place. The elections are being conducted peacefully." He said a BJP victory would transform the state into "Sonar Bangla" with restored law and order and good governance.

Shah's 60-day CAPF deployment aligns with and extends the Election Commission of India's (ECI) mandatory protocols for safeguarding election materials. Under the Representation of the People Act, 1951, election petitions can be filed within 45 days of result declaration. ECI directives require polled Electronic Voting Machines (EVMs), Voter Verifiable Paper Audit Trail (VVPAT) units, Symbol Loading Units and related records including CCTV footage to be preserved in secure strong rooms under District Election Officer custody for at least this 45-day period or until any petitions are disposed of. Strong rooms must maintain armed security, joint political party access protocols, CCTV monitoring and fire-safety measures. EVMs are categorised (polled units kept separately) and memory data cannot be erased during this window, as per Supreme Court directions and ECI compliance orders.

The extra 15 days of central forces provide a buffer for the sensitive post-poll transition, ensuring law and order while EVM integrity is legally protected. This proactive step by the Centre supports the ECI's mandate for free and fair elections regardless of the outcome. With campaigning ending on April 27, all eyes are on April 29's final phase and May 4, when the results will be announced.

NIA to probe crude bomb recovery in South 24 Parganas district

PRAMOD KUMAR SINGH
■ New Delhi/Kolkata

The National Investigation Agency (NIA) has taken control of the investigation into the sensational recovery of 79 crude bombs from the Bhangar area in the South 24 Parganas district.

The recoveries come barely 48 hours before polling on April 29, prompting the Election Commission to issue a 24-hour ultimatum to the State police for action against bomb-makers and to hand over all such cases to the NIA.

Acting on orders from the Union Ministry of Home Affairs (MHA), NIA registered a fresh case on April 26, taking over the original FIR No. 62/2026 filed at Uttar Kashipur Police Station. As of now, no arrests have been made in the primary RC-25 case, but the probe is focusing on sourcing of explosives, possible terror links and conspirators.

The seizures of crude bombs occurred on April 25, when a police team from North Kashipur police station, acting on specific intelligence, raided an abandoned house near a burial ground at Poilepara under the Bhangar



Division. The police team recovered 79 round-shaped objects, each tied with jute ropes and suspected to be crude bombs, along with other bomb-making materials.

The MHA described the storage as a direct threat to human lives and property, explicitly noting the intent to create fear and terror in the minds of the people. Officials believe the case qualifies as a Scheduled Offence under the National Investigation Agency Act, 2008 and could involve a larger conspiracy with implications for national security.

The Bhangar area is notorious for political violence and crude-bomb usage. Trinamool Congress candi-

date Saokat Molla is locked in a fierce contest with ISF chief Nawsad Siddique, with the seat having flipped to the Opposition in 2021.

Tensions rose further in the areas on April 26 as an additional 100 crude bombs were found in the same Uttar Kashipur-Chelegoalia belt, allegedly linked to a house belonging to a TMC worker. NIA has arrested Ahidul Islam Molla, also referred to as Wahidul Islam Molla, a key accused in a March 2026 explosion in nearby West Bamunia village.

That blast, which occurred while crude bombs were being assembled, killed one person and injured three, including a TMC booth presi-

dent. Molla, who had been absconding, was assaulted by locals upon his sudden return and handed over to the police. Investigators now plan to question him in the fresh Bhangar case as well.

The NIA's swift intervention underscores the MHA's assessment that the Bhangar haul is not mere local law-and-order problem but potentially part of a wider network aimed at destabilising the polls.

Central forces are already deployed across the region for security. Bhangar's history of recurring clashes between ruling-party workers and Opposition factions has turned the area into a tinderbox during every election cycle.

This latest episode has only heightened fears of violence as voters head to the booths to cast their votes on April 29.

The NIA is expected to file its first status report in court soon. with officials emphasising a zero-tolerance approach to poll-related explosives. For residents of Bhangar, the message is clear that the Centre is watching, and the era of unchecked crude-bomb politics may not be allowed anymore.

BJP slams Congress MLA for ‘justifying’ attack on Trump



BJP spokesperson Shehzad Poonawalla

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

The BJP on Monday demanded that Congress leader Rahul Gandhi condemn his party MLA Vijay Wadettiwar's remarks, alleging the legislator justified the shooting at an event attended by US President Donald Trump in Washington and was "praying for a similar attack" on Prime Minister Narendra Modi.

In a video shared by the ruling party, the Maharashtra MLA purportedly says, "As you sow, so shall you reap. Whatever one does, one has to face the consequences," while alleging that Trump, during his tenure in the highest office, has sought to dominate other countries and has "disturbed" global peace. He allegedly went on to add that a "similar sentiment" exists in India.

Posting a video clip of Wadettiwar's remarks, BJP spokesperson Shehzad Poonawalla alleged that the Congress has gone beyond political criticism and has endorsed the attack.

"In opposing Prime Minister Narendra Modi, the Congress party is now going against the country. Vijay Wadettiwar has justified the shooting attempt on Trump and said that a similar sentiment exists in India. In a way, he is hoping that such an incident happens here too," he said

in a video post on social media. Poonawalla also accused the MLA of making controversial remarks earlier, including on "Operation Sindoor", and allegedly giving a clean chit to Pakistani terrorists in the 26/11 attacks. "He has now gone beyond and made the most obnoxious comment," he said.

The BJP spokesperson accused the Congress leaders, including its president Mallikaarjun Kharge, of repeatedly using abusive language against Prime Minister Modi, saying such statements reflect a "dangerous and irresponsible mindset". "You can hate the BJP, but why would you want such things to happen in this country? And why would you pray or hope for it? "They have abused the prime minister over 150 times and issued threats against him. And now they have stooped to this. Only because they oppose the BJP, they would even justify such incidents involving someone holding a constitutional position," he said.

In another post, he also referred to alleged remarks by Kharge in which he described the BJP and the RSS as "poisonous snakes" that must be finished and called Modi a "terrorist".

Demanding an apology, Poonawalla said this reflects the "true face" of the Congress and amounts to an insult to the Constitution.

Nation Focus



JULY 31 DEADLINE FOR PADMA AWARDS 2027 NOMINATIONS

Citizens can file nominations and recommendations for the Padma Awards to be announced on Republic Day, 2027, by July 31 this year, a Government statement said Monday. The suggestions will only be received online on the Rashtriya Puraskar Portal (<https://awards.gov.in>), it said. The civilian honours - Padma Vibhushan, Padma Bhushan and Padma Shri - are amongst the highest awards of the country. Instituted in 1954, the civilian honours are announced on the Republic Day every year. "The awards seek to recognise 'work of distinction' and are given for distinguished and exceptional achievements/service in all fields/disciplines, such as Art, Literature and Education, Sports, Medicine, Social Work, Science and Engineering, Public Affairs, Civil Service, Trade and Industry, etc.," the statement said.



NITI AAYOG MEMBER GOBARDHAN DAS MEETS PM

Newly-appointed full-time member of the Niti Aayog, Gobardhan Das, on Monday met Prime Minister Narendra Modi, who said every struggle the scientist faced only strengthened his commitment to serve society and make it free from suffering. On April 24, the Government reconstituted the Niti Aayog, appointing former chief economic advisor Ashok Kumar Lahiri as vice chairman and five full-time members, including Das.

"Met Professor Gobardhan Das Ji this morning. His personal life journey is very inspiring. Every struggle he faced only strengthened his commitment to serve society and make it free from suffering. This has been reflected in his contribution to public health and immunology.

Rajnath to attend SCO meeting in Kyrgyzstan

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

In the backdrop of the ongoing West Asia conflict, Defence Minister Rajnath Singh will lead a high-level Indian delegation to the Shanghai Cooperation Organisation (SCO) Defence Ministers' Meeting to be held in Bishkek, Kyrgyzstan, on Tuesday, the defence ministry said on Monday.

The SCO is an intergovern-



mental organisation established on June 15, 2001, in Shanghai, China. Its membership includes India, Russia, China, Kazakhstan,

Kyrgyzstan, Pakistan, Tajikistan, Uzbekistan, Iran and Belarus. India became a full member in 2017 and assumed the rotating chairmanship in 2023.

Giving details about the schedule, officials said during the meeting, the Defence Ministers of various member countries will deliberate upon a number of issues concerning the defence and security of the region. Issues related to international

peace, counter-terrorism and defence cooperation among SCO member states will also be discussed.

This year's SCO meeting is taking place against the backdrop of geopolitical turmoil being witnessed due to the situation in West Asia. The SCO, one of the largest political and economic organisations of the region, may discuss measures to reduce the impact of the ongoing conflict.

PM Modi leads mega roadshow in Gangtok

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Gangtok

Prime Minister Narendra Modi led a mega roadshow in Gangtok on Monday evening after arriving in Sikkim to attend the closing ceremony of the 50 years of statehood celebrations.

Modi, who wore a traditional Bhutia cap and a Lepcha coat, was received at the Libing helipad by Governor Om Prakash Mathur and Chief Minister Prem Singh Tamang.

From the helipad, the PM began the roadshow, which concluded at Lok Bhavan, where he will stay overnight. On the open vehicle, Modi was flanked by CM Tamang on his left and State BJP president DR Thapa on his right.

Large crowds lined the roads for hours, waving national flags and waiting to catch a glimpse of the Prime Minister. As his convoy moved slowly through the city, people broke into celebrations. Some enthusiastic supporters chanted "Modi, Modi, Modi", while a few women were seen showering flower petals in his direction. Modi acknowledged the cheering crowds by waving continuously.

Tamang was also seen urging the gathered people to cheer for the PM during the roadshow.

The route of the roadshow was decorated, with arch gates erected at several points and large cut-outs of Modi placed along the roads. On Tuesday, Modi will visit the Orchidarium in



Gangtok. To commemorate the golden jubilee of Sikkim's statehood and showcase the State's ecological and floral heritage, the "Swarnajayanti Maitri Manjari" Park has been developed as a world-class Orchid Experience Centre.

The PM will also participate in the closing ceremony of Sikkim's 50th statehood celebrations at Paljor Stadium, where he will unveil development projects worth over Rs 4,000 crore. The projects cover several sectors, including infrastructure, connectivity, healthcare, education, power, urban development, environment, tourism and agriculture. Modi is also scheduled to address the gathering on the occasion.

He was expected to attend the opening ceremony of the year-long celebrations last year, but could not reach the venue due to inclement weather.

However, he addressed the event virtually from Siliguri in neighbouring West Bengal. "With immense fervour and heartfelt enthusiasm, the people of Sikkim accorded a grand and resounding welcome to PM on his arrival in Gangtok," he said in a social media post.

Ladakh gets 5 new districts; total count rises to seven

MOHIT KANDHARI ■ Jammu

Winning the hearts and minds of the people of Ladakh, aspiring for good governance, Lieutenant Governor of Ladakh, Vinai Kumar Saxena, on Monday approved the issuance of a notification to create five new districts in the Union Territory ahead of the visit of Union Home Minister Amit Shah on April 30.

With this, the cold desert region of Ladakh will now have a total of seven districts. Kargil district will emerge as the biggest administrative unit with 80 revenue villages, followed by Leh with 44 revenue villages, after redrawing the territorial boundaries of the new districts.

The Ministry of Home Affairs,

Government of India, had earlier approved the formation of five new districts on 26 August 2024.

Ladakh currently has only two districts, Leh and Kargil, each managed by its autonomous district council.

Lieutenant Governor, Saxena, described the move as "historic", saying this would usher in a new era of inclusive development in the Union Territory by ensuring an effective and efficient delivery of services at the doorsteps. "This transformative decision underscores the Government of India's commitment to unlocking Ladakh's immense potential and ensuring balanced, inclusive, and sustainable development across the Union Territory," Saxena said.

As per the notification, three dis-



Vinai Kumar Saxena

tricts, namely, Nubra (Headquarters: Diskit), Sham (Headquarters: Khaltsel), and Changthang

(Headquarters: Nyoma) have been carved out from Leh district, while two districts - Zaskar (Headquarters: Padum) and Drass (Headquarters: Drass-Ranbirpura) have been carved out from Kargil district.

The new districts will take the benefits meant for the people to their doorsteps by bolstering governance in every nook and cranny. The creation of five additional districts will decentralise governance, reduce travel distances for citizens (often exceeding 300 km), and ensure faster and more effective delivery of public services.

Importantly, the creation of new districts is also expected to generate significant employment opportunities through the establishment

of new administrative offices, supporting infrastructure, and allied services. This will further boost local employment, skill development, entrepreneurship and economic opportunities.

The move, the Lieutenant Governor said, was aligned with Prime Minister Narendra Modi's dream of a developed and prosperous Ladakh, which was envisioned with the inception of Ladakh as a Union Territory in 2019.

Following the notification, the territorial limits of the seven districts have been defined. Now, the Leh district will have 44 revenue villages, Nubra 30, and Changthang 24. Similarly, Kargil district will have 80 revenue villages, Sham district 27, Zaskar 26, and Drass 19.

HC quashes PSA against AAP MLA

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Jammu

The High Court of Jammu and Kashmir and Ladakh on Monday quashed the Public Safety Act (PSA) against Aam Aadmi Party (AAP) legislator Mehraj Malik, a party spokesperson said.

Malik, who is the AAP's Jammu and Kashmir unit president, was detained under the stringent PSA on September 8 last year for allegedly disturbing public order and was subsequently lodged in the Kathua jail.

Outspoken Aam Aadmi Party MLA from Doda (East) earned the rare distinction of becoming the first sitting MLA who was detained under the PSA, an administrative law that allows detention without charge or trial for up to two years in some cases.

On September 24, he filed a habeas corpus petition in



Mehraj Malik

the high court, challenging his detention and seeking Rs 5 crore as compensation.

On February 23, the high court had reserved its order in the case. "The court pronounced its judgment in Mehraj Malik's case. His PSA has been quashed, and it bolsters our faith in the judiciary," AAP spokesperson Appu Singh Slathia told reporters after the hearing. Slathia was part of Malik's legal team.

Malik was detained after he launched a hate campaign

against the Deputy Commissioner Doda Harvinder Singh. The verbal brawl between the two started after the Deputy Commissioner turned down one of his recommendations over the issue of shifting a health sub-centre. Several clips of Mehraj Malik abusing the Deputy Commissioner, Doda, went viral on various social media platforms, following which an FIR was registered against AAP MLA.

The district authorities had claimed Malik was trying to influence the administration and resorting to theatrics to allow the sub centre to function in a building built by one of his supporters on State land and pay him the monthly rent. In the 2024 Jammu and Kashmir Assembly polls, Malik won the Doda seat by over 4,500 votes, securing AAP's first-ever victory in the Union territory.

towards social welfare and women's empowerment, the NCW said in a statement.

He also assured the commission that his future artist agreements would include mandatory legal due diligence provisions to ensure dignified and appropriate representation of women and children in films and related creative projects.

Sanjay Dutt apologises to NCW over song row

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Actor Sanjay Dutt on Monday appeared before the National Commission for Women (NCW) in connection with the controversy over the song 'Sarke Chunar Teri Sarke' and submitted a written apology, expressing regret for any "unintended" harm caused to society. During the hearing,

held under NCW chairperson Vijaya Rahatkar, the commission raised concerns over alleged vulgarity and indecent representation of women in the song from the movie "KD The Devil" and questioned issues of intent, awareness and accountability.

The chairperson emphasised whether adequate due diligence was undertaken before participating in



content that could be perceived as promoting objectification of women, while also underlining the responsibility of senior and influential public figures in ensuring that their work remains within the bounds of legal and societal standards.

As a corrective measure, Dutt committed to sponsoring the education of 50 tribal girl children as part of efforts

States Focus



TELANGANA SEEKS CBI PROBE INTO KALESHWARAM PROJECT

Telangana CM A Revanth Reddy on Monday suggested that the ministers meet the CBI Director, if required, to facilitate a probe by the investigating agency into the alleged irregularities in the Kaleshwaram project executed during the previous BRS regime. Reddy held a meeting with Irrigation Minister N Uttam Kumar Reddy and officials to discuss the Government's next course of action in the wake of the High Court direction restraining action against former CM K Chandrasekhar Rao and others based on the findings of the PC Ghose Commission. The State Government has decided to step up efforts to initiate a CBI probe into the alleged irregularities in the Kaleshwaram project.



STALIN INTERACTS WITH TOURISTS IN KODAIKANAL AHEAD OF RESULTS

Tamil Nadu Chief Minister MK Stalin on Monday interacted with people and tourists at Kodaikanal regarding the prospects of DMK in the just concluded Assembly polls. Stalin is on a brief trip to Kodaikanal with his family after the elections ended on April 23. During his morning walk at Manoranjitha Reservoir, he posed for photographs and selfies with the public waiting along the road. The DMK chief is also likely to meet senior party leaders to enquire about measures taken with regard to the appointment of counting agents, party sources said. The DMK contested in 164 seats. Eleven alliance party candidates, including those from Vaiko-led MDMK, contested on the ruling party's Rising Sun symbol, effectively making it 175 constituencies for the party.

Mamata ends West Bengal poll campaign with 6 km roadshow

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Kolkata

Chief Minister Mamata Banerjee undertook a roadshow in south Kolkata spanning over six kilometres on Monday afternoon at the fag end of campaigning for the second and final phase of the West Bengal Assembly election. The TMC chief was accompanied by party Rajya Sabha MP Sagarika Ghose and candidates Aroop Biswas and Debasish Kumar from Tollygunge and Rashbehari, respectively. People waiting on the roadside and on rooftops and balconies waved at Banerjee as she greeted them with folded hands, walking briskly, as her party compatriots had a tough time keeping pace with her.

The chief minister is contesting from the Bhabanipur Assembly seat, where she is pitted against her bete noire, Suvendu Adhikari of the BJP, who defeated her in the 2021



West Bengal CM and Trinamool Congress supremo Mamata Banerjee with party leaders and workers during a roadshow in Kolkata on Monday PTI

elections in Nandigram.

Banerjee was subsequently elected from Bhabanipur in a byelection.

The roadshow started at Sukanta Setu in the Jadavpur area and culminated at Gopalnagar crossing, past her Kalighat residence, with two small stopovers in between. TMC flags, festoons, cutouts of Banerjee

and banners with slogans in favour of the candidates adorned the roadsides through which the road show passed and culminated at around 5.30 pm.

A large number of TMC supporters participated in the roadshow that Banerjee conducted to end her campaign for the 2026 Assembly election in West Bengal.

Tamil Nadu polls: Women voters outshine men with 86.2% turnout

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Chennai

Women voters outnumbered their male counterparts in exercising their franchise on April 23, with over 2.52 crore women, constituting nearly 86.2 per cent of the total female electorate in Tamil Nadu, enthusiastically casting their votes.

The male electorate that voted accounted for 2.35 crore, which was 83.96 per cent of the total male electorate in the state, an official said on Monday.

Tamil Nadu saw an impressive voter turnout, with over



4.87 crore electors casting their votes across all 234 Assembly constituencies in the State. This included 4,517 third-gender voters, who re-

resented 58.44 per cent of the registered third-gender electorate. The state recorded an estimated overall turnout of 85.1 per cent. Tamil Nadu has an electorate strength of 5.73 crore, comprising 2.93 crore women, 2.83 crore men, and 7,728 third-gender persons. It also included 14.59 lakh first-time voters. A total of 4,023 candidates, including a large number of independents, contested from the 234 constituencies.

About 24.22 lakh votes were polled in Chennai district, which has 16 Assembly constituencies. The counting of votes is scheduled for May 4.

TMC MP claims BJP vandalised car; saffron party dismisses allegations

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Kolkata

TMC MP from Arambagh Mitali Bag on Monday alleged that BJP's 'goons' vandalised her car at Goghat in West Bengal's Hooghly district when she was going to attend a rally of party general secretary Abhishek Banerjee on the last day of campaigning.

The BJP, however, rejected the charge and claimed that Bag was staging a "drama" and that TMC workers had actually attacked saffron party supporters.

An Election Commission official said a report has been sought on the alleged incident, and central forces were camping at the spot.

In a Facebook Live video, a visibly shaken Bag alleged that her vehicle was attacked near the BJP candidate's election office.

"When my vehicle was passing by the election office of BJP candidate Prashanta Digar, saffron party-backed miscreants threw stones at our vehicle, smashing its windshield," she claimed.

Referring to herself as a Dalit woman, Bag said, "I was on my way to the meeting of Abhishek Banerjee when some lathi-wielding BJP workers sitting in front of the office of party candidate Prashanta Digar blocked the way and threw stones at our vehicle."

She claims that she was seated in the front seat of the MUV while party workers were in the rear.

Appealing to the Election Commission to act on her complaint, she said, "The BJP talks high about the safety of women, but see how they treat a woman MP, a Dalit woman from the Bagdi community. CEO Manoj Agarwal, in a recent



visit, alleged that TMC workers are terrorising people in the area. But Agarwal, please check the facts."

Claiming she was covered with broken glass shreds, Bag said she went to the local health centre and was wheeled inside by the medical staff.

The TMC shared her video on its social media page, saying, "The attack on a woman Dalit MP by BJP goons shows the true nature of the fascist party."

Speaking at a rally in Nadia district, Abhishek Banerjee said, "Our MP Mitali Bag, an elected female representative from the Scheduled Caste community, was brutally and dastardly attacked by BJP lumpens and thugs. Her car was vandalised. Shards of glass pierced her body."

"TMC will not take this lying down, and the people of Bengal will respond to the attack through the votes.

After May 4, we will find every attacker and take appropriate action," Banerjee said. An official from the CEO's office said, "We have sought CCTV footage. We are also checking the Facebook Live done by the MP." BJP spokesperson Debjit Sarkar claimed there was no attack on Bag by saffron party sup-

porters, and instead, TMC workers charged towards BJP supporters in the office and injured several of them. "To divert attention, Bag is now staging a drama," Sarkar said.

The former BJP president of the Arambagh unit, Biman Ghosh, too, alleged that BJP workers were attacked during a campaign in support of party candidate Prashant Digar.

"While campaigning was underway, some miscreants led by Goghat Trinamool leader Sanjay Khan attacked our workers with sticks, bricks, rods and firearms. Nearly 50 people have been injured, and 20 were admitted to a hospital. Our candidate's vehicle was also vandalised. Bag is staging a drama to suppress the incident," Ghosh claimed.

Khan dismissed the allegations and claimed that the BJP workers entered the locality and started hurling bombs targeting residents, who belong to a minority community. The TMC, in an official statement, said the threat by Union Home Minister Amit Shah to "our leaders and party workers that anyone who steps out of their house would be hung upside down was acted upon today," TMC said.

Count all VVPAT slips in Kozhikode: DCC chief to ECI

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Kozhikode (Kerala)

Kozhikode District Congress Committee (DCC) president K Praveen Kumar on Monday demanded that all VVPAT slips in the district be counted, alleging attempts to tamper with the election process.

The demand comes amid the Congress's recent allegation that the strongroom where EVMs of the Perambra constituency were stored had been opened by the returning officer, a claim denied by the



Election Commission of India (ECI) and the district administration. The election for 140 Assembly seats was held on April 9, and the vote count will be held on May 4.

"We suspect there is an attempt to tamper with the election process in Kozhikode district. So, we have submitted a petition to the Election

Commission seeking the counting of all VVPAT slips in the district," Kumar said.

Kumar alleged that despite filing a complaint against the returning officer, no action had been taken so far.

"The district collector is protecting the officer who violated the rules. We have been trying to meet him for two days, but no appointment was given," he said.

Earlier, the Congress and the UDF had alleged that the strongroom at JDT College, where EVMs of the Perambra constituency were stored,

had been opened by the returning officer.

They alleged that the entry of any State official or State police personnel into the designated area amounts to a violation of Election Commission rules.

However, the returning officer, in a statement, said that an unsealed room where polling records for the Perambra constituency were kept was opened in the presence of polling agents of the candidates to update election-related information in the software.

Chandy raises concerns over EVMs in Kottayam

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Kottayam (Kerala)

Congress leader Chandy Oommen on Monday raised concerns over EVMs from two Assembly constituencies being stored in a single hall in Kottayam. Speaking to reporters, Chandy said that a complaint had been submitted by his election agent to the Election Commission in this regard.

"The counting of EVMs will be held in one hall. I do not believe there is any need to keep EVMs of both constituencies in the same hall. There is another hall and EVMs of one constituency could have been kept there," he said.



Chandy said that the EVMs of the Puthuppally constituency, from where he contested, were being stored along with those of the Changanassery con-

stituency. He said that even with air-conditioners installed, there were concerns about the condition of the EVMs given the intense summer heat across Kerala. "I will comment about it after May 4 when the election result is announced," he said, indicating that he would elaborate further after the results.

He refused to comment on the debate over the Congress chief ministerial candidate, stating that such discussions had been put to rest by the Kerala Pradesh Congress Committee.

He said that there was nothing wrong with Congress workers highlighting certain leaders. "There is nothing wrong with it. We have several leaders in our party," he said.

AICC to decide CM, no internal rift, claims KPCC president

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Kannur (Kerala)

Kerala Pradesh Congress Committee (KPCC) president Sunny Joseph said on Monday that there is no internal debate in the Congress in Kerala over the chief ministerial candidate, and that the decision will be made by the AICC.

Speaking to reporters, Joseph said he was grateful that people believed there would be a Congress chief minister in the State after the election results are announced.

The Assembly election for the 140 constituencies was held on April 9, and the results will be declared on May 4. "There is a proper method in Congress for selecting the CM. After the election results are announced, the AICC will make a decision and present it to the public. It will then be approved by the Congress workers and the public," he said.

His comments came at a time when various leaders have expressed support for VD Satheesan, Ramesh Chennithala, and KC Venugopal as potential chief ministerial candidates if the UDF comes to power.

Senior Congress leader VM Sudheeran said the debate over the chief ministerial candidate is irrelevant at this time.

"This is not the first time Congress is poised to win an election and come to power.



The party has a traditional method of selecting the Chief Minister. According to this process, opinions from the state unit will be considered and evaluated by the party high command, after which a decision will be made," he said. Meanwhile, K Muraleedharan, who contested the election from the Vattiyoor kavu seat in Thiruvananthapuram, said he was not interested in such debates.

Asked about promotional campaigns by some Congress leaders aimed at drawing the attention of the party high command, Muraleedharan said he viewed them as efforts to keep people entertained.

"During this lull, people should shake off the dull mood. With no fireworks at Thrissur Pooram this time, some may have chosen to create a few 'fireworks' of their own-but they won't cross the line," he said.

Jobs and agriculture crisis: Key factors in Katwa's TMC-BJP battle

SUPRATIK SENGUPTA ■ Kolkata

Katwa in West Bengal's Purba Bardhaman district has emerged as a keenly watched Assembly constituency, with a direct contest likely between TMC and BJP as agrarian distress and the youth's aspirations drive the poll discourse in the predominantly rural seat.

Katwa, an unreserved seat, is one of the seven Assembly segments under the Bardhaman Purba Lok Sabha constituency. It has a predominantly rural character, with around 65.40 per cent of voters residing in villages and 34.60 per cent in urban centres. The electorate is socially mixed, with Scheduled Castes accounting for about 27.41 per cent and



Muslims around 21.80 per cent of the population.

Historically, the constituency was considered a Left stronghold. The CPI won the seat twice, while the CPI(M) secured it six times.

The Congress also had a significant presence, particularly under veteran leader Rabindranath Chatterjee, who won the seat in 1996 and went on to retain it consecutively. Chatterjee

later joined the TMC in 2016 and has continued his winning streak, securing victories in both the 2016 and 2021 Assembly elections as a TMC candidate.

The 2016 election witnessed a close contest, with Chatterjee defeating Congress candidate Shyama Majumdar by only 911 votes. In 2021, Majumdar, then contesting on a BJP ticket, lost to Chatterjee by 9,155 votes. (PTI)

AIADMK alleges DMK malpractices in TN polls; seeks ECI action

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Chennai

AIADMK leader IS Inbadurai on Monday alleged that the ruling DMK was involved in "electoral malpractices" in several constituencies during the Assembly polls held on April 23 and urged the Election Commission of India (ECI) to take action.

Alleging that the DMK has "distributed money to bribe the voters," the AIADMK leader, who is also a Rajya Sabha MP, claimed that in

Coimbatore and Karur, "several malpractices" were done by the DMK.

"In Coimbatore South constituency, DMK candidate had distributed gold coins to the voters", he alleged.

Stating that the AIADMK had already lodged a complaint with the ECI against alleged malpractices by the DMK, he demanded that the ECI take action. Asserting that his party will win polls and form the Government, Inbadurai expressed confidence that AIADMK chief



Edappadi K Palaniswami will be the next chief minister.

He said the people of Tamil Nadu wanted "change of Government," and added that the "AIADMK is the only saviour" of the people.

He praised late chief minister J Jayalalithaa as an "unmatched leader in Indian political history." She achieved so much during her tenure, and those accomplishments benefited women and their empowerment. She introduced 50 per cent reservation for women

in local bodies and set up all-women police stations.

The Tamil Nadu Assembly is 234-member strong. Vote counting is set to take place on May 4, and the result will be known the same day.

V Senthil Balaji is the DMK candidate in the Coimbatore South segment.

The DMK has put up a big fight to retain power, and its archival AIADMK has similarly shown determination to bounce back and form the Government after being in Opposition for 5 years.



Visva Bharati teachers flag stressful poll duty to VC

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ Kolkata

Teachers of West Bengal's Visva Bharati University have written to Vice Chancellor Probr Kumar Ghosh over "extremely stressful" poll-related duties, seeking immediate intervention of the Election Commission of India (ECI).

In a letter dated April 26, several faculty members of the central university said they were under "extreme mental and physical stress" due to continuous deployment for poll-related work across districts.

The first phase of elections to the 294-member West Bengal Assembly was held on April 23, while the second phase will take place on April 29. Votes will be counted on May 4. "We are constrained to draw your urgent attention," the teachers said in the letter, noting that many of them had been assigned duties in different parts of the South 24 Parganas district and asked to report by April 28 morning, barely a day after completing assignments in Birbhum.

"Some have to travel as far as Sagar Island.

Given the limited transport options and very short notice, it will be extremely difficult to reach on time," it stated.

The faculty members pointed out that even on April 26, they were attending training sessions for counting day observers, leaving them little time to rest before their next deployment.

"At this time of the year, this is extremely stressful on health. This is also severely affecting our primary responsibility - teaching," they said.

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Order Order

Delhi HC protects actor Allu Arjun's personality rights



The Delhi High Court has protected the personality rights of Telugu actor Allu Arjun and restrained the unauthorised use of his name, voice and likeness by several entities for commercial use and impersonation.

In an interim order passed on April 17 on a lawsuit by the "Pushpa" star, Justice Tushar Rao Gedela said Arjun has a "stellar career" and that his highly popular dialogues and other distinctive attributes demonstrated his "iconic status".

It further said that unique and distinctive attributes, like name, appearance and voice, clearly constituted copyrights of the actor, over which he has exclusive rights of exploitation, and he would suffer an irreparable loss and injury if an interim relief was not granted.

The court also noted that Arjun has various trademark registrations of his name, abbreviations, etc.

"Defendant...are restrained from violating the plaintiff's personality/publicity rights by utilising and/or in any manner directly and/or indirectly, using or exploiting or misappropriating the Plaintiffs (a) name "Allu Arjun"; (b) image and likeness; and (c) any other attributes of the plaintiff which are exclusively identifiable with him for any commercial and/or personal gain and/or otherwise by exploiting them in any manner whatsoever without the plaintiff's consent and/or authorisation, through the use of any technology including but not limited to Artificial Intelligence, Generative Artificial Intelligence, Machine Learning, Deepfakes, Face Morphing and on any mediums and formats including but not limited to physical medium, the virtual medium such as websites, metaverse, social media, etc," the court ordered.

SC takes note of brutal assault on woman advocate, issues interim directions

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

The Supreme Court on Monday took note of the brutal assault on a woman advocate allegedly by her husband and directed the Delhi Police commissioner to hand over the probe to a senior officer, preferably a woman officer in the rank of assistant or deputy commissioner of police.

A bench of Chief Justice Surya Kant and Justice Joymalya Bagchi took suomotu cognisance after advocate Sneha Kalita wrote a letter to the CJI seeking urgent intervention and also for grant of compensation under the National Legal Services Authority (NALSA) victim compensation scheme. The top court asked the investigating officer to look into the aspect of three hospitals refusing admission to the victim.

According to the allegations, the victim, who is a practising advocate at the Karkardooma district courts here, was brutally assaulted



with a sword and was stabbed by her husband at Sonia Vihar on April 22.

The bench was hearing a suomotu case titled 'In Re: Brutal assault on a member of the legal fraternity and need for judicial intervention'. During the hearing, Kalita told the bench that after the assault, the victim somehow managed to call her family and the PCR.

Additional Solicitor General Aishwarya Bhati,

appearing for the NCT of Delhi, told the bench that an FIR was registered and the husband, alleged to be the prime accused, was arrested on the intervening night of April 25-26. "Please find out why the hospitals denied emergency treatment to the victim," the CJI told Bhati, after it was claimed that three hospitals refused admission to the victim who was later admitted to the AIIMS Trauma Centre.

The bench noted that the letter addressed by Kalita was received in the CJI's office on Sunday.

Referring to the right of a suspect or an accused to have a fair investigation and also to ensure that no one should go scot free, the bench passed a slew of interim directions in the matter.

"The Commissioner of Police, Delhi, is directed to hand over the investigation

to a fairly senior officer and preferably a woman officer in the rank of assistant/deputy commissioner of police," it said. The bench said in the complaint, there were allegations against the in-laws of the victim and they were stated to be absconding.

It also noted the victim has three minor daughters.

The bench said Kalita has informed it that after the assault, the in-laws of the victim took away her two minor daughters aged four years and one year along with them and their whereabouts was unknown.

It noted that eldest daughter was aged 12 years and was allegedly abandoned at night outside the house by the husband and she was later on recovered by the police.

The bench said the police would find out the whereabouts of the two minor girl children.

It said the custody of the eldest daughter shall continue with the maternal grandparents. The bench asked Kalita to assist it as an amicus

curiae in the matter. It noted that the victim was taken to four hospitals and three of them refused admission. It said one of the hospitals provided first aid to her and referred the case to other hospital. Noting that the victim would be in need of financial assistance, especially for undergoing treatment and to look after her minor daughters, the bench directed the NALSA to release interim sum of ₹3 lakh in her favour.

It directed the investigating officer to submit a status report of the probe and posted the matter for hearing on May 11.

The accused, Manoj Kumar, a resident of Sonia Vihar, was arrested from Khajuri Khas area on Sunday, the police had earlier said.

Kumar allegedly stabbed his 38-year-old wife on April 22, they said.

"During interrogation, Kumar confessed to the crime and told police that he attacked his wife following a family dispute," an officer said.



Where is question of offence in consensual relationship, SC asks

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Where is the question of an offence when a relationship is consensual? the Supreme Court on Monday asked a woman who had challenged an order of the Madhya Pradesh High Court that had quashed an FIR against her former live-in partner in a case of alleged sexual assault on a false promise of marriage.

A bench of Justices BV Nagarathna and Ujjal Bhuyan noted that the woman lived together with the man and also had a child from him.

"Where is the question of offence when there is a consensual relationship? They were living together and she also had a child from him and



then there is no marriage and now, she says sexual assault? For 15 years they lived together," Justice

Nagarathna remarked. The woman's counsel told the court that she had lost her husband earlier and was

introduced to the accused by her brother-in-law. The court was also told that the accused had promised to marry her

and sexually exploited her. Justice Nagarathna then asked, "Why did she go and live with him before marriage?"

"She lived with him. She had a child from him. He walks out because there is no marriage bond. Legal bond is not there. He walks out, that is the risk in a live-in relationship. So once he walks out, it does not become a criminal offence," she said.

The woman's lawyer submitted that the accused was already married and had concealed this fact.

"See, if there was marriage, the question of her rights would have been better. She could have filed regarding bigamy. She could have filed for maintenance. She would have got those reliefs. Now

since there is no marriage, they live together, this is the risk. They can walk out any day. What do we do?" Justice Nagarathna said.

She suggested that the woman could pursue remedies, such as maintenance for the child, and asked the parties to go for mediation.

"Even if he goes to jail, what will she gain? We can think of some maintenance for the child. Child is now seven years (old). At least, some monetary compensation can be made for the child," Justice Nagarathna said.

The apex court issued a notice in the matter and asked the parties to explore if a settlement could be reached between the petitioner and the accused.

Plea against SIR exclusion in West Bengal: SC asks tribunal to accord out-of-turn hearing

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

The Supreme Court on Monday asked the appellate tribunal to accord out-of-turn hearing and decide an appeal filed by a man challenging the deletion of his name from the voter list after the Special Intensive Revision in West Bengal.

A bench of Chief Justice Surya Kant and Justice Joymalya Bagchi passed the order while hearing the plea seeking a direction for restoration of the petitioner's name in the electoral roll of Diamond Harbour constituency in the poll-bound state. While the first phase of the West Bengal assembly polls was held on April 23, the second phase is scheduled on April 29. The votes will be counted on May 4.

"The petitioner, being aggrieved by his exclusion from the voter list in the SIR process, is said to have already approached the appellate tribunal on April 2, 2026. We dispose of the instant writ petition with a request to the appellate tribunal to accord out-of-turn hearing and decide the petitioner's appeal at the earliest," the bench said.

On April 24, the apex court asked the appellate tribunals to give out-of-turn hearing to those who make out a case of urgent hearing against deletion



from electoral rolls after the SIR in West Bengal.

The CJI had expressed happiness over the high voter turnout in the first phase of West Bengal assembly polls held on Thursday. The state registered a record voter turnout of 92.72 per cent in the first phase of voting for 152 constituencies.

The bench was then hearing a batch of petitions, including the one filed by Chief Minister Mamata Banerjee, related to the SIR of electoral rolls in the state.

Earlier, the top court ordered that persons, whose pleas were allowed by

the appellate tribunals before April 21 or 27, must be permitted to vote in the first or second phase of assembly elections, respectively.

It, however, had clarified that mere pendency of appeal before the appellate tribunals would not give anyone a right to vote.

Approximately 700 judicial officers from West Bengal and neighbouring Odisha and Jharkhand were deployed to deal with around 60 lakh claims and objections of those who were deleted from voter lists during the SIR of electoral rolls in the State.

Reproductive autonomy of mother-to-be must be accorded highest importance, says SC

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Observing that the reproductive autonomy of a mother-to-be must be accorded the highest importance, the Supreme Court has allowed a 15-year-old girl to medically terminate her pregnancy of more than 28 weeks.

The top court has said when constitutional courts are approached by unintended mothers seeking termination of pregnancy, they ought not take a prohibitory approach. A bench of Justices BV Nagarathna and Ujjal Bhuyan said the pregnant woman's choice is relevant rather than that of the child to be born and stressed that the continuation of such a pregnancy could have long-lasting repercussions on the minor's mental health, educational prospects, social standing and overall development.

The court remarked that the reproductive autonomy of a woman must be accorded the highest importance and if a woman, carrying an unwanted pregnancy, is compelled to continue it, then her constitutional rights would be breached.

"The right to make decisions concerning one's body, particularly in matters of reproduction, is an integral facet of personal liberty and privacy under Article 21 of the Constitution of India. This right cannot be rendered ineffective by imposing unreasonable restrictions, especially in cases involving minors and unwanted pregnancies, such as in the instant case.

"No court ought to compel any woman and more so, a minor child, to carry a pregnancy to full term against her express will. Such compulsion would not only disregard her decisional autonomy but could also inflict grave mental, emotional and physical trauma in case she is compelled to give birth," the bench said in an order passed on April 24.

In the circumstances, denying relief would compel the minor to endure irreversible consequences and such an approach would be contrary to the constitutional and settled principles



recognising reproductive choice as a fundamental right, the court pointed out.

It said the choice of the pregnant woman is relevant rather than that of the child to be born.

"What is of relevance is the choice of the pregnant woman rather than the interest of an unborn child. It is easy to say that if the pregnant woman is not interested in raising the child, she may give away the child in adoption and therefore, must be compelled into giving birth to the child.

"However, that cannot be the correct approach, particularly, in cases where the child to be born is unwanted. In such a situation, directing the pregnant woman to give birth to the child against her wishes and to forcefully continue her pregnancy would negate the welfare of the pregnant woman and make it subordinate to the child yet to be born," the bench said.

It said constitutional courts must weigh the circumstances in which a case in relation to the welfare of a pregnant woman has to be considered rather than a child to be born.

"The constitutional court ought to weigh all facts and circumstances from the lens of the party who intends to terminate the pregnancy and is willing to undertake the medical risks rather than directing completion of the pregnancy and giving birth to an unwanted child.

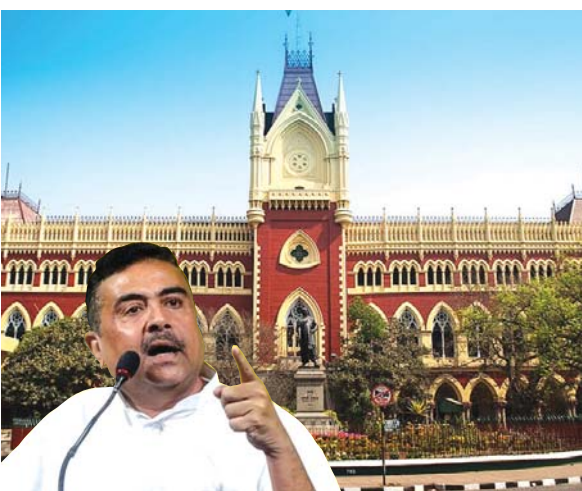
"If the constitutional court states that even an unwanted pregnancy has to be continued, then instead of approaching the court for permission, parties then visit illegal abortion centres or secretly undergo termination of such a pregnancy which would make the pregnant woman more vulnerable and exposed to dangers," the bench said.

HC rejects PIL seeking cancellation of Adhikari's candidature from Bhabanipur

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Kolkata

The Calcutta High Court on Monday rejected a PIL seeking cancellation of BJP leader Suwendu Adhikari's candidature in the Bhabanipur constituency, which will go to polls in the second phase on April 29. Adhikari is pitted against Chief Minister and Trinamool Congress chief Mamata Banerjee in the constituency.

The petitioner sought the rejection of Adhikari's candidature, alleging that he had made some comments that went against the secular fabric of the nation. However, the petitioner could not provide any satisfactory answer to the court's query as to under which provision of the Constitution the candidature should be cancelled.



A division bench presided by Chief Justice Sujoy Paul rejected the petition, refusing to admit it for hearing. Adhikari's lawyer Billwadal Bhattacharya claimed that the petition was moved with a political

motive to affect the candidature of Adhikari from Bhabanipur. The first phase of elections to the 294-member West Bengal assembly was held on April 23. Votes will be counted on May 4.

PM degree case: Delhi HC grants 2 more weeks to DU to file objections

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

The Delhi High Court on Monday granted two more weeks to Delhi University to file its objection to the delay in filing appeals against an order refusing disclosure of details of Prime Minister Narendra Modi's bachelor's degree.

The counsel for the appellants urged the court to condone the delay, saying the varsity was given an additional three weeks to file its objections on the last date as well.

The DU counsel, however, said objections to the delay will be filed within two weeks and requested that the issue be decided after filing the response.

"Learned counsel for respondent states that objection to application seeking condonation of delay will be filed within two weeks.

Response thereof will be filed by the appellants by the next date of listing," a bench of Chief Justice DK Upadhyaya and Justice Tejas Karia said.

The matter was listed for next hearing on August 20.

On February 10, the court had granted three weeks' time to DU to file the objection to the delay.

Solicitor General Tushar Mehta, appearing for the university, had said "there was nothing in the matter" and it was "only to sensationalise".

A senior counsel appearing for an appellant had said the objections to the delay had not been filed even after two and a half months of the court permitting DU to do so.

Appeals have been filed challenging a single judge's order which had set aside a Central Information Commission (CIC) decision directing disclosure of Prime Minister Modi's degree.

The appellants before the



division bench are RTI activist Neeraj, Aam Aadmi Party leader Sanjay Singh and advocate MohdIrrshad.

On August 25, 2025, the single judge had set aside the CIC order, saying only because PM Modi was holding a public office, it did not render all his "personal information" to public disclosure.

It had ruled out any "implicit public interest" in the information sought, and said the RTI Act was enacted to promote transparency in

Government functioning and "not to provide fodder for sensationalism".

Following an RTI application by Neeraj, the CIC on December 21, 2016, allowed inspection of records of all students who cleared the BA exam in 1978 — the year Prime Minister Modi also passed it.

The single judge had passed the combined order in six petitions, including the one filed by the Delhi University, challenging the CIC by which the varsity was

directed to disclose the details related to Modi's bachelor degree.

The Delhi University's counsel had sought the CIC order to be set aside but said the varsity had no objection in showing its records to the court.

The single judge had opined the educational qualifications were not in the nature of any statutory requirement for holding any public office, or discharging official responsibilities.

The situation might have been different, had educational qualifications been a pre-requisite for eligibility to a specific public office, the judge had said, calling the CIC's approach "thoroughly misconceived".

The High Court had also set aside the CIC order that directed the CBSE to provide copies of Class 10 and 12 records of former Union minister Smritilrani.



Editor's
TAKE

India braces for a summer of extremes

India faces a heatwave on a national scale. This signals a deeper climate crisis, demanding urgent preparedness and long-term resilience strategies

It may be a distinctions one would not be proud of but it is a record of sorts. Of world's 100 hottest cities, 98 happen to be in India. The country is witnessing extreme heat conditions as temperatures are soaring and have touched 45 degree celsius in many regions. And this is just the month of April. The worst is yet to come. As the mercury rises with every passing day, the signal is clear – April is showing the mood of summer. April 24 was already the hottest day in four years. From the plains of Punjab and Haryana to eastern states like Odisha and Jharkhand, and even typically humid regions such as Kerala, the heatwave is pan India unlike in the past. The India Meteorological Department (IMD) has issued alerts. Many cities are rescheduling the school timings to protect children from the scorching heat. Indeed this extreme heat could be fatal in some cases and chances of heat strokes are high if one is outdoors for long.

Heatwaves increases the risk of dehydration, heatstroke, and cardiovascular stress, particularly among the elderly, outdoor workers, and children. Millions of informal workers, from construction laborers to street vendors, are at maximum risk. The impact of this impact is not just on public health but on economy as well. This heatwave will test India's resilience and heat tolerance to the limits.Productivity will be low and work hours would be considerably reduced. As heat intensifies, electricity demand surges due to cooling needs, placing enormous pressure on already strained power grids and increasing the risk of outages thereby affecting production. And this is not an isolated or localised heatwave; it is here to stay. This heatwave signals a dimate trajectory. This year is expected to be particularly difficult due to the anticipated strengthening of El Niño conditions. El Niño events typically lead to higher-than-normal temperatures and suppressed monsoon rainfall in India. The implications for agriculture are severe. India's agrarian economy remains heavily dependent on the monsoon. A deficient or delayed rainfall season could impact crop yields, particularly for water-intensive crops such as rice and sugarcane. Farmers, already grappling with rising input costs and climate variability, may face yet another year of low yield. Water scarcity is another looming crisis. Reservoir levels, groundwater tables, and urban water supply systems are all vulnerable to prolonged heat and weak rainfall.

Rising global temperatures are making heatwaves a recurring feature rather than an occasional anomaly. The big question is are we prepared for this undeclared emergency – a situation that can play havoc with economy, cause social unrest and even lead to panic among the people. The policy response, must move beyond short-term coping mechanisms. Heat action plans need to be strengthened and implemented at scale, with a focus on early warning systems, public awareness, and community-level interventions. At the national level, water management and climate-resilient agriculture must become central priorities. How effectively we deal with these extreme heat conditions will decide how fast we grow!

Rediscovering Delhi's Central Legislative Assembly

Amid Delhi's celebrated architectural icons—from the Qutub Minar to India Gate—stands a largely overlooked monument that has quietly witnessed the evolution of India's democratic spirit: the Central Legislative Assembly



FIROZ
BAKHT
AHMED

It has been rightly said that history is written on each and every brick of Delhi. However, Delhi is usually known for monuments like Purana Qila, Qutub Minar, India Gate, Parliament House and others, whereas the Central Legislative Assembly building has been evading the historians' eyes. It is witness to the chequered history of Delhi for a century covering the Delhi Durbars, building of New Delhi, the present Parliament House, of which the predecessor was this Central Assembly only with also the description of the horrendous laws like, the Rowlet Act, a precursor to the Jalianawala Bagh massacre. This building is witness to the century old Parliamentary traditions.

Besides, it is also associated with the celebrated freedom fighter, Vithalbhai Patel, whose efforts of excellence and brilliance got shadowed by none other than his illustrious younger brother, Sardar Vallabhbhai Patel, who was one up, as he became free India's first Home Minister and Deputy Prime Minister! The details of the inimitable history of this monument have also been covered in a coffee table book, "Shatabdi Yatra: Hundred Years of Excellence", immaculately curated and authored by Vijender Gupta, the speaker of the Delhi Assembly, who occupied the same seat as Vithalbhai Patel (1925-1930) and who gathered the related documents and pictures from every nook and cranny possible within India and abroad, including Britain. The historic Central Legislative Assembly not only happens to be a glorious history of governance in India but also accommodates the life and times of Vithalbhai Patel, the savant servant and son of the soil, whose immense contribution for Indian freedom struggle, cannot be forgotten despite not being sufficiently covered. As this monument's present speaker seems to be in love with this monument of Indo-Corinthian architecture, quite impeccably, Vijender Gupta has carved into it all the micro and macro details on the walls, galleries and his book that has been published both in English and Hindi. He is authoring another book on the nuances of the World Wars and role of Indian dominion under the British.

While this book on the Central Legislative Assembly was presented to Narendra Modi, the Indian Prime Minister, he stated that it appears to be the intellectual and administrative legacy of Vithalbhai Patel as an astute nationalist leader and the history of excellent governance in India! This almost blatantly neglected monument, marks a historic milestone and duly pays homage to Vithalbhai Patel, a pioneer of secular democratic traditions in India. The envi-



AS ONE TAKES A TOUR OF THE CENTRAL LEGISLATIVE ASSEMBLY, ONE FINDS OUT THAT WHILE HONOURING THE LEGACY OF VITHALBHAI PATEL, IT ALSO CHRONICLES THE EVOLUTION OF INDIA'S DEMOCRATIC INSTITUTIONS OVER A CENTURY

Firoz Bakht Ahmed is a former Chancellor of Maulana Azad National Urdu University, Hyderabad and grand-nephew, Bharat Ratna, Maulana Azad

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rons of the monument serve as both a historical and visual narrative of India's legislative journey of its excellent governance, that hardly any other country boasts of! It highlights how parliamentary institutions evolved from the manacles of colonial frameworks and clutches of injustice into the vibrant democratic system that has turned India into a bright and brilliant democracy today. The history of this monument is not merely a record of events but a celebration of secular traditions, harmonious society, constitutional values, democratic resilience, and institutional growth.

As one takes a tour of the Central Legislative Assembly, one finds out that while honouring the legacy of Vithalbhai Patel, it also chronicles the evolution of India's democratic institutions over a century in a very appealing style, accompanied by not only unique but stunning pictures, immensely important historical snippets, like the one of the closeness between Vithalbhai Patel and Subhash Chandra Bose, who he made the sole in charge of his will part of his will and to carry out his last rites at Chaupatti, Mumbai (Bombay then). Incidentally, on October 22, 1933, Vithalbhai Patel died in Geneva, Switzerland, with Subhash and many doctors and nurses by his bedside during his last breaths. In a letter of October 2, 1933, Vithalbhai wrote, "In the event of my death in Europe, I desire that Subhash Chandra Bose, take charge of my body and make the necessary arrangements for sending it to Bombay for cremation on the Chaupaty sands alongside the place, where Lokmanya Balgangadhar Tilak's body was cremated."

It seemed that he was aware of his death

earlier though he died on October 22, 1933. The last words of Patel were, "I bless all my countrymen in India and abroad. Before I breathe my last, I pray for the Independence of India." Bose duly obeyed that but the British Raj officers created many boulders for him. Nevertheless, with the help of nationalists, KF

Nariman, SA Baveri, T Bhawan, Deepnarayan it Singh and others, he ably carried out the instructions of Vithalbhai. Lamentably, few people remember Vithalbhai Patel, other than

a building named after him at Delhi's Parliament Street. Nevertheless, the first Prime Minister of Mauritius, Sir Seewoosagar Ramgoolam, in his book, "Our Struggle: 20th Century Mauritius", writes, "My stay among the Indian students thus provided me with a political apprenticeship, especially as developed close friendship with patriotic students like Sidhanand Sinha, who was an able student leader and organiser. But it was Vithalbhai Patel, the elder brother of Sardar Vallabhbhai Patel, the future Home Minister and Deputy Prime Minister of India, who came to be my personal political guru."

Impeccably carved with all the micro and macro details, "Shatabdi Yatra: Hundred Years of Excellence" by Vijender Gupta has been published both in English and Hindi. He is authoring another book on the nuances of the World Wars and role of Indian dominion under the British. While the book was presented to Narendra Modi, the Indian Prime Minister, he stated that it appears to be the intellectual and administrative legacy of Vithalbhai Patel as an astute nationalist leader and the history of excellent governance in India!

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Modern Parenting: Discipline or convenience?



SAKSHI
SETHI

2ND OPINION

In an age defined by speed, noise, and constant distraction, an uncomfortable question confronts us: are we truly raising disciplined children, or merely managing their behaviour for our own convenience? The distinction may appear subtle, but its consequences are already unfolding in homes, classrooms, and society at large. Discipline, in its truest sense, is not about control or punishment; it is about guidance, self-regulation, and the steady shaping of character.What often passes for discipline today swings between two extremes—rigid restriction or complete absence of boundaries. Both are equally harmful. Consider the increasingly common sight of children pacified with smartphones in public spaces. While this may offer parents immediate relief, it creates a deeper dependency. Instead of learning patience or emotional control, children

begin to rely on instant gratification. This pattern, visible in restaurants, homes, and even schools, replaces long-term development with short-term convenience.To be fair, modern parenting is not easy. Dual-income households, academic pressures, and the pervasive influence of digital media stretch parents to their limits. In such circumstances, convenience often becomes a coping mechanism.

Yet, when convenience replaces conscious effort, discipline becomes the first casualty.The impact is evident in classrooms. Educators increasingly encounter students who struggle with basic skills such as attentive listening, patience, and the ability to accept feedback. These are not intellectual deficits but signs of weakened discipline. Such behavioural gaps do not emerge overnight; they are the result of gradual neglect in nurturing essential habits.Technology plays a decisive role in this shift. Today's children grow up in a world of constant stimulation—likes, views, instant answers, and endless comparison. Algorithms are designed to capture attention, not build character. When children become accustomed to immediate rewards, the slower, effort-driven processes of real learning begin to feel burdensome. A child abandoning a difficult math problem within minutes is not necessarily lacking intelligence, but endurance—the very quality discipline is meant to cultivate. Equally concerning is the growing reluctance to say "No." Many parents fear that setting limits may harm a child's self-esteem or strain

their relationship. However, discipline without boundaries is directionless.

A child who never encounters refusal does not become confident, but entitled—ill-equipped to handle rejection or responsibility. Even simple routines, like fixed bedtimes, play a vital role in building self-regulation. Their absence often manifests in irritability, lack of focus, and declining

performance.It is also crucial to distinguish discipline from punishment. Harsh scolding or humiliation may enforce temporary compliance, but they do not foster understanding. True discipline is rooted in consistency, explanation, and example. It teaches children

how to respond to failure—with reflection and resilience, not frustration or blame.Importantly, discipline is not the sole responsibility of parents. Schools, communities, and media collectively shape a child's environment. Discipline cannot flourish in contradiction.The reality, then, is uneven. While many parents and educators strive to instill values, there is a growing tendency to prioritise ease over effort and freedom over responsibility. What we need is not stricter control, but smarter discipline—built on consistency, clear expectations, meaningful dialogue, limited digital exposure, and an emphasis on effort rather than mere outcomes.

The writer is an educator and councillor

LETTERS TO THE EDITOR

Reclaiming the true measure of women

A society's progress is not defined merely by infrastructure or economic growth, but by how it values its people—especially women. This powerful reflection challenges the narrow lens through which women are often viewed, reduced to appearance or traditional roles, while their intellect, resilience, and achievements remain underappreciated. Across the world, including India, women are excelling as scientists, educators, astronauts, and leaders.

Yet their accomplishments frequently receive less attention than superficial aspects of their identity. The reference to women teaching mathematics is particularly striking-highlighting a field long dominated by men, despite the historic and ongoing contributions of women.

Equally overlooked is the invisible labour within homes. Managing households, raising children, and sustaining families require immense skill and dedication, yet are dismissed as routine duties rather than recognised as vital contributions. The role of media and social platforms is perpetuating shallow portrayals of women. Respect for women cannot remain symbolic; it must be reflected in everyday behaviour, opportunities, and attitudes.

PRIYANKA SAURABH | HISAR

AAP in crisis: The test of political survival

The reported defection of Raghav Chadha and several other prominent figures from the Aam Aadmi Party to the Bharatiya Janata Party signals a deepening fissures within the party. If claims of over two-thirds of its Rajya Sabha members switching sides hold, the implications could be politically and legally significant. The turning point appears to have come earlier this month when Chadha was removed as Deputy Leader in the Rajya Sabha.

This move formalised an already widening rift with leadership under Arvind Kejriwal. The exodus of senior voices suggests not just internal dissent, but a broader crisis of cohesion and direction within the party. However, questions remain about the legal validity of such defections. India's anti-defection law allows a merger only when supported by two-thirds of a legislative party, making the numbers crucial. If the threshold is not met, disqualification proceedings could follow. Beyond legality, the episode exposes structural weaknesses in party organisation and leadership management. For AAP, the road ahead will depend on its ability to rebuild trust, retain credibility, and reassert its ideological clarity in an increasingly competitive political landscape.

KIRTI WADHAWAN | KANPUR

PM Modi's Hooghly ride sparks questions

At a time when economic pressures weigh heavily on ordinary citizens, the optics of Narendra Modi enjoying a leisurely boat ride on the Hooghly River have drawn sharp criticism. With inflation rising, essential commodities becoming costlier, and the rupee under strain, many citizens are grappling with daily hardships.

Against this backdrop, images of the Prime Minister, equipped with expensive accessories and seemingly at ease, appear disconnected from ground realities. Critics argue that such displays, particularly during election campaigns, risk conveying insensitivity toward public distress. The comparison to Nero—legend has it, playing music while Rome burned—may be rhetorical, yet it underscores a deeper concern about leadership priorities and public perception.

Symbolism matters in politics, and moments like these can shape narratives as much as policies. For politically aware citizens, especially in states like West Bengal, such instances may influence electoral choices.

Ultimately, leadership is judged not only by governance but also by empathy and the ability to align with the lived experiences of the people.

THARCIOUS S. FERNANDO | CHENNAI

ERODING TRUST: TRUMP, NATO, AND THE TRANSATLANTIC RIFT

The diminishing global respect for Donald Trump stems less from external bias and more from his own conduct. Once, NATO symbolised unity, with Europe often perceived as a natural extension of American leadership.

Today, that trust appears fractured. A March 2026 survey reflects deep disillusionment—overwhelming majorities in Germany, France, and Denmark hold unfavourable views of Trump. The latest flashpoint—his call to expel Spain from NATO—has only widened the divide. Legally, such a move is untenable.

The NATO treaty contains no provision for expelling a member; participation is voluntary, and withdrawal can only be self-initiated.

Yet, reports of internal

discussions within the U.S. administration about punitive actions raise serious concerns about strategic judgment.More critically, America's unilateral posture in its conflict with Iran has found little support among allies like France, Germany, and Britain. Besides, its allies in the Middle East are not as confident of its power as they were earlier.

This isolation signals not just a policy disagreement but a deeper erosion of trust. By pushing allies away while pursuing contentious military engagements, the United States risks weakening the very alliances that once underpinned its global influence—and, in the process, alienating both the international community and its own citizens.

JANG BAHADUR | JAMSHEDPUR

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PIC TALK



Workers pack freshly harvested cucumbers in Chikmagalur, Karnataka.

PHOTO: PTI

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Pakistan’s grand strategic plot for survival

The dramatic collapse of Pakistan’s high-profile attempt to mediate between the United States and Iran in April 2026 has done more than embarrass Islamabad—it has exposed the deeper fault lines of a state struggling to balance ambition with capability



PRASHANT TEWARI

The swiftly moving tides and currents of recent events have proved beyond a shadow of doubt that Pakistan has proved to be abjectly incapable of making the United States and Iran smoke the proverbial peace pipe in Islamabad and has created an unholy mess beyond redemption. The 21-hour-long overtly publicised maiden peace talks disastrously collapsed on 12th April, 2026, to the chagrin of the entire international community. Incredulously, the untrustworthy Pakistan glibly offered to host yet another round of peace negotiations as an ingenious face-saver, which from the very world go bristled with ominous possibilities! It's indeed a travesty of fate that even the second attempt by Pakistan to broker the US-Iran peace talks proved to be utterly abortive on 25th April, 2026, marking a crumbling setback for Pakistan's attempt to mediate between the two nations. The Iranian delegation, led by Iran's Foreign Minister Abbas Araghchi left Islamabad in a huff (prompting President Donald Trump to summarily cancel the trip of the American delegation, including his Special Envoy Steve Witkoff and his Senior Advisor and son-in-law Jared Kushner, to Islamabad!), leaving Pakistan's ambitious pipe dream of brokering a US-Iran peace deal in shatters and exposing Pakistan's abysmally woeful political impotence. In a surprise move, Araghchi returned to Islamabad on 26th April, 2026 and met Field Marshal Syed Asim Munir Ahmed Shah (notoriously known as "Mullah Munir"), Pakistan's highly touted hardline Islamist first Chief of Defence Forces, widely recognised as the de facto ruler of Pakistan, in his lair in a renewed effort to keep the peace pot boiling. The visit proved to be futile to the hilt, and a thoroughly distraught Aarghchi was obliged to pack up and leave Pakistan, albeit empty-handed, and head for Moscow for talks with the Russian President Vladimir Putin. Semantics aside, the deceitful Pakistan has been universally ridiculed as a global laughing stock! In this context, the towering American 16th President Abraham "Abe" Lincoln in a speech delivered on 8th September, 1858 in Clinton, Illinois, had aptly remarked, "You can fool all the people some of the time and some of the people all the time, but you cannot fool all the people all the time."

Pakistan today stands at a critical inflexion point, economically strained, geopolitically stretched, and strategically compelled to recalibrate its position in a rapidly shifting regional order. Beneath the surface of its diplomatic engagements and security posturing lies a deeper, more complex design: a state navigating near-bankruptcy while leveraging its military, geography, and ideological positioning to remain relevant and solvent. At the heart of this posture is an unspoken but evident imperative, economic survival. With mounting debts, dwindling foreign exchange reserves, and repeated reliance on bailout packages, Pakistan's leadership has been forced to think beyond conventional economic reforms. Instead, it appears to be crafting a geopolitical strategy that monetises its strategic location, military capability, and ideological alliances. This "grand strategic survival plot" is not merely reactive; it is structured, with Islamabad positioning itself as indispensable in regional security to convert geopolitical relevance into economic relief through monetary aid, defence partnerships, and strategic concessions.

Internally, Pakistan faces a convergence of debilitating economic hardship and crumbling political fragility. Rampant inflation, crippling unemployment, and persistent instability have eroded public confidence, while the enduring civil-military imbalance ensures that the armed forces continue to overwhelmingly dominate key policy decisions. The weakness of democratic institutions, combined with economic distress, has created a volatile domestic environment. Yet this instability also feeds into Pakistan's external strategy. Like many nations under pressure, it often externalises its crises, amplifying external threats and projecting itself as a frontline state to secure both legitimacy and leverage on the global stage.

A key pillar of this strategy is Pakistan's deepening defence relationship with Saudi Arabia. Historically rooted in close ties, this partnership has



evolved into a quasi-security arrangement where Pakistan provides military training, advisory support, and even troop deployments. In return, Saudi Arabia has extended crucial financial lifelines, including deferred oil payments, direct assistance, and diplomatic backing. The contours of an emerging defence pact suggest a more institutionalised framework, effectively integrating Pakistan's military capabilities into the Kingdom's broader security architecture.

At the same time, Pakistan continues to metamorphose its ties with the United States. Despite a history marked by irreconcilable mistrust and misgivings, Islamabad recognises Washington's enduring influence on global finance and security. The post-Afghanistan withdrawal landscape has opened fresh avenues for engagement, particularly in counter-terrorism and regional stability. Pakistan appears keen to reposition itself as a strategic partner once again, offering intelligence cooperation and logistical support in exchange for military aid and economic assistance—a pragmatic reset driven by sheer necessity rather than mere sentiment.

Pakistan's alignment with the Gulf Cooperation Council further underscores its commitment to Sunni geopolitical consolidation. This alignment is both strategic and ideological, embedding Pakistan within a bloc that provides financial support, diplomatic backing, and strategic depth. However, this positioning inevitably places it at odds with Iran, the principal Shia power in the region. While often understated in official discourse, the sectarian dimension continues to shape regional alliances and rivalries, forcing Pakistan to carefully balance its commitments to Sunni allies with the realities of sharing a border with Iran.

Pakistan is a lifelong opponent of Israel. Significantly, the founding father of Pakistan Mohammad Ali Jinnah, who was suffering from an advanced state of "secretly hidden" incurable tuberculosis, pejoratively described Israel as an "illegitimate child of the West" and called upon fellow Muslims to resist Israel's "nefarious designs" "on Jerusalem and even went on to the extent of asserting that "Israel is an artificial creation, born out of injustice and oppression". It's little wonder then that Pakistan's sabre rattling Defence Minister, Khawaja Muhammad Asif, launched a scathing anti-Semitic attack on Israel on 10th April, 2026 on X ranting, "Israel is evil and a curse for humanity...I hope and pray people who created this cancerous state on Palestinian land to get rid of European Jews burn in hell." In a severe denouncement, the Israeli Prime Minister's Office retaliated on X, "Pakistan Defence Minister's call for Israel's annihilation is outrageous...This is not a statement that can be tolerated from any government, especially not from one that claims to be a neutral arbiter for peace." Interestingly, while Pakistan maintains a strong, openly rhetorical stance against Israel that flagrantly reeks of anti-Semitism, Pakistan's antagonism towards Israel remains largely notional in operational terms. Unlike other regional actors with a history of confrontation, Pakistan's opposition is primarily ideological and symbolic. This allows Islamabad a certain degree of strategic flexibility, enabling it to uphold pro-Palestinian positions without becoming entangled in direct conflict, thereby preserving focus on more immediate geopolitical concerns.

Central to Pakistan's external strategy is its military, which remains one of its most potent assets. Highly trained and battle-hardened, the armed forces have increasingly been deployed as instruments of statecraft. From peacekeeping missions to bilateral security arrangements, Pakistan has demonstrated a willingness to provide military services in exchange for financial and

strategic benefits. This quasi-mercenary dimension, though rarely acknowledged officially, is evident in its engagements across West Asia and beyond. It allows Pakistan to generate revenues, strengthen alliances, and maintain operational readiness, all while reinforcing the military's overbearing role in national policy.

In Asia, Pakistan's most consequential partnership remains with China. Anchored by the China-Pakistan Economic Corridor, this relationship extends beyond infrastructure into defence, technology, and diplomatic cooperation. For Islamabad, Beijing serves as a vital counterweight to India's expanding regional and global influence. Chinese support provides Pakistan with military hardware, investment, and diplomatic cover, particularly in multilateral forums. However, this deepening alignment also raises concerns about overdependence, with long-term implications for Pakistan's strategic autonomy.

Meanwhile, the situation in Afghanistan continues to cast a long shadow over Pakistan's security landscape. The resurgence of militant groups, coupled with cross-border terrorism and refugee pressures, has created a complex and often volatile environment. Despite its historical involvement in Afghan affairs, Pakistan now faces the unintended consequences of instability across its western frontier. Managing this persistent threat remains one of Islamabad's most pressing challenges, complicating both its internal security and regional diplomacy.

Beyond immediate alliances, Pakistan appears to be scrupulously cultivating a broader ideological network inextricably rooted in pan-Islamic solidarity. By invoking the concept of Muslim brotherhood, it seeks to strengthen ties with countries such as Turkey and Azerbaijan, alongside traditional Sunni monarchies. This outreach enhances Pakistan's diplomatic reach, reinforces its ideological identity, and creates alternative axes of support beyond the Western sphere. The emphasis on shared religious and cultural ties provides a unifying narrative that transcends economic and political divides.

Lamentably, Pakistan is increasingly earning the dubious reputation of being a failed, rogue, radicalised state and, worse still, an epicentre of global terrorism. According to the 2026 13th edition of the Global Terrorism Index (GTI), which provides a comprehensive summary of the key

global trends and patterns in terrorism over the last two decades, "Pakistan recorded the highest score on the Index and is the country most impacted by terrorism" and "Deaths from terrorism in Pakistan are now at their highest level since 2013, with the country recording 1,139 terrorism deaths and 1,045 incidents in 2025". And India has time and again, since the very inception of Pakistan, been a hapless victim, nay studied target, of Pakistan's state-sponsored export of terrorism leading to unwanted, bloody wars and skirmishes! Reprehensively, Pakistan is the largest exporter of donkeys, particularly to China. Joining the unusual list of Pakistan's exports are beggars. According to Zeeshan Khanzada, the well-known Pakistani Senator and Chairman of the Senate Standing Committee on Overseas Pakistanis and Human Resource Developmentt, 90 per cent of the beggars imprisoned in West Asian countries are from Pakistan and are being held in prisons in Saudi Arabia and Iraq.

The problem has gained such enormous proportions that countries like Saudi Arabia and Iraq have tersely requested the Pakistani government to stem the inflow of beggars. Not only that, most of the pickpockets arrested from within Mecca's Masjid al-Haram, the Great Mosque of Mecca, the largest mosque in the world and the holiest site in Islam, are Pakistanis!What an incorrigible nation!

Ultimately, Pakistan's trajectory reflects a strategy shaped more by compulsion than choice. Confronted with economic crisis, political friability, and regional pressures, the state is leveraging every available asset: military strength, ideological alignment, and geopolitical positioning to sustain itself. Yet, this approach carries inherent risks. Overdependence on external patrons, deepening sectarian alignments, and the increasing militarisation of its foreign policy may perforce constrain Pakistan's options in the long term. The real challenge lies in transitioning from a survival-driven framework to a more stable and sustainable model of statecraft. Until then, Pakistan will continue to walk a precarious tightrope, balancing alliances, managing crises, and striving to maintain relevance in a world where strategic utility often defines national endurance.

Maritime security: Need to have proactive doctrine



KRIPA NAUTIYAL

The ongoing tensions in the Gulf and the looming spectre of a blockade in the Strait of Hormuz serve as a stark reminder that global sea lanes are neither inviolable nor immune to disruption. For India, a nation whose economic lifelines are inextricably tied to the seas, this is not a distant geopolitical abstraction but an immediate strategic concern. With a coastline stretching over 11,000 kilometres, an expansive Exclusive Economic Zone, and a vast network of islands, India's maritime geography is both an asset and a vulnerability.

Over the decades, the country has painstakingly built a credible coastal security architecture. Yet, credibility alone is no longer sufficient. The emerging security environment demands a decisive doctrinal shift—from a reactive posture to a proactive, preventive, and integrated maritime strategy. India's coastal security framework has evolved less through anticipation and more through adversity. The establishment of the Coast Guard in 1978 marked the beginning of a structured maritime law enforcement presence. The absence of an integrated, multi-agency security grid became painfully evident in 1993, when the Mumbai serial blasts were facilitated by the clandestine landing of arms and explosives along the Maharashtra coast. This incident forced policymakers to acknowledge the coastline as a critical security frontier, leading to enhanced patrolling efforts. However, these measures, while important, were incremental and insufficient to address systemic vulnerabilities. The Kargil conflict in 1999 triggered a broader reassessment of national security, including maritime dimensions, but it was the attacks of 26/11 that exposed the full extent of India's coastal security lapses. The response in the aftermath was substantial and transformative. Initiatives such as the Coastal Security Scheme, the establishment of Joint Operations Centres, the National Command Control Communication and Intelligence (NC3I) network, and the National Maritime Domain Awareness project significantly strengthened India's maritime security infrastructure.

The integration of marine police forces, the deployment of coastal radar chains, and the expansion of surveillance capabilities further enhanced situational awareness. In recent years, India has continued to build upon this foundation. Investments in offshore patrol vessels, maritime reconnaissance aircraft, and information-sharing platforms such as the Information Fusion Centre for the Indian Ocean Region have improved operational readiness.

Agreements with multiple countries to share white shipping information have expanded India's maritime reach beyond its immediate waters. Collectively, these measures have created a system that is both robust and credible. Yet, despite these advancements, the fundamental orientation of India's coastal security remains reactive. The current model measures success primarily through enforcement metrics—patrol hours logged, distances covered, and quantities of contraband seized. While these indicators are important, they reflect a focus on intercepting threats after they have materialised rather than preventing their emergence. A purely interdiction-based approach, no matter how efficient, cannot achieve lasting security outcomes. A proactive maritime security strategy requires a fundamental redefinition of both objectives and metrics. Instead of focusing solely on immediate enforcement outcomes, success must be evaluated in terms of sustained reductions in illegal maritime activities, disruption of criminal networks, and resilience of coastal ecosystems. This approach recognises that security threats at sea are often rooted in economic, social, and governance deficits on land.

Central to this shift is the need to transform coastal communities from passive subjects of security measures into active partners. Fishermen, harbour workers, and coastal traders possess granular, real-time knowledge of local maritime activity that no technological system can fully replicate. A fisherman noticing an unfamiliar vessel lingering offshore or unusual patterns in maritime movement can provide critical early warnings. Institutionalising such community-based intelligence through formal reporting mechanisms, legal protections, and prompt response systems is not a peripheral initiative—it is a strategic imperative. Depleting fish stocks, rising operational costs, limited access to credit, and lack of insurance push many in coastal communities towards smuggling or other illegal enterprises. By investing in marine insurance schemes, cooperative credit structures, and alternative livelihoods such as aquaculture and coastal tourism, the state can reduce the incentive base for criminal recruitment. In this sense, ministries dealing with fisheries, finance, and labour become as critical to maritime security as traditional defence and law enforcement agencies.

Governance of littoral spaces also requires urgent attention. Corruption within port and harbour ecosystems represents a significant security vulnerability. Illicit consignments that pass through compromised administrative systems pose risks equivalent to those that evade detection at sea. Strengthening regulatory oversight through measures such as biometric crew identification, universal vessel tracking systems, and independent audits of port authorities is essential. While joint exercises involving the Navy, Coast Guard, intelligence agencies, and other stakeholders are valuable, their effectiveness depends on the institutionalisation of lessons learned into everyday operations. India's vision of regional cooperation, articulated through initiatives like SAGAR (Security and Growth for All in the Region), provides a strong conceptual framework. However, translating this vision into operational reality requires deeper collaboration with neighbouring countries, including joint surveillance, coordinated enforcement actions, and shared intelligence mechanisms. Without such cooperation, enforcement efforts risk merely displacing criminal activities across maritime borders rather than eliminating them. Ultimately, the imperative for India is clear. The seas surrounding the country are becoming increasingly contested and complex, shaped by geopolitical tensions, economic competition, and transnational threats. A reactive approach, however sophisticated, will always remain one step behind evolving challenges. India stands at a juncture where it can either continue to refine its reactive systems or embrace a transformative approach that anticipates and mitigates threats before they materialise. The choice will determine not only the security of its coastline but also the resilience of its broader strategic and economic future.



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India’s space race heats up: New venture from Hyderabad signals next big leap.



SAYAN CHATTERJEE

India's space economy is moving into a decisive phase—defined by scale, speed, and growing global ambition. Over the years, the Indian Space Research Organisation (ISRO) has launched more than 430 foreign satellites, steadily building a reputation for cost-efficient and reliable missions. What began as a largely scientific pursuit is now evolving into a commercially competitive space programme, at a time when the global space economy is projected to cross the \$1 trillion mark by 2040.

This shift is unfolding against a rapidly changing global backdrop. The rise of reusable launch technologies, led by SpaceX, has dramatically lowered costs and turnaround times, forcing spacefaring nations to rethink their strategies. India, however, appears to be keeping pace. High-profile missions such as Chandrayaan, along with record-setting

multi-satellite launches and a steadily growing private ecosystem, point to a clear strategic pivot—one that aims to capture a larger share of the global launch and satellite services market.

Demand is surging across sectors, from broadband connectivity and earth observation to defence-linked space infrastructure. In this environment, India's combination of affordability, reliability, and a more open policy framework is increasingly positioning it as a serious contender on the global stage.

At this crucial juncture, defence-linked sources suggest that India could soon witness another milestone. By May 2026, the country may see the rollout of its first full-stack private aerospace venture by the name of Astramile Aerospace. The proposed venture brings together a diverse founding team—an Indian Army veteran, former scientists from the Defence Research and Development Organisation (DRDO) & ISRO and Hyderabad-based entrepreneur Neetu Malhotra. If realised as planned, the company could mark a significant step forward in India's private participation in the space sector.

Astramile Aerospace is expected to position itself alongside existing players like Skyroot



Aerospace and Agnikul Cosmos, while seeking to distinguish itself through a fully integrated, end-to-end aerospace model. Unlike many startups that focus on a single segment, the company is reportedly aiming to combine launch capabilities with satellite manufacturing under one umbrella.

According to sources familiar with the plans, the venture is working on both nano and

micro satellite platforms. Nano satellites in the 10–50 kg range and micro satellites between 100–500 kg are expected to serve a wide spectrum of applications, including earth observation, telecommunications, agriculture, and defence.

To support this, the company is setting up a state of art cleanroom facility for precision manufacturing, alongside advanced vibration and thermal vacuum testing systems required for space-grade qualification. The broader manufacturing ecosystem is being designed to handle the entire lifecycle—from assembly and calibration to final flight readiness—effectively creating a vertically integrated operation across both payloads and launch systems.

On the propulsion front, Astramile is planning near-term testing of reusable semi cryogenic engine based Launch Vehicle to insert small satellites weighing between 800 to 1000 kilograms into the Lower Earth Orbit (LEO). This platform is expected to eventually support deep-space missions. Notably, around 80% of the venture's components are expected to be indigenously sourced, aligning closely with India's push for self-reliance under Hon PM's initiative of Atma Nirbhar Bharat and Make in India. Headquartered in Hyderabad, the company

is also planning a 100-acre integrated aerospace campus in Andhra Pradesh. The facility is expected to house design, R&D, and manufacturing operations, with a strong emphasis on sustainability—ranging from renewable solar energy use to zero liquid discharge systems and closed-loop water management.

Currently self-funded, Astramile Aerospace is in the process of raising seed or Series A round. Its roadmap outlines a phased investment strategy leading up to its first launch tentatively in 2029. In the longer term, the company is targeting over 10 orbital launches annually, scaling satellite production to as many as 25–30 units per year, and expanding into global markets.

Going by the current plans, Astramile Aerospace is likely to become a key player in India's evolving space ecosystem—at a time when the country is not just participating in the global space race, but steadily working to shape it.

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BLASÉ CAPITAL

ALL IN, **ALL OUT**

As the debate rages across the world whether AI will create net jobs, or destroy tens of millions of existing ones, the news seems to swing towards the negative side. Tech giant Oracle announced layoffs of 20,000-30,000 people, who are located globally, and were told about their sackings via emails. Over the past month or two, according to several media reports, other tech biggies such as Meta, Microsoft, Disney, and others have pink-slipped thousands of employees. In India, data that emerged from Q4-26 results show that in several IT firms, the net number of employees has come down, despite additions of freshers. No one is safe anywhere. The cuts in Oracle, for instance, include the employees based in India, the US, Canada, and Latin America. In effect, they cut across economies and geographies, and include both the emerging markets, and developed economies. Even the so-called low-cost, high-productive individuals are under the scanner.

More importantly, as the Indian scenario shows, with the intake of thousands of first-timers, even as overall numbers fall, and as speculation grows in the western world, the senior, highly-skilled, and obviously higher-paid employees are more at risk today. According to some media reports, the Oracle layoffs include those who had worked in the firm for more than three decades. According to speculations by one such employee, “an internal algorithm may have flagged off senior individual contributors and mid-level managers,” and some of those with “outstanding stock options could have been among those targeted.” This raises two interesting, and seemingly-counterintuitive issues. The first is that possibly AI, or an algorithm driven by it, is choosing the names of those who will be sacked. AI sacks humans, who will be replaced by AI. Second, there was an initial assessment that AI will take over low-quality, low-productive, and easily-transferable jobs, and drive away the lower-level employees. But the Oracle incident seems to imply that the seniors are at risk. The use of AI may not be just to drive up productivity but lower costs, and get rid of the expensive individuals. This seems more believable because of the mention of stock options.

Maybe this succeeds similar trends in other knowledge-based, and knowledge-driven segments, and sectors. In the past, tech coupled with youngsters, who were savvy with tech and cost a lot less, replaced senior and more experienced employees across sectors. Indeed, business models were built around a clutch of a dozen, even half-a-dozen, seniors, who would control, train, and manage hundreds of youngsters, who were faster to use tech to reduce time and costs. AI may do the same, and in a similar fashion. IT firms, and global tech firms may wish to hire skillful youngsters, with knowledge about AI, and its use, train them over weeks or months, and deploy them in large numbers. A few senior managers, or team leaders will oversee them. This happened in the case of IT, when onshoring gave way to offshoring, and outsourcing, and Indian campuses were loaded with dozens of mid-levels, or even young team leaders, who handled dozens of people each. Today, with the aid of AI, the senior team leaders can handle hundreds, if not thousands, thereby dismantling the mid-layer, and part of the upper layer. Thus, firms will be full of freshers, and first-timers, along with a small set of seniors, who are critical, or are founders.

But, at present, one is not sure about the business models, especially related to HR and workforce, which will evolve later. Today, along with the seniors, and mid-levels, even the freshers are facing problems. This is because, as many youngsters lament in places such as Pune, Bengaluru, Hyderabad, and Chennai, the IT firms have either reduced or frozen intake at the lowest levels. This is especially true about the top Indian firms, and MNCs, and most of the jobs available are with the start-ups, which largely work, ironically, in AI-related fields. According to some people, while AI influences the people at the mid-level and senior-level, it “erodes the bottom layer.” The truth is that firms need less people at every level. As we said earlier, no one is safe. Possibly, the only safe people today are youngsters with AI- and tech-specific skills so that firms can employ them to use AI and tech at cheaper costs. Thus, costs matter as much as skills and experience, as we said earlier. In fact, according to some observers, youngsters seek some limited experience, even in smaller firms, to gain the confidence to launch their own firms. Everyone wants a start-up; the dream days are over.

However, there is another side to the knowledge sector’s story. Across segments, past decisions to combine tech with youngsters failed to deliver the goods. Only the founders, and some of them, survived. In contrast, business models that combined tech, human experiences, and young blood did much better, if the workloads were divided fairly and firmly among the three workhorses. There were things that tech can do independently, and some that it can do with the help of either youngsters or seniors. There are things that seniors can do, with or without the help of tech, and some that juniors can do with tech.

The Pioneer

NEW DELHI | TUESDAY | APRIL 28, 2026

BUSINESS

10

Hormuz + 2 after China + 1?

History shows that the Strait’s future may be like El-Mandeb or Suez?

Despite more clarity, or rather greater enthusiasm about the opening of the Strait of Hormuz, and the end of war, the future of global oil supplies remains under a churn. Many experts believe that the Strait’s trajectory may be similar to China’s after the pandemic. Then, nations vigorously and rigorously pursued China+1 to make their supply chains more varied and flexible, even if more expensive. In the future, both buyers and sellers may aggressively maintain Hormuz+2 routes to ensure greater safety, security, and certainty. For the once-crucial Strait, life after Iran may never be the same again.

According to a recent article, “Markets and policy-makers should look at the precedent already set in the Bab El-Mandeb and Suez Canal. Despite intermittent stabilisation efforts, traffic through the Red Sea corridor remains structurally depressed, even after years of reopening, with Suez throughput still far below pre-crisis levels. It has become clear that incentives such as transit fee discounts are widely failing to bring vessels back. The Houthis (rebels) did not need to close the corridor permanently; they needed to make it all unreliable. That alone was enough to rewire global shipping behaviour.”

In effect, what the Houthis managed in the Red Sea will happen in the Strait. Over the past several years, the Iran-backed rebel forces in Yemen ensured the closures of El-Mandeb several times, including the attacks on commercial vessels that led to “significant disruptions,” with “many ships rerouted.” Even in February 2026, before the Iran war, there were reports that ships preferred the longer and expensive route around the Cape of Good Hope in South Africa rather than face the ire of the Houthis in the Red Sea. Even if the Strait opens, shippers and insurers will forever dread the wrath

of Allah, or Ayatollah. Over the next few months, even years, after the peace between the US and Iran, the Strait will continue to be in danger, if not real then perceived.

Rebels in the Middle East will continuously threaten to target the choke point, now that they realise its significance, and how it can force giant nations to take notice, and react immediately. If the US is forced to move its navy against a puny, and much-weaker Iran, imagine the state of the European and Middle-East nations. Despite the lack of war in the future, peace is forever shattered.

As a media article adds, “There needs to be an understanding that shipping is not governed by physical access alone, but by risk perception. Once that perception shifts, as is now the case of Hormuz, the system behaves differently. The withdrawal of war-risk insurance in March effectively shut down commercial navigation, regardless of whether the Strait was technically open. Even now, when some parties have stated that the Strait has been partially reopened at certain times, major operators still refuse to transit. In some cases, none of the top shipping companies are willing to take cargo through the Strait.”

One needs to simultaneously remember that when global crude oil prices go up and down, they generally do not completely reflect the demand-supply scenario. Much of the rise in the oil prices is due to the increase in, what is called, the risk premiums. It is the actual or perceived risks that push up the prices, or the lack of it that brings them down. Hence, risk is a crucial element in the pricing structure of crude oil. The risks attached with Hormuz will be permanently embedded in the supply route, either as a premium, or as a neglect.

Even in the post-war scenario, the war-risk

premiums that have surged, will settle down but remain substantially high, \$10-20 a barrel over the pre-war crude prices. Insurers will price in the risks of possible disruptions that can begin any day, any time. Shippers, despite their images of being brave and adventurous, will be cautious, and err on the side of caution. Nations will not want a situation when dozens of their vessels are suddenly stuck in the Strait, as they were. Even the Middle East producers will ship via several routes to diversify risks.

Over the years, due to the crises in the Strait and Red Sea, the Cape of Good Hope is a permanent default route. Although it can add up to two weeks to a ship’s journey from the Middle East to Asia, or thousands of nautical miles, depending on the destination ports, it is no longer a “temporary detour.” As critics maintain, the route via the Good Hope is to prevent bad things elsewhere. It is “embedded in network design,” as shippers seek alternatives like Hormuz+2. The implications, they add, “for energy markets are, and will increasingly become profound.”

Energy will become a more sensitive tool in diplomacy and geopolitics. Both buyers and sellers of oil will think of supplies as a means to either enhance friendships with some, and reduce exposure to possible enemies. Thus, Europe, as is the case after the Russia-Ukraine war, will forever be fearful of Russian supplies, and move towards the US and African suppliers. India will need to wean towards the US for higher supplies, despite Russia being a friend, to get the India-America bilateral trade treaty in place. China will remain a great oil-linked friend with Russia and Iran. Japan will try new things.

Grand projects, which were kept on the back bench because of their enormous costs, and construction periods, will be back on the table. These may include “pipelines to the Red Sea, storage hubs outside the choke points, and new transshipment models.” The Russia-China pipeline, long mired in controversies and delays, may get a boost. Since these investments are irreversible, once spent, they will fundamentally reconfigure the “global energy logistics.” Once committed, nations, firms, and policy-makers will find it difficult to back out, or back away.

Hence, according to several analysts, “The most dangerous mistake policy-makers can make now is to treat reopening (of the Strait of Hormuz) as a resolution. The data shows otherwise. Traffic does not return. Costs do not normalise. Behaviour does not revert. The system evolves.” Logically, global trade and energy flows will be “more regional, more redundant, and more expensive. Efficiency has given way to resilience. The price of security will be permanently embedded in trade.” As we once entoned in these columns, the straight road, or rather shipping route, through the Strait is forever crooked. The ships going towards it will fork in different ways before they reach it.

OUR TAKE

A Contrarian Investor

Teenagers engage with money

Even before they leave school, they explore ways to earn, and save

day spending decisions, and parents retain control over the larger financial choices. The structure allows a lot of experiments but within limits, and helps the youngsters to gradually build judgement. In many, it allows the students to break out of the family clutches, and become largely independent, especially when they launch start-ups, or businesses while still in school or colleges.

The larger shift is conceptual. Gen Alpha is not just aware of money but is beginning to engage with it in practical ways. It is transitioning from observation to participation. For families, this increases the need for structured financial conversations. For educators and fintech players, it opens up a new segment that requires tailored tools and guidance. In effect, India’s youngest consumers are not waiting to understand money; they are experimenting with it, within boundaries, but with clear intent. Hence, stakeholders need to think differently while engaging with the teenagers, not just as a section that can be wooed, lured, even manipulated, and nudged into decisions.

A recent study on health insurance reveals how the young Indians, those in their twenties and thirties, are prepared for medical risks. The report draws on a survey of over 2,400 respondents across more than 35 urban and rural locations. It highlights a clear disconnect between awareness and adoption. While more than 50 per cent place health insurance among top three financial priorities, only 14 per cent have a policy, which underscores the gap between intent and action. A central feature of the study is the Health Protection Score (HPS), described as a “first-of-its-kind composite metric” that evaluates preparedness for medical emergencies. The findings paint a worrisome picture.

Despite a sense of health, youngsters record a HPS of 4.54, which indicates limited preparedness. Slightly over three-fourths “fall within the vulnerable zone, with 23 per cent classified as very vulnerable, and 53 per cent as somewhat vulnerable.” Less than a quarter of them are financially or medically prepared. The report suggests that this gap is driven more by percep-

tion than affordability. Many young individuals defer buying insurance, because of the false belief that it is only necessary later in life. This aligns with a behaviour that prioritises liquidity (26 per cent) over long-term protection (eight per cent).

Familial considerations remain a key driver of purchase decisions. Rising healthcare costs, access to quality treatment, and need to safeguard loved ones are the major motivators to buy the policies, particularly in the smaller towns where insurance is viewed as a safety net. Thus, emergencies and existing problems lead to a greater awareness. Youngsters, who are not surrounded by the sick are unlikely to think about possible health emergencies that may crop up later. This is evident from the manner in which teenagers discover insurance.

While Google and YouTube aid the discovery process, human interactions continue to influence the final decisions. Among those aged between 24 and 27 years, friends and family impact more than half of the purchases. More than a third of this age group relies on agents, a percentage that rises to more than 40 per cent among those who are aged between 31 and 34 years. However, retaining the policies remains a challenge. The report notes that “34 per cent (of those who) discontinued their policy because they felt they and their families were healthy,” and “31% opted to ‘rather invest in something that gives returns.’”

Nimish Agrawal, chief marketing officer, Niva Bupa Health Insurance, which conducted the survey, said, “India’s young population is increasingly aware of the importance of financial planning, and health insurance is gradually becoming part of that conversation. However, the gap between intent and ownership shows that the category still needs to become more relevant, relatable, and easier to understand for younger consumers.” While Gen Alpha builds early habits around earning, spending, and savings, young adults’ experiences show that financial awareness does not automatically extend to protection. The gap is most visible in insurance, where intent remains high but ownership and continuity lag, leaving many exposed to health risks. Yet, the challenge will be to translate curiosity into financial behavior.

The Pioneer

SINCE 1865

PIOTECH

India-born Duke grad quietly saving big tech millions on its ML stack



Himanshu Jain

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Behind every product that feels effortless at scale, there's usually a small group of engineers doing unglamorous, high-leverage work that almost nobody hears about. In Silicon Valley, one of those engineers is Himanshu Jain, an India-born, Duke-educated ML engineer working on the models that rank what billions of people see in their social feeds every day.

From Duke to Menlo Park

Jain's path into Big Tech is the kind that's become increasingly common for the new generation of Indian-origin technologists shaping Silicon Valley's AI stack. He studied Computer Science at Duke University before landing a Machine Learning internship in 2021 at one of the largest consumer tech companies in the world, where he built a zero-to-one job groups recommendation product end-to-end and shipped it to the public. The work earned him a full-time offer.

One of the hardest ML problems in Big Tech

Since March 2022, Jain has been a Software Engineer (ML) working on newsfeed ranking in Menlo Park, arguably one of the most technically demanding and businesscritical ML surfaces anywhere in the world. It's a domain where tiny efficiency gains translate into massive real-world impact, both for user experience

and the company's bottom line. According to his own track record, he has driven over \$20 million in estimated annual savings through his work on ranking systems. It's the kind of quiet, high-leverage engineering that rarely makes headlines but keeps platforms running.

Wins at this scale don't come from clever one-off hacks. They come from deeply understanding the ML systems behind ranking and having the rigor to ship changes carefully on a product that serves billions of users a day.

A builder from the start

What stands out about Jain's profile isn't just the Big Tech work. It's a consistent pattern of building things that ship. On the side, he's launched an educational search engine aggregating data from seven plus learning platforms, and has published Visual Studio Code extensions that have crossed 8,000 downloads. Small but telling signals of an engineer who builds for real users, not just for the resume.

In an industry that loves to celebrate founders and frontier researchers, engineers like Himanshu Jain are a reminder of a quieter but equally important truth. The AI products we take for granted are held up by people doing exacting, high-leverage work inside the machine. And if his trajectory is any indication, the most interesting chapters of his career are still ahead.

Rubrik secures and accelerates AI agents on Google Cloud



PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Rubrik (NYSE: RBRK), the Security and AI Operations company, has launched Rubrik Agent Cloud (RAC) for Gemini Enterprise Agent Platform. The collaboration will help organisations to accelerate and secure the deployment of AI agents on Google Cloud with a critical layer of semantic governance and operational resilience powered by Rubrik's real-time, intent-based guardrails.

Gartner predicts that 40 per cent of enterprise applications will be integrated with task-specific AI agents by the end of 2026. For customers running Google Cloud-built autonomous agents, the new integration provides Rubrik capabilities to monitor, govern, and instantly remediate AI actions. RAC is powered by Rubrik's Semantic AI Governance Engine (SAGE), data security's leading AI governance engine designed to maintain total

control over agent behavior – with the industry's only 'rewind' capability to undo mistakes.

"As enterprises move into the autonomous era with Gemini Enterprise, security and governance are top of mind," said Satish Thomas, Vice President, Applied AI & Platform Ecosystem, Google Cloud. "Rubrik helps to provide a unified control layer for agent deployment and security that is critical for AI success."

"Enterprises want the speed of Google Cloud's AI technologies, but also require the safety of Rubrik's cyber resilience," said Devvret Rishi, General Manager AI, Rubrik. "Through this collaboration, we will remove the governance bottleneck for customers developing with Gemini Enterprise Agent Platform. RAC provides real-time guardrails organisations need to speed AI agents into production, without the worry of compromising enterprise security or integrity."

Bricks without blueprints: The cost of India's silicon dependency



NISHANT SAHDEV

While India is pouring concrete in Odisha but the rules for what goes inside those factories are redrafted here in Washington.

From Gujarat to Odisha, new semiconductor packaging plants, assembly lines, and data centers are rising across the country. Every inauguration is presented as evidence that India has entered the front rank of technological powers. In New Delhi, with a message that the India's age of silicon has arrived.

This optimism has value. Manufacturing creates jobs, builds technical discipline, and reduces pressure from India's vast electronics import bill. But a dangerous confusion has entered the national conversation. We are mistaking infrastructure for control. There is a major difference between hosting technology and owning it. A country can build factories, consume huge subsidies, and still remain dependent on systems designed, licensed, and governed elsewhere.

While bilateral frameworks like the Initiative on Critical and Emerging Technology (iCET) are sold to Indian institutional investors as a triumph, the numbers tell a harsher story.

In February, Washington imposed a uniform 10 per cent tariff. In March, the USTR launched aggressive Section 301 investigations into industrial capacities across 16 economies. These are not accidents of diplomacy. They are the new baseline of American trade policy, which is growing highly protectionist. India is building the physical hardware for the future, but the United States holds the rules for how that hardware can be used. We are building a house on a rented foundation.

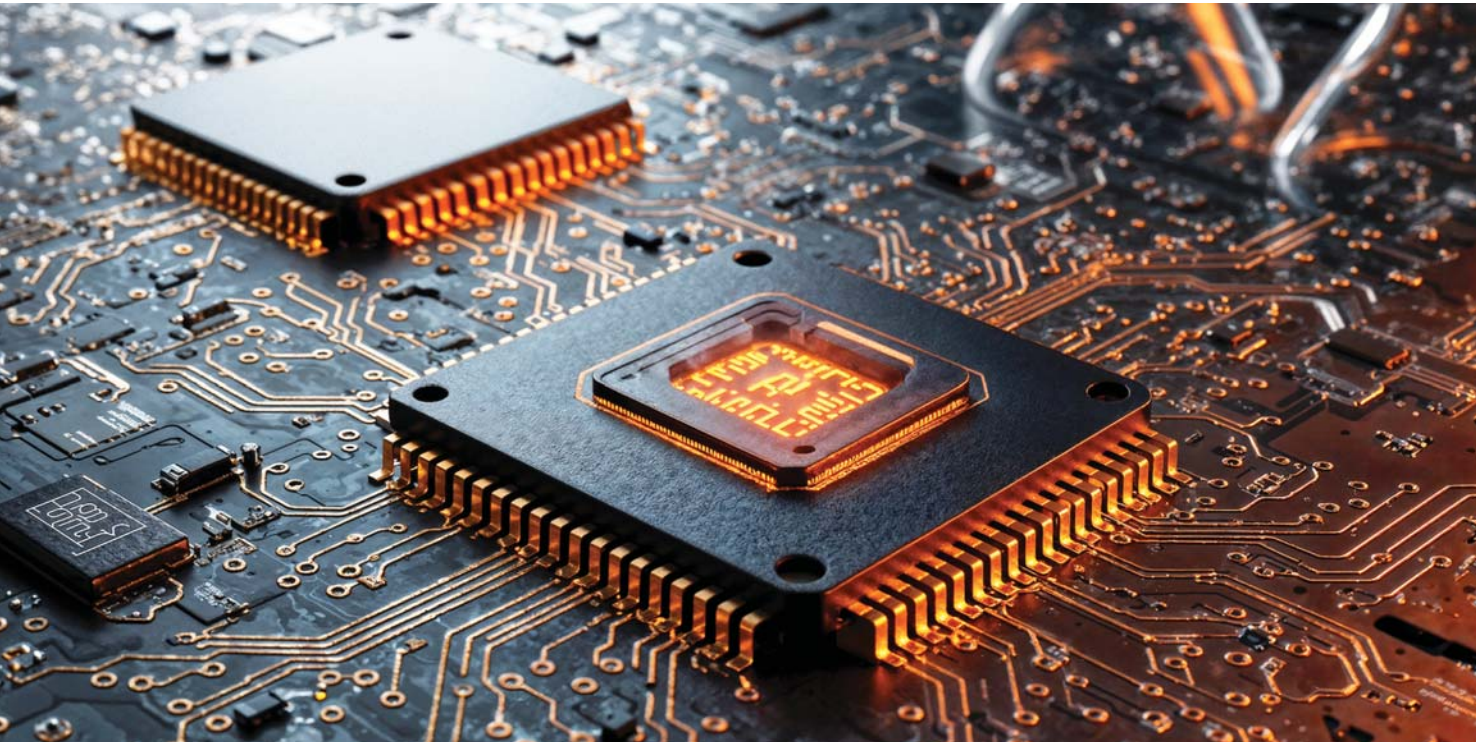
The Fallacy of Linear Progress

New Delhi suffers from the assumption of linear progress. Policymakers believe geopolitical alignment with the U.S. guarantees technology transfers, which fuels manufacturing, ending in export dominance.

This ignores how modern supply chains actually work. Trade policy today is a highly volatile market. If a domestic facility's viability can be erased overnight by a sudden pivot in foreign export controls, it is not an independent Indian asset. It is a leveraged project dependent on external permission.

The Packaging Trap and the Margin Deficit

Washington's playbook in the Indo-Pacific is economically rational:



onshore the high-margin, intellectually rigorous work of chip design and AI research, while outsourcing the lower-margin, ecologically demanding labor of assembly, testing, and packaging (ATP) to partner nations.

Look at the underlying economics. In the global semiconductor value chain, fabless design and core intellectual property capture nearly 50 per cent of the industry's total profit. Assembly and packaging yield less than 10 per cent. By focusing state incentives primarily on ATP and legacy manufacturing, India walks into a high-investment, low-yield trap. A fab without design capability is a factory with rent to pay. The 3D Glass Solutions partnership in Odisha creates vital employment, but it cannot be the final destination. Without a corresponding surge in indigenous chip design and intellectual property ownership, India will remain a highly capable subcontractor.

This is the Silicon Shackle: achieving the status of being physically indispensable to the global supply chain, while remaining fundamentally dependent on the original architect. If India owns the building but not the operating system, sovereignty is cosmetic.

The Token Tax and the \$120 Billion Ledger

This dependency extends into the digital sphere. A new zone of influence is being drawn by the U.S. Department of Commerce that prioritizes American technological hegemony over global market access.

Under these rules, acquiring the compute-dense GPUs necessary for India's 10,000-chip National AI Mission requires navigating National

Validated End-User (NVEU) authorizations. For Indian data centers, these mandatory audits act as a silent embargo. They delay time-to-market by months. India subsidizes the power and constructs the data centers, but the computing power humming inside them remains audited and overseen by a foreign capital.

Compute dependence is the new oil dependence. Furthermore, we must confront the hidden economic drain of our current AI ecosystem. Over 80 per cent of Indian AI startups today build their applications on top of U.S.-hosted, proprietary foundational models. This creates a perpetual Token Tax. Every time an Indian enterprise utilizes an American API to process a prompt or analyze data, a micro-payment of capital—and crucially, behavioral data—flows outward.

India's electronics import bill is already projected to cross a staggering \$120 billion by the end of this fiscal cycle. Now, factor in the cost of artificial intelligence. A single cluster of top-tier Nvidia GPUs costs tens of millions of dollars, and Indian enterprises are currently forced to rent this compute power by the hour from American hyper-scalers. If we do not cultivate our own foundational model weights, we will add a crippling digital trade deficit to that ledger. We risk becoming a vast workforce of diligent prompt engineers rather than the architects of original systems.

The Closing Window on Data Leverage

Historically, India's greatest leverage in technology negotiations has been its demographic scale. We represent the largest open data market in the world, processing over 13 billion digital public infrastructure transactions every single month. Global AI giants have extracted this Indian data to train their models for free.

This is where India should worry. The frontier of artificial intelligence is moving away from scraping raw human data.

The next generation of models increasingly relies on synthetic data—data autonomously generated by algorithms training themselves. As this happens, our demographic advantage will precipitously diminish. Once algorithms no longer need our data to become smarter, our primary bargaining chip disappears.

We must urgently enforce a Data-for-Tech framework. If foreign entities wish to utilize the high-quality datasets generated by the Indian populace, they must be compelled to provide more than localized software services. They must share the underlying blueprints: the model weights and the source code. Access to our digital market must be priced as a high-value geopolitical trade.

A Hard-Headed Policy Blueprint If India wants to transition from diplomatic optimism to hard-headed execution, it must adopt an uncompromising approach:

1. **A Sovereign GPU Reserve:** India must establish a state-backed stockpile of high-end compute. This requires unlocking institutional capital to secure long-term, non-

revocable licenses for cutting-edge hardware, insulating domestic startups from sudden export control shocks.

2. **IP Co-Development Mandates:** Any foreign firm receiving taxpayer-funded incentives under the India Semiconductor Mission must be legally required to enter into binding IP co-development agreements with Indian entities. We need the design blueprints, not just the assembly instructions.

3. **Targeted Chip Design Scaling:** India must aggressively scale up its Design Linked Incentives (DLI), offering massive R&D tax credits specifically for fabless chip design firms. The objective is clear: own the intellectual architecture of the chips we are currently paying to package.

4. **The "Indi-LLM" Initiative:** We require a heavily funded national mission to build foundational models trained explicitly on Indian languages and legal frameworks, with the core weights stored domestically. This guarantees that if external APIs are ever restricted, India's digital nervous system continues to function.

The global technological order is currently being recalibrated. The margin for error is zero. Ribbon cuttings are easy. Technological leverage is harder. To move beyond the role of a diligent subcontractor, India must recognise that true autonomy is the product of calculated hedging and aggressive IP ownership. We must ensure that when we build for the future, we are building on ground that we unquestionably control.

Author is a physicist at the University of North Carolina at Chapel Hill and a columnist on AI, infrastructure, and global systems

India's pathbreaking digital technologies accelerate forensic sciences

India has created e-forensics platforms thereby connecting the various laboratories across distinct locations



DR T SENTHIL SIVA SUBRAMANIAN

India stands unique and tall in innovation, intellects, infrastructures, and most importantly the smart industrialisation. India has achieved the global leadership position by consciously, thoughtfully, and strongly adapting the best mantra — Viswa Guru, Viswa Sevak and Viswa Rakshak.

India's major strength lies in innovations created by intellects who introduces differences in research and implementation through creative mindset, problem solving capabilities and most importantly the right intention to serve for the society through community-based culture.

India is fully committed to protecting, preserving, and potentially using the data for the social cause. This has given special priority to protect users against cybercrime and preventing accidents thereby ensuring the safety and security of citizens of our nation. The launch of digital India especially the Digitisation and digitalisation have filled the gaps and opened several avenues in the field of digital forensic sciences. The market trends in India's digital forensics see an enhanced trajectory, which is projected to grow at a CAGR of 40 percent, which would reach ₹11,829 crore (\$1.39 billion) by FY 2029-30. This statistic is more than three times the global average of 11 per cent [References: Deloitte-DSCI report 2025]

India's present era is an age of emerging science and technology that could be thoughtfully and smartly utilised for safety and security especially in the field of forensic sciences. India has created a big breakthrough in groundbreaking technologies in the field of semiconductor technologies, quantum technologies and most important-



ly the blockchain and cyber securities. India's technological innovation is rewriting the emerging forensic sciences especially exploring advanced quantum science integrated with artificial intelligence, 3D printing, SCADA and most importantly the advanced supercomputing algorithms.

The emerging technologies and infrastructures in our nation have bridged the gap between the crime scenes and court rooms in India. India is on the maintaining to build its throughout the globe for forensic to meet the high demands of maintain and storing data in the safety mode. These Vocal for Local data centers could find potential applications in the field of crimes and accidents.

India's infrastructure in forensic science and technologies.

India has established first Central Fingerprint Bureau in 19th century (1897). Since then, India has strengthened its forensic sciences investigation through creating crime and toxicological laboratories at various locations. Presently our nation has 07 in-house central forensic laboratories under Directorate of Forensic Science Services, thirty-two state forensic science laboratories and additionally has ninety-seven regional laboratories.

India has created e-Forensics platforms thereby connecting the various laboratories across distinct locations. India thoughtfully taken an important initiative to preserve the wildlife through adapting the best practices of DNA analysis program at the Wildlife Institute established in Dehra Dun.

Forensic science: Skillng avenues in India

India has established world's first and only dedicated University called as National Forensic Sciences University fully focused for Forensic sciences in the state of Gujarat.

The increasing crimes and accidents throughout the globe have created huge avenues for forensic investigators across worldwide. Sciences to meet the demands of skilled manpower in the field of forensic sciences, The school of open learning of National Forensic Sciences University, an institution of national importance and pioneering institutions is creating big avenues for youth to reskill and upskill in the domain of forensic science and technology through Massive Open Online Courses (MOOC), certificate and short term courses.

The courses have greater flexibility for the young talents through ease of learning via self-pace learning mode. The courses focus on creating awareness about cyber security, fundamentals of window malware, foundation on IoT security and Forensics and many more.

It also offers variety of certificate courses on crime scene management, clinical and forensic toxicology. Additionally, it offers several undergraduate, post graduate and research programs for students. The School of Forensic Science & Risk Management at Raksha University at Lavad, Gandhinagar is conducting variety of capacity building programs for students, Police and Paramilitary forces keeping in view of the purpose of security of our nation.

Way forward for forensic sciences in India

Viksit Bharat@2047 has creating huge opportunity for innovative intellects and emerging infrastructures in India. Ministry of Home Affairs and Cooperation has taken a huge initiative to create a dedicated National Forensic Data Centre in our nation to keep a focus on 'Women Safety. In addition to this, a National Forensic University which would function as Centre of excellence in forensic and allied sciences has been planned to build in the state of Odisha. The institutions and innovative facilities to be established forensic sciences will further strengthen the investigative programs, especially cyber and forensic crime through qualitative and quantitative research initiatives. Uttar Pradesh State Institute of Forensic Science (UPSIFS), Lucknow is aiming to strengthen the investigative infrastructure through establishing first of its kind Centre of Excellence in quantum computing in collaboration with QNU Labs under the National Quantum Mission, 3D additive manufacturing facilities, and SCADA.

Quantum machine learning algorithms can break the complex chain of cybercrime data. It has also been planned to establish 3D printing and additive rapid prototyping facilities for forensic facial reconstruction, ballistic reconstruction, and most importantly creating and reconstructing a 3D simulating environment of crime and accident scenes. These technologies will function as a Kavach for national security and digital trust.

Author is a Head, Institute Industry Interface Program, Hindustan College of Science and Technology, Mathura

Militants kill defence minister of Mali, seize towns

WILSON MCMAKIN
■ Dakar (Senegal)

Mali's defence minister was killed in a sweeping attack by jihadis and rebels who seized several towns and military bases, authorities said , the latest violence in the junta-run country that has long battled militants linked to al-Qaida and the Islamic State group as well as a separatist rebellion in the north.

The Malian Government confirmed the death of the defence chief, General Sadio Camara, in a post on the defence ministry's Facebook page, and expressed its condolences to his family. State-run television also broadcast the announcement of his death by spokesman General

Issa Ousmane Coulibaly. Mali was struck on Saturday by one of the biggest coordinated attacks on its army in the capital, Bamako, and several other cities and towns in an assault that also challenged Mali's security partner, Russia, which has forces on the ground in the West African country.

The Government said the attacks appear to be over, but several questions remain, including who was in control of a key northern city that the separatists claim to have taken.

The Government has not provided a death toll from Saturday and previously said only that at least 16 people were wounded in what it



denounced as terror attacks.

The separatists have been fighting for years to create an independent state in northern Mali, while al-Qaida and IS-aligned militants have been fighting the Government for over a decade. According to the

Government statement, Camara's residence was targeted by a suicide car bomber and other attackers on Saturday. "He engaged in an exchange of fire with the assailants, some of whom he managed to neutralise," it said. "During intense clashes,

he was wounded and then transported to the hospital, where he unfortunately succumbed to his injuries."

A spokesperson for the separatist Tuareg-led Azawad Liberation Front, or FLA, said the Russian Africa Corps troops and the Malian military withdrew from the city of Kidal following the attack on Saturday, after an agreement was reached for their peaceful exit.

"Kidal is declared free," said FLA spokesperson Mohamed El Maouloud Ramadan. In a statement on state TV late Sunday night, Gen. Oumar Diarra, head of the armed forces, confirmed that the Malian army had left the city and that its forces were repositioning in Anefis,

a city about 100 kilometres (62 miles) south of Kidal.

The separatists have been fighting for years to create an independent state in northern Mali. Kidal had long served as a stronghold of the rebellion before being taken by Malian Government forces and Russian mercenaries in 2023. Its capture marked a significant symbolic victory for the junta and its Russian allies.

Saturday's wave of attacks was the first time the separatists joined forces with the al-Qaida-linked group JNIM, which said it was also part of the attack on Kidal and had also targeted a town outside of the capital of Bamako and three other cities on Saturday. (AP)

First woman archbishop visits Pope Leo in Vatican City



NICOLE WINFIELD ■ Vatican City

The Archbishop of Canterbury, Sarah Mullally, arrived at the Vatican on Monday for an audience with Pope Leo XIV, making her first foreign visit since being installed as the first woman leader of the Church of England and spiritual leader of millions of Anglicans around the world. Mullally, whose appointment has split the already divided Anglican Community, arrived early to meet with Leo in his library. Later, they were to go to into the Urban VIII Chapel inside the Apostolic palace for what the Vatican said would be a "moment of prayer".

Mullally is on a four-day pilgrimage to Rome that has included visits to the main pontifical basilicas, where she has prayed at the tombs

of Saints Peter and Paul and met with top Vatican officials.

Lambeth Palace says her visit is designed "to strengthen Anglican-Roman Catholic relations through prayer, personal encounter, and formal theological dialogue. It aims to deepen bonds of communion, affirm a shared witness, and encourage ongoing collaboration at both global and local levels." Anglicans split from Rome in 1534, when English King Henry VIII was refused a marriage annulment. Despite a formal theological dialogue that began in the 1960s, big differences remain, especially over the Church of England's decision to ordain women. The Roman Catholic Church reserves the priesthood for men. (AP)

Indian FS likely to visit Nepal next month



SHIRISH B PRADHAN
■ Kathmandu

Foreign Secretary Vikram Misri is likely to travel to Nepal next month, the first high-level visit from India after the formation of the Balendra Shah-led Government in March, official sources here said on Monday. The visit is expected to take place in the first half of May, the official sources at Nepal's Foreign Affairs Ministry said.

The exact date and details of the visit are not yet finalised. Bilateral relations and the review of India-funded projects will be on the agenda during Misri's visit.

Earlier this month, External Affairs Minister S Jaishankar met his Nepalese counterpart Shisir Khanal in Mauritius on the sidelines of the Indian

Ocean Conference, where they held discussions over bilateral relations and mutual cooperation.

During the meeting with Khanal, Jaishankar proposed sending Misri to Kathmandu to understand the priorities of the new Government, the sources added. Prime Minister Narendra Modi invited Balendra Shah to India in his congratulatory message after Shah assumed the charge of the top executive position of the Himalayan nation in late March.

The visit by Foreign Secretary Misri is also expected to prepare the grounds for the visit of the Nepalese Prime Minister Shah to India in the near future.

The official announcement regarding the visit is yet to be made. (PTI)

Water riots: 42 people killed in Chad

ASSOCIATED PRESS
■ N'Djamena

At least 42 people were killed in eastern Chad after a clash between two families over a water point escalated into a cycle of reprisals, the country's deputy prime minister said late Sunday.

Limane Mahamat said during a visit to the village of Igote, in the Wadi Fira province, near the border with Sudan, where the clashes occurred on Saturday, that 42 people were killed and 10 wounded. He said those injured were evacuated to the provincial health centre.

Mahamat said the cycle of reprisals had spread over a roughly large area, prompting an intervention by the army. He said the "swift response" by the military helped contain the clashes and that the situation is now "under control." The deputy prime minister announced the launch of a 'customary mediation' process in the



village and of judicial proceedings to determine criminal responsibility. Intercommunal clashes over resources are common in the Central African country. Last year, clashes between farmers and herders in southwestern Chad left 42 people dead and several

homes burned. Mahamat said the Government will take "all necessary measures" to prevent a destabilisation of the border area.

Chad's eastern provinces have for several months been hosting refugees fleeing the war in Sudan and are facing increasing

pressure on resources and security. In February, Chad closed its border with "until further notice," calling it an attempt to limit the spread of conflict into its territory after multiple crossings by fighters with the warring Sudanese factions.

US military strike on drug boat kills 3 in Pacific Ocean



Pete Hegseth speaking to members of the media during a press briefing at the Pentagon in Washington

ASSOCIATED PRESS
■ Washington

The latest US military strike on a boat accused of ferrying drugs in the eastern Pacific Ocean killed three people Sunday, according to a social media post by US Southern Command.

The Trump administration's campaign of blowing up alleged drug-trafficking vessels in Latin American waters has gone on since early September and killed at least 186 people in total.

Other strikes have taken place in the Caribbean Sea. The military has not provided evidence that any of

the vessels were carrying drugs. After Sunday's attack, Southern Command posted a video on X showing a boat moving swiftly in the water before a explosion left it in flames.

It repeated previous statements by saying it had targeted the alleged drug traffickers along known smuggling routes.

The attacks began as the US built up its largest military presence in the region in generations and came months ahead of the raid in January that captured then-Venezuelan President Nicolas Maduro.

Russian drone attack wounds 14 in Odesa



HANNA ARHIROVA ■ Kyiv

A Russian drone attack before dawn on Ukraine's southern city of Odesa wounded 14 people, including two children, authorities said on Monday, in the latest barrage of civilian areas that have been a hallmark of Moscow's full-scale invasion, now in its fifth year. The drones hit residential neighborhoods and civilian infrastructure, said the head of the city's administration, Serhiy Iysak. Russia has repeatedly targeted Odesa, a key Black Sea port for Ukraine.

Five of the injured, most of them with shrapnel wounds, were hospitalized, according to the head of the regional military administration, Oleh Kiper.

Meanwhile, a Ukrainian drone strike killed two people in the Russian-occupied part of Ukraine's Kherson region, Moscow-installed Gov. Vladimir Saldo said Monday. A man and a woman in their 70s died in the village of Dnipropryany, the European Union has approved a 90-billion-euro (\$106-billion) loan to Ukraine, and the EU intends to place more sanctions on Moscow. (AP)

ful guided aerial bombs and around 60 missiles of various types at Ukraine.

Ukraine's wartime development of cutting-edge military technology means it is intercepting more than 90% of the drones that Russia launches, Zelenskyy claimed in a post on X. However, Ukraine needs more American-made Patriot air defense missiles that are able to shoot down Russia's ballistic missiles.

Ukraine has recently been helping countries in the Middle East and Gulf region, which are countering attacks on their territory by Iranian drones, with know-how amid the Iran war.

Also, Norway is the latest European country to enter into a joint drone manufacturing agreement with Kyiv, Ukraine's Defense Ministry said on Monday.

Zelenskyy noted a recent raft of good news for Ukraine: NATO partners, excluding the United States, have contributed to a financial arrangement to buy American weapons, the European Union has approved a 90-billion-euro (\$106-billion) loan to Ukraine, and the EU intends to place more sanctions on Moscow. (AP)

PUBLIC NOTICE

Notice is hereby given on behalf of Mrs. Mridula Tyagi, Mrs. Sunaina Tyagi & Mrs. Suresh Tyagi who are present owner and in possession of Property Bearing No. F-342, Land area measuring 22 Sq. Yds., out of Kharsa No. 670m, situated in the area of Village Basal Darapur, colony known as Sudarshan Park, New Delhi (hereinafter called the "said property"). Mr. Hari Om Tyagi was the owner of said property through registered Sale Deed dated 26/11/2015 executed by Smt. Sonia duly registered in the office of SR&L, Saira Tower, Delhi as registration No. 10282, Addl. Book No. 1, Page Nos. 184-191, Volume No. 22504, Dated 26/11/2015. After the demise of Mr. Hari Om Tyagi the said property transferred through succession/Legal Her Certificate in the name of Mrs. Mridula Tyagi, Mrs. Sunaina Tyagi & Mrs. Suresh Tyagi. Now Shri RAM Kihladi intend to Purchase and mortgage the said property from Vastu Housing Finance Corporation Ltd. To comply the requirements of BANK/NBFC, we give this public notice that if any Person having any type of claim/right/title/interest/creating mortgage over the said property, may inform in writing, at the address mentioned below, about his objections, within 07 days from today, failing which it shall be presumed that the said property is free from all type of Encumbrances, lien etc. Lucum Legal LLP N-161, Ground Floor, Saira Tower, Gautam Nagar Near Yusuf Sarai Community Centre New Delhi-110049 Contact @ 011-40045316 & 41667327

PUBLIC NOTICE

Notice is hereby given on behalf of Mr. Yushuf Khan who is Purchasing of Residential Plot of land area measuring 74 Sq. yards i.e. 61.87 Sq. meter, out of Kharsa No. 64, Situated in Village Akbarpur, Beharampur Pargana Loni Tehsil and District Ghazalabad, UP, from Mr. Badruddin who owned the said Property, through Sale Deed dated 16.11.2023 executed by (1) Mrs. Sharifan, (2) Mr. Ifraan, (3) Mr. Gulam, (4) Mr. Hassam, (5) Mr. Jannudeen duly registered in the office of SR&L, Saira Tower, Delhi as registration No. 12288, Addl. Book No. 1, Page Nos. 255-256, Volume No. 10528, Dated 16.11.2023. Now Mr. Yushuf Khan and Mrs. Anisha Khan intend to purchase and mortgage the subject property for the financial assistance from VASTU HOUSING FINANCE CORPORATION LTD That, Photocopy of SMC of Late Bade Shah and Photocopy of Succession/Mutation Order issued by the concerned authority in favor of (1) Mrs. Sharifan, (2) Mr. Ifraan, (3) Mr. Gulam, (4) Mr. Hassam, (5) Mr. Jannudeen has been lost/ misplaced/ not available. To comply the requirements of BANK/NBFC, we give this public notice that if any Person having any type of claim/right/title/interest/creating mortgage over the said property, may inform in writing, at the address mentioned below, about his objections, within 7 days from today, failing which it shall be presumed that the said property is free from all type of Encumbrances, lien etc. Lucum Legal LLP N-161, Ground Floor, Saira Tower, Gautam Nagar Near Yusuf Sarai Community Centre New Delhi-110049 Contact @ 011-40045316 & 41667327

AXIS BANK LTD.		Branch Office - Axis Bank Limited, SBB LOAN CENTER SCO-221, 2nd Floor, Paramjeet Tower, Sector 12, Karnal-132001
Corporate Office: 3rd Floor, Block-9, Bombay Dyeing Mills Compound, Pandurang Budhakar Marg, Worli, Mumbai-400 025, Registered Office: Trishul, 3rd floor, opposite Samartheswar Temple, Law garden, Ellisbridge, Ahmedabad-380006		
DEMAND NOTICE U/s 13(2) OF SECURITIZATION AND RECONSTRUCTION OF FINANCIAL ASSETS AND ENFORCEMENT OF SECURITY INTEREST ACT, 2002		
Whereas the borrowers/co-borrowers/guarantors/mortgagors mentioned hereunder had availed the financial assistance from Axis Bank Ltd. We state that despite having availed the financial assistance, the borrowers/guarantors/mortgagors have committed various defaults in repayment of interest and principal amounts as per due dates. The account has been classified as Non-Performing Asset on the respective dates mentioned hereunder in accordance with the directives/guidelines issued by Reserve Bank of India, consequent to the Authorized Officer of Axis Bank Ltd. under Securitization and Reconstruction of Financial Assets and Enforcement of Security Interest Act, 2002 & in exercise of powers conferred under Section 13(2) read with Rule 3 of Security Interest (Enforcement) Rules, 2002 issued Demand Notices on respective dates mentioned herein below under Section 13(2) of SARFAESI Act, 2002 calling upon the following borrowers / guarantors / mortgagors to repay the amount mentioned in the notices together with further interest at the contractual rate on the amount mentioned in the notices and incidental expenses, cost, charges etc. until the date of payment within 60 days from the date of receipt of notices.		
The notices issued to them on their last known addresses have returned un-served and as such they are hereby informed by way of public notice about the same.		
Name Of Co-Borrower And Guarantor Name / Address	NPA Date	2. Date Of Demand Notice
	3. Outstanding Amount	4. Loan Amount
1. Mr. Narendar S/o Mr. Dharman Pal, R/o Khawat No. 936, Khata No. 1251, Killa No. 57/21 (G-16), Gandhi Nagar, Ganaur, Distt. Sonapat - 131101, Haryana; Also At - Mr. Narendar S/o Mr. Dharman Pal, R/o Qtr. No. 15, Type-III, Sec-A-5, Narela, Delhi - 110036, New Delhi; 2. Mrs. Sheetal Devi W/o Mr. Narendar, R/o Khawat No. 936, Khata No. 1251, Killa No. 57/21 (G-16), Gandhi Nagar, Ganaur, Distt. Sonapat - 131101, Haryana; Also At - Mrs. Sheetal Devi W/o Mr. Narendar, R/o Qtr. No. 15, Type-III, Sec-A-5, Narela, Delhi - 110036, New Delhi	1. 10-Apr-2025	2. 16-Apr-2026
Property Address Of Secured Assets: All Piece & Parcels Of Plot Measuring 160 Sq. Yards, 5/136 Share Out Of 6 Kanal 16 Marla, Comprised In Khawat No. 936, Khata No. 1251, Must. & Killa No. 57/21 (G-16), Situated At - Waka Rakba Ganaur, Mohalla Gandhi Nagar, Within M.C Limits Ganaur, Distt. Sonapat, Haryana, Owned By Mrs. Sheeta Devi Vide Sale Deed No. 3906 Dated 02-Dec-2021. Boundaries North - Property Of Ved Parkash, South - Property Of Parnila, East - Street, West - House Of Ram Kanner	3. Rs. 40,44,925.83/- (Rs. Forty Lakh Forty Four Thousand Nine Hundred Twenty Five And Eighty Three Paise Only)	4. Rs. 43,36,602/- (Forty Three Lakhs Thirty Six Thousand Six Hundred Two Only)
In the circumstances as aforesaid, the notice is hereby given to the above borrowers, co-borrowers and/ or their guarantors (where ever applicable) to pay the outstanding dues as mentioned above along with future interest and applicable charges within 60 days from the date of the publication of this notice failing which further steps will be taken after the expiry of 60 days of the date of this notice against the secured assets including taking possession of the secured assets of the borrowers and the mortgagors under Section 13(4) of Securitization and Re-construction of Financial Assets and Enforcement of Security Interest Act, 2002 and the applicable rules thereunder. Please note that under Section 13 (1) of the said Act, no Borrower shall, transfer by way of sale, lease or otherwise any of his secured assets referred to in the notice, without prior written consent of the secured creditor.		
Date: 28.04.2026, Place: Haryana	Sd/-, Authorized Officer, Axis Bank Ltd.	

The Pioneer

Classified

CHANGE OF NAME

I, No. 15440986W Nk(DVR) Rajesh Pujari, R/o- H.No. 3/85, Near Bus Stop, Shirgaon, Belgaum, Karnataka- 591214, in my service documents my Father's Name is wrongly written as Birappa whereas his correct Name is Birappa Pujari, which may be amended accordingly.

PD(965/C) I, No.15440986W Nk(DVR) Rajesh Pujari, R/o- H.No. 3/85, Near Bus Stop, Shirgaon, Belgaum, Karnataka- 591214, in my service documents my Mother's Name is wrongly written as Malu whereas her correct Name is Mallava Pujari, which may be amended accordingly.

PD(966/C) I, No.15749789N Nk Bandger Tanaji Laxman, R/o- Vill/PO- Budhgaon, Teh- Miraj, Dist- Sangli, Maharashtra - 416304, have changed my son's name from Bandger Devansh Tanaji to Bandgar Devansh Tanaji, vide affidavit dated 27/04/2026 before Notary Public Delhi.

PD(967/C) I, L Yogachithra, W/o JC- 769886A Sub/Maj Lakshmi Narayanan B, R/o- 1011 Jesintha Mary Nagar Thirukanurpatti, Thanjavur, Tamilnadu- 613303, have changed my name from L Yogachithra to Yogachithra L, vide affidavit dated 25/04/2026 before Notary Public Delhi.

PD(968/C) I, No.15749789N Nk Bandger Tanaji Laxman, R/o- Vill/PO- Budhgaon, Teh- Miraj, Dist- Sangli, Maharashtra - 416304, have changed my son's name from Bandger Shreyansh Tanaji to Bandgar Shriyansh Tanaji, vide affidavit dated 27/04/2026 before Notary Public Delhi.

PD(969/C) I, Atul Kumar S/o Late Rajpal Gupta, Resident of K1-2A, Ground Floor, Kavi Nagar, Ghaziabad U.P. -201002 have changed my name from Atul Kumar to Atul Kumar Gupta. Henceforth I would be known by the name of Atul Kumar Gupta for all future purposes.

Public Notice / General Information

The general public is hereby informed that my client has lawfully purchased the below-described land/property/agricultural land from 1. Sh. Vedpal S/o Sh. Kishan R/o House No. D-854, Ward No. 9, Shyam Patti, Norangabad, Mandkola (217), Distt. Palwal-121103, Haryana ("Seller No.1") 2. Sh. Vinod Kumar S/o Sh. Jagdish R/o Dubaul (194), Mewat-122103, Haryana ("Seller No.2") collectively referred as "Sellers". The details of the said land of the Seller are as under: Khawat/Khata No. 1452/1443 Rectangle No. 117 Killa No. 16(8-0), 25/1(7-3), Rectangle No.159 Killa No. 4(9-7), 5/1(5-13), 6/1/1(3-2), 14(8-15), total fields 6 land measuring 42 Kanal 0 Marla 1/10 Share 4 Kanal 4 Marla and Khawat/Khata No. 1648/1635 Rectangle No. 191 Killa No. 20(8-0), 21/1(6-0), 21/1(6-0), 21/2(2-0), 22(7-13), Rectangle No. 192 Killa No. 14(8-0), 16(8-0), 17(8-0), Rectangle No. 202 Killa No. 4/3(3-0), 5(8-0), 6(8-0), 7/1(2-17), 15(8-0), 16(8-0), Rectangle No.203, Killa No. 1(8-0), 2/1(3-1), 11(8-0), 20(8-0), 21/1(2-3), total fields 18 land measuring 114 Kanal 14 Marla 38/1147 Share 3 Kanal 16 Marla i.e. total land measuring 8 Kanal 0 Marla ("Seller-1") 2. Khawat/Khata No.1455/1446, Rectangle No.117, Killa No. 7(3-4), 13(4-6), 14(8-0), 15/2(2-19) Rectangle No.159 Killa No. 6/2(2-18), 15/1(2-17), 15/2/1(0-15), 16/2(2-18) 17(8-12), total fields 9 land measuring 34 Kanal 19 Marla 2/9 Share 7 Kanal 15.33 Marla and Khawat/Khata No. 1455/9/1446/1 Rectangle No. 192 Killa No. 24/1(1-10), 25(8-0), total fields 2 acres measuring 9 Kanal 10 Marla 2/9 Share 2 Kanal 2.2 Marla i.e. total land measuring 9 Kanal 17.55 Marla ("Seller-2") Situated in the revenue estate of Village Khalipur, Tehsil Indri Distt. Palwal. ("Scheduled Property/Land")

The said purchase has been undertaken by my Client with due care and proper due diligence. The said Public notice is being issued, so as to ascertain and invite disclosure of any hidden claims, rights, or disputes, if any, relating to the said Scheduled Property/Land. The Seller has further declared that the said Scheduled Property/Land is completely free from all kinds of encumbrances including but not limited to charges, mortgages, loans, claims, disputes, litigations, attachments, stay orders, ceiling proceedings, acquisition, surplus land, government dues, or any third-party rights or claims whatsoever, and that the title of the Scheduled Property/Land is clear, clean, and marketable. The Seller has further represented and warranted that the Seller has clear, valid, absolute, and marketable right, title, interest and ownership and was in actual, vacant, peaceful physical and legal possession of the said Scheduled Property/Land and that no prior, existing, or subsisting agreement, transaction, understanding, or arrangement of any nature whatsoever, whether oral or written, in respect of the said Scheduled Property/Land has been entered into with any third party in respect thereof. It was also declared that no case, proceeding, or dispute in respect of the said Scheduled Property/Land is pending before any court, tribunal, or any competent legal or quasi-legal authority/forum.

Therefore, any person, bank, financial institution, government department, or any other party, firm, company, or entity, who has or claims to have any valid, legal, or equitable right, title, interest, claim, demand, charge, or encumbrance of any nature whatsoever in respect of the said Scheduled Property/Land—whether by way of sale, gift, lease, tenancy, license, exchange, partition, mortgage, lien, inheritance, succession, agreement, litigation, decree, stay order, possession, or otherwise—shall intimate the undersigned in writing, along with full particulars of such claim/objection and supporting documentary evidence, within fifteen (15) days from the date of publication of this notice.

In case no information or objection is received within the stipulated period, it shall be conclusively and lawfully presumed that there exists no encumbrances including but not limited to third-party claim, right, or dispute etc. in respect of the said Scheduled Property/Land and my client shall be legally deemed to have clear, valid, absolute, and marketable right, title, interest and ownership therein along with actual, vacant, peaceful physical and legal possession thereon, entitling my Client to lawfully proceed, sell and deal with the Scheduled Property/Land.

Thereafter, any such claim, objection, or dispute shall be treated as legally untenable, deemed to have been waived, and my client shall not be held liable for the same in any civil or criminal proceedings before any court, tribunal, or any competent legal or quasi-legal authority/forum. The Scheduled Property/Land shall be deemed to include all rights, easements, pathways, appurtenances, standing crops, trees, plants, constructions, fences, boundary walls, etc. attached thereto.

The general public is hereby cautioned not to deal or enter into any transaction concerning the Schedule Property/Land with any person, party, or entity, failing which such transaction shall be at their own cost, risk and consequences. This public notice is issued on behalf of my Client with complete bona-fide, transparency, and good faith so as to safeguard my client against any future allegations of fraud, misrepresentation, or collusion or any other allegations whatsoever in relation to the Schedule property. This notice is being issued without prejudice to any of the legal rights, contentions and remedies available to my client under applicable law.

Durga Lal - Advocate, Law Consultant Office, Office No. 57 Nehru Ground Near Main Post Office, B.K. Chowk, NIT Faridabad, Haryana. ENROL. No. PH/563/2022 Mobile No.7303834091, Email- lawconsultantsoffice@gmail.com

▼ PROSPECT

Dr Akhilesh Das Gupta Law School to host 1st All India Moot Court Competition

The Dr Akhilesh Das Gupta Institute of Professional Studies (Dr Akhilesh Das Gupta Law School) is set to organise its 1st All India Moot Court Competition on April 28-29. The event is being conducted under the able guidance of Alka Das, Chairperson of the BBD Group, and Viraj Sagar Das, President. The inaugural ceremony will be graced by Justice (Retd) M Karpaga Vinayagam, former Chief Justice of the Jharkhand High Court, as the Chief Guest. The valedictory ceremony will be honored by the presence of Dr T R Naval, Additional District & Sessions Judge (Retd), as the Chief Guest. The theme for this year's competition is "Deepfake Technology and Cyber Crime," a highly relevant and pressing issue in today's digital age. This prestigious national-level competition aims to provide law students with practical exposure to real courtroom procedures. Participants will present legal arguments before experienced judges and legal experts, thereby enhancing their advocacy, legal research, and analytical skills. On this occasion, Dr Vijay Dheer (Director, Coordination), Dr Niranjan Bhattacharyya (Director), Pankhuri Aggarwal (Assistant Director, HR), and Professor (Dr) Jogi Ram Sharma (Principal, ADGLS) jointly stated that the competition is being organized on a grand scale, with participation from 40 teams representing reputed law universities and colleges across the India, comprising approximately 120 participants. Each team will consist of two speakers and one researcher, who will present arguments for both the petitioner/appellant and the respondent. The competition will be conducted over two days and will include preliminary rounds, semi-finals, and the final round. The institute also offers BA LL B (Hons.) and BBA LL B (Hons), which are five-year integrated law programmes affiliated with Guru Gobind Singh Indraprastha University.



Dr Priti Adani marks 25 years of Adani Public School

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Ahmedabad

Adani Public School (APS), Mundra, has completed 25 years of shaping young minds, marking its Silver Jubilee with a deeply moving celebration that brought together students, alumni, parents and educators in a shared moment of pride and reflection. The occasion also marked the inauguration of an indoor sports complex and a state-of-the-art auditorium in Kutch, reinforcing the school's focus on holistic development.

The celebrations were led by Dr Priti Adani, Chairperson of the Adani Foundation, the social welfare and development arm of the Adani Group, whose vision for the school took shape in 2001. While the project was already underway, the Gujarat earthquake accelerated its execution, with education emerging as a source of stability and hope for the community.

Marking the milestone, Gautam Adani Chairman of the Adani Group, said, "As Adani Public School completes 25 years, this moment celebrates far more than an institution. It honours dreams nurtured and futures shaped.



Dr Priti Adani

At this milestone, my hope is that every student leaves with the confidence to dream without limits, the resilience to rise after every fall, and the humility to give back. Every child here carries the promise of India's future, and it is this promise that inspires purposeful action."

Reflecting on the journey, Dr Priti Adani said, "Twenty-five years ago, a simple thought took root on the windswept coast of Kutch, that every child deserves an education that opens a window to the world. What began as a small ray of hope has grown into a radiant lamp, illuminating lives and communities. This journey

belongs to every teacher who believed, every parent who trusted, and every child who dared to dream."

The celebrations unfolded as a tribute to this journey, beginning with a traditional welcome by Bagpiper Band and National Cadet Corps (NCC) cadets. Innovation and creativity came alive through Science, Technology, Engineering and Mathematics (STEM) and robotics exhibits, alongside curated art workstations and performances that reflected a culture of inquiry and expression.

The occasion also marked the inauguration of an indoor sports complex, featuring facilities for badminton, pick-

leball and table tennis, along with a state-of-the-art auditorium with a seating capacity of 558, making it among the largest of its kind in Kutch. These additions reinforce the school's commitment to holistic development. A specially curated documentary traced the school's journey from its early years in Mundra to its emergence as a leading institution in the region. A commemorative coffee table book capturing the institution's journey and milestones was also released.

From an initial cohort of 233 students and 27 teachers to a thriving institution with over 2,300 students and more than 100 educators, the school continues to be anchored in its belief in holistic education and dignity in equality.

A defining moment of the event was Dr Adani's interaction with alumni, parents and student achievers, underscoring the enduring bond between the institution and the community it serves.

As the event concluded with the school anthem, the celebration became more than a milestone. It became a reaffirmation of a shared purpose shaped over 25 years.

NTPC-GE handled operations at Chhattisgarh boiler blast site: Vedanta chief



Anil Agarwal

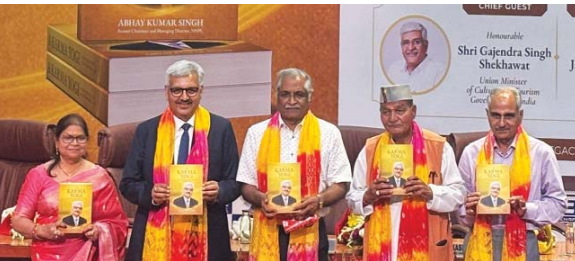
PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Nearly two weeks after Chhattisgarh power plant blast killed 25 people, Vedanta Chairman Anil Agarwal on Monday said the entire responsibility for the operations and maintenance (O&M) of the facility was entrusted with NGSL, a joint venture between power giant NTPC and GE.

"What weighs heavily on my mind is this: at our Athena plant, we had put in place the highest standards of safety. The entire responsibility was entrusted to NGSL, a partnership between NTPC and GE, among the most respected and trusted institutions in India. The contractors, the teams, the technical expertise, all were theirs.

"It was on the strength of this trust that we had confidently outsourced the plant's operations and maintenance. And yet, this unfortunate tragedy occurred," Agarwal said in a social media post.

Autobiography of ex-CMD NHPC Abhay Singh released



PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

A remarkable new book titled "A Karma Yogi - The Untold Realities of Life in India's C-PSU" authored by Abhay Kumar Singh, former Chairman and Managing Director (CMD) of NHPC Limited was formally released on 26 April 2026 in New Delhi in the presence of distinguished dignitaries. The book is an autobiography of Abhay Kumar Singh and presents his journey from his early life to his tenure as CMD of NHPC. It offers valuable insights into the functioning of Central Public Sector Undertakings and the challenges responsibilities and leadership experiences associated with life in India's C-PSUs.

The book was released by P Uma Shankar Former Secretary, Ministry of Power; HK Paliwal, Principal Advisor to the Government of Arunachal Pradesh (GoAP) and Former Chief Secretary Govt of Arunachal Pradesh Kashi Singh Airy Ex-MLA and Founding Member of Uttarakhand Kranti Dal and Sudha Singh, wife of Abhay Kumar Singh.

Gajendra Singh Shekhawat Union Minister of Culture and Tourism joined the event virtually. Addressing the audience, he appreciated the book and praised the dedication of AK Singh towards his work and his significant contribution to the public sector and nation-building.

Speaking on the occasion, P Uma Shankar said that he had read the book and found it to be one of the most unique works providing deep insight into the functioning of Central PSUs and the challenges that officers confront during their careers. He appreciated the practical

experiences and leadership lessons documented in the book. HK Paliwal recalled the period when he was Chief Secretary of Arunachal Pradesh and AK Singh was CMD of NHPC Limited.

He emphasised that a major credit for the massive capacity addition plan of NHPC in Arunachal Pradesh goes to AK Singh who strongly advocated for NHPC and successfully convinced both the Central Government and the Government of Arunachal Pradesh that only NHPC had the capability to handle mega hydropower projects in the state. As a result today NHPC has established strong footprints in the development of hydropower in Arunachal Pradesh.

Speaking on the occasion, Abhay Kumar Singh stated that he had made a genuine effort in the book to describe his journey from his very early life until his tenure as CMD of NHPC so that the younger generation could learn important lessons on how one can contribute meaningfully to the betterment of one's organisation. Kashi Singh Airy recalled the challenging period in Uttarakhand when there were widespread protests against hydropower projects. He stated that it was A. K. Singh who amicably resolved various issues and concerns enabling NHPC to successfully execute the projects and move forward with development initiatives.

Smt. Sudha Singh shared that she feels fortunate to have accompanied her husband throughout the difficult phases of his career which enabled him to perform with greater dedication and confidence ultimately contributing to the success and growth of NHPC.

NCC Guwahati group launches Aqua Adventure Regatta 2026

TONY DAS ■ Guwahati

In a landmark initiative to promote adventure, leadership and watermanship among youth, the NCC Guwahati Group under the aegis of NCC North Eastern Region Directorate has launched Aqua Adventure Regatta 2026 for 100 NCC cadets from Assam at the picturesque Umiam Lake, Meghalaya. Organised by 1 Assam Battalion NCC from 24 April to 03 May 2026, the ten-day camp marks a first-of-its-kind initiative where Army and Air Wing NCC cadets from Assam are being imparted structured training in water-based adventure activities on such a scale.

For many cadets, this is their first exposure to boating and water



sports, making the camp a unique and transformative experience. The regatta has been conceptualised to instil courage, discipline, teamwork and water confidence among

the cadets, while also nurturing young talent for future adventure and competitive pursuits. The initiative adds a new dimension to adventure training within NCC and

seeks to broaden the horizons of youth development in the region.

During the camp, cadets are undergoing intensive training in sailing and kayaking under expert instructors from the Umiam Sailing Club, learning essential skills in seamanship, navigation, safety and team coordination in a challenging yet inspiring environment.

The Aqua Adventure Regatta reflects the commitment of the NCC to provide meaningful experiential learning opportunities that foster leadership, resilience and a spirit of adventure among the youth.

The camp is also reinforcing camaraderie, self-confidence and a sense of national pride among participating cadets.

DAILY SUDOKU

9				6		7	
							3
7	6	1		4			
		8	6				
5		7		2		4	1
					7	9	
				5		1	3
8							6
	7		4				2

DIFFICULTY RATING: ★★★★★☆

HOW TO SOLVE IT

Sudoku is a logic puzzle where you fill a 9x9 grid so that numbers 1 to 9 appear once in every row, column, and 3x3 box, using elimination and logical deduction- no maths involved.



SOLUTION (27.04.26)

5	2	6	4	8	3	9	7	1
7	3	1	6	5	9	8	4	2
4	8	9	1	2	7	6	5	3
8	6	2	9	3	5	4	1	7
9	5	7	2	1	4	3	6	8
1	4	3	7	6	8	2	9	5
6	7	8	3	4	1	5	2	9
2	1	5	8	9	6	7	3	4
3	9	4	5	7	2	1	8	6

DOUBLE CROSSWORD
TUESDAY | APRIL 28, 2026

1	2	3	4	5	6	7	8		
			9						
10						11			
13		14					15		16
17						18			
20	21					22		23	
24						25			
27								28	
30								31	

- ACROSS**
- Initially great deficit to smooth over (5)
 - Doubtful strength? (5)
 - Officer apt to be taken in by a murderer (7)
 - You may go ahead and run out of it! (4)
 - Two nil? (5)
 - Quietly stand up and remove by force (5)
 - The noted powers landowners possess (7)
 - Looking embarrassed in a predicament (3)
 - Ah, a sailor and a captain! (4)

- DOWN**
- It's wrong to lash out somewhat tardily (6)
 - Six-footer once thought divine (6)
 - He can't quite raise the mast (3)
 - They can brighten our nights (5)
 - Errand to a holy place? (7)
 - Nice change for a soccer star (4)
 - Get tough (6)
 - You could call him Rock (5)
 - It could get the golfer off to a flier! (5)
 - The beast takes a trip (5)
 - Bolt a plate while it's hot (5)

- One of those falling, in effect? (6)
- Bird needing a bit of chaperoning (5)
- Hang around and look at it with hesitation (6)
- Room for a holy man or sinner (4)
- Lug out of the arena (3)
- Robbers having wild parties (7)
- Royal maids, possibly (5)
- A Bohemian character to see and copy (5)
- In disrobing, might he preen himself? (5)
- A case of something legal to do (7)
- Cold that makes a companion unwell (5)
- She once bought a newspaper (5)

- Youthful figures (5)
- She finishes a drink for a Scot (5)
- Screw, shall we say? (7)
- Stupid, endless whirl of fashion (6)
- Truman, as writer (6)
- Unit of a U.S. soldier in a Spanish city (6)
- Poles pay out for a bloomer! (5)
- A factory unpleasant to go through (4)
- Tearaway type? (3)

SOLUTION (27.04.26)									
ACROSS					DOWN				
9, Ill humour	26, Be-hold-en	1, Fin-is-he-d	16, Shines		2, Slip on	27, Staunch			
10, Tear-away	28, Turn	3, L-one-so-me	26, Bee (B)		4, O-rdain	30, Red Cross			
12, I-M-P-S	31, Freedom	5, Start-led	31, F-O-O-tsore		6, Fair enough	32, M-eth-inks			
13, Rep-air	34, Un-settled	7, Caut-i-on	33, Striker		8, Cannon	35, Sal-O-o n			
14, R-etinu-e	36, Flowerpot	11, Readily	36, Fac-AD-e			37, (n)P-ris-on			
15, Hands down	38, Calling								
17, Land of nod	39, Recess								
18, Decline	40, Fi-fi (rev)								
20, Made up	41, Hope-less								
21, Fall	42, Dirty work								
24, Reve-aled									

कार्यालय नगर निगम, देहरादून

पत्रांक-103 / सागनिवि / नगनि / देहरादून / 2026-27 (ई-निविदा सूचना) दिनांक 24 / 04 / 2026
नगर निगम देहरादून द्वारा निम्नानुसार कार्य किये जाने हेतु पुन ई-निविदा आमंत्रित की जाती है तथा निविदा से सम्बन्धित समस्त विवरण ई-निविदा पोर्टल www.uktenders.gov.in से प्राप्त किये जा सकते हैं।

कार्य का विवरण	आगणन धनराशि (रुपये में)	निविदा शुल्क (18%) जी०एस०टी० सहित)	घरोहर राशि (2% of Estimated Cost)	निविदा डाले जाने की प्रारम्भिक एवं अंतिम तिथि	निविदा खोलने की तिथि एवं समय
1. वार्ड 04. राजपुर रोड, चन्द्रलोक बस्ती में श्री विजय सिंह पंवार के घर के पास सी०सी० सड़क एवं श्री किशन सिंह क्षेत्री शिरेपन हजार दो सौ रूपये के घर के पास सुरक्षा दीवार निर्माण कार्य।	27,53,200 /- (सत्ताईस लाख शिरेपन हजार दो सौ रूपये)	2,360 /- (दो हजार तीन सौ साठ रूपये)	55,100 /-		
2 नगर निगम मुख्य कार्यालय परिसर में बोर्ड मीटिंग हॉल की सीढ़ियों के बराबर लिफ्ट (एलीवेटर) लगाने का कार्य, स्टोर रूम का पुन निर्माण, मुख्य भवन की छत में टीन शेड, रिकॉर्ड रूम में टाईल लगाने एवं अन्य निर्माण / मरम्मत कार्य।	33,41,500 /- (तैतीस लाख इकतालीस हजार पाँच सौ रूपये)	2,950 /- (दो हजार नौ सौ पचास रूपये)	66,830 /-		
3 नगर निगम मुख्य कार्यालय परिसर स्थित पार्किंग में NCAP के अन्तर्गत इण्टरलॉकिंग टाईल बिछाने का कार्य।	55,49,800 /- (पचपन लाख उनचास हजार आठ सौ रूपये)	4,720 /- (चार हजार सात सौ बीस रूपये)	1,11,000 /-		
4. लोहारवाला मलिन बस्ती के पास स्थित पार्क का विकास कार्य।	23,11,000 /- (तेईस लाख ग्यारह हजार रूपये)	2,360 /- (दो हजार तीन सौ साठ रूपये)	46,220 /-		
5. किरसाली मान स्टेट के पास स्थित पार्क का विकास कार्य।	31,58,000 /- (इकतीस लाख अष्टावन हजार रूपये)	2,950 /- (दो हजार नौ सौ पचास रूपये)	63,160 /-		
6 अथोईवाला में पानी की टंकी के पास स्थित पार्क का विकास कार्य।	45,44,000 /- (पैतालीस लाख चौतालीस हजार रूपये)	3,540 /- (तीन हजार पाँच सौ चालीस रूपये)	90,880 /-		
7. हटवाल गांव के पास स्थित पार्क का विकास कार्य।	43,10,000 /- (तैतालीस लाख दस हजार रूपये)	3,540 /- (तीन हजार पाँच सौ चालीस रूपये)	86,200 /-		
नगर आयुक्त नगर निगम, देहरादून					

BRIEFLY

Mathis Albert youngest American in Bundesliga history

Mathis Albert became the youngest American to play in the Bundesliga when he made his debut for Borussia Dortmund on Sunday at the age of 16 years, 11 months and 5 days.

Albert, who is from Greenville, South Carolina, went on in the 88th minute of Dortmund's 4-0 German league win over Freiburg. He beat the record set by Gio Reyna, also playing for Dortmund, on January 18, 2020.

Reyna was 17 years, 2 months and 5 days old at the time, younger than the previous record-holder, Christian Pulisic, who was 17 years, 4 months, and 12 days old when he made his



Thomas Cup Finals: India beat Australia 5-0, reach quarters



India sealed a place in the Thomas Cup Finals quarterfinals with a commanding 5-0 sweep of Australia in a Group A tie on Monday.

India and China occupy the top spots in the group. The 2022 champions had opened with a 4-1 win over Canada, while China blanked Australia 5-0 and beat Canada 4-1 earlier in the day.

The two sides will clash in their final group tie on Wednesday to decide the group topper.

Paris Olympian and Commonwealth Games champion Lakshya Sen set the tone with a 21-14, 21-16 win over Ephraim Stephen Sam to hand India an early lead.

US Open champion Ayush Shetty, who recently finished runner-up at the Badminton Asia Championships, doubled the advantage with a dominant 21-8, 21-6 victory over Shrey Dhand.

India's top doubles pair of Satwiksairaj Rankireddy and Chirag Shetty, the Asian Games champions, made it 3-0, defeating Rizky Hidayat and Jack Yu 21-14, 21-16 to clinch the tie.

HS Prannoy, a bronze medallist at the 2023 World Championships and Asian Games, extended the lead with a 21-11, 21-17 win over Rishi Honda Boopathy in under 30 minutes. In the second doubles, Hariharan Amsakarunan and MR Arjun outplayed Andika Ramadiansyah and Ephraim Stephen Sam 21-12, 21-10 as India completed a flawless outing without dropping a match.

Red-carded keeper sparks brawl with punch in Spain



A second-division soccer game in Spain ended in a brawl after Zaragoza goalkeeper Esteban Andrada punched Huesca defender Jorge Pulido in the face. Huesca goalkeeper Dani Jimenez was later sent off for punching Andrada during the melee on Sunday.

The match was in its final minutes when Andrada shoved Pulido to the ground when he approached the Argentine goalkeeper. After the referee showed Andrada a second yellow card for the shove, the goalkeeper ran after Pulido and hit him in the face with a powerful right-hand punch.

An altercation between players and staff members from both teams ensued.

Andrada was in the middle of the brawl when Jimenez came running and hit him on the back of his head.

Shot nearly 50,000 targets every year, says champion Zoravar

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ New Delhi

Trap marksman Zoravar Singh has built his career on grit, grind and discipline, with his breakthrough coming last year through a rare World Championships bronze, a landmark he insists was no accident but the result of nearly 50,000 clay targets a year and relentless training in all conditions.

"I have done all that and more," said the champion trap marksman, noting that his journey has demanded an "extraordinary workload of nearly 45,000 to 50,000 cartridges a year, backed by constant tactical analysis of when to attack, when to hold back".

Zoravar, 48, became only the third Indian trap shooter to win a World Championships medal after legends Karni Singh and Manavjit Singh Sandhu, with the last such medal — a gold — coming in 2006 in Zagreb, Croatia, through Manavjit.



For Zoravar, the elusive medal in Athens last year was the culmination of "all the effort he had put in his professional shooting career spanning more than three decades".

"I have been at it since 2022," said Zoravar on the sidelines of an event, marking 75 years of the National Rifle Association of India (NRAI), here on Monday.

"The plan was clear after the National Games -- to break into the final. I set precise targets for myself, knowing I would have to survive shoot-offs in cut-throat competition just to secure a place in the finals.

"Because only then would a medal become possible. The first goal was simply to reach the final, and after that it was about trusting

the process and forgetting the result... and here we are," added Zoravar.

With one goal achieved, his next aim is to qualify for the 2028 Los Angeles Olympics, whose qualification cycle will begin with the World Championships later this year.

"We have the World Championships, then next year is a gruelling year, and there have been several rule changes also in shooting, so we have to comprehend that as well.

"Obviously, one who adapts the best in such a short time will be successful," the Delhi marksman said.

In between, there is also the Asian Games in Japan this September–October, but it is unlikely the champion marksman will feature in the Indian contingent due to "peaking" considerations after the World Championships and last year's World Cup Finals, which left him slightly short on momentum.

Indian rider Johann wins Qatar Superstock 600 Championship



PRESS TRUST OF INDIA ■ Doha

Johann Emmanuel has become the first Indian to win the Qatar Superstock 600 Championship (QSTK) by topping both races in the postponed final round in Doha.

The 19-year-old Chennai-based Johann, trailing championship leader Marton Bellei from Hungary by nine points going into the weekend's double-header, needed to win both races to seal the title, and he delivered in a stunning fashion.

Qualifying second, Johann won both races, withstanding immense pressure to clinch the championship with a 21-point advantage.

He finished the season with six wins out of 10 races, having endured a 200 kmph crash and three retirements due to mechanical issues.

Bhaker's confidence surges as Olympic qualification cycle nears

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA ■ New Delhi

India's double Olympic medallist shooter Manu Bhaker is brimming with confidence ahead of the new season, determined to reignite her competitive spark after a quiet spell following her Paris Games glory.

With the 2028 Los Angeles Olympics qualification cycle kicking off this year, Manu has her sights firmly set on the Asian Games and the World Championships — targets she believes will restore the competitive edge that powered her to two bronze medals at the 2024 Olympics.

"We have the Asian Games (in Japan) and the World Championships coming up at the end of this year, so definitely we are looking forward to the two major competitions," said the 24-year-old pistol ace on the sidelines of

an event, marking 75 years of the National Rifle Association of India (NRAI), here on Monday.

"So, the preparations which me and my coach we have... we sat down some time back, and we planned what the (upcoming) competitions are and what the preparedness is. I feel we have all the



things sorted and hopefully we will do very well," added the Jhajjar shooter who has endured a relatively quiet spell since her 2024 Paris success, managing a 10m air pistol World Cup silver last year and a 25m pistol silver at the Asian Championships in New Delhi this year.

Manu welcomed the move with clear excitement, delighted that shooting will return to the programme at the 2030 Commonwealth Games in India after being left out of both the 2022 edition in Birmingham and the upcoming Games in Glasgow.

HC upholds AITA poll results; Gita Mittal appointed as Administrator



AMANPREET SINGH
■ New Delhi

The Delhi High Court on Monday allowed the results of the All India Tennis Association (AITA) elections held on September 28, 2024, to stand, but directed that the elected body will function only as an interim arrangement under the supervision of a court-appointed Administrator, former Chief Justice Gita Mittal.

In its order, Justice Mini Pushkarna made it clear that while the outcome of the 2024 elections will not be disturbed at this stage, the executive committee will operate in a limited capacity and remain subject to the oversight of Justice (Retd.) Mittal.

It means that Chintan Parikh, who is from the Gujarat State Association, is the new AITA President, while Maharashtra's Sunder Iyer is General Secretary. Dinesh Arora from the Punjab Association is treasurer, while

CHINTAN PARIKH-LED AITA TO OPERATE TEMPORARILY UNDER ADMINISTRATOR

KSLTA's Sunil Yajman is one of the joint secretaries.

"It's a great moment for tennis in India. All we want is to promote the game in the country and take it to the pinnacle. We want to do a lot for junior tennis as well. While we will work as an interim body for the time being, it still is a huge step forward to create a system through which the Indian tennis ecosystem will benefit," Iyer said.

The court tasked Justice Mittal with managing the affairs of AITA and ensuring that its functioning is aligned with the National Sports Code and the amended constitution and by-laws by June 30.

As of now, AITA has a 25-member Executive Committee, but as per the NSG Act, it needs to be a 15-member panel.

Mirabai Chanu set to miss Asian Championships due to injury

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ New Delhi

Star Indian weightlifter Mirabai Chanu is set to miss the rescheduled Asian Championships in Gandhinagar next month due to a shoulder injury.

The Tokyo Olympics silver medallist and former world champion had sustained the injury during the National Championships in February.

"Mirabai picked up a shoulder niggle during the Nationals. It is an important year with the Commonwealth Games and Asian Games scheduled back-to-back, and she cannot afford to take any risks," a source close to the developments said.

Komal Kohar is likely to take Chanu's place in the Indian team.

At the National Champi-



onships in Modinagar, Chanu had won the 48kg gold with a total effort of 205kg (89kg+116kg). She also attempted a 91kg snatch lift but was unsuccessful.

The 31-year-old will compete in the 48kg category at the Commonwealth Games 2026, scheduled from July 23 to August 2, before bulking up to the 53kg category for the Asian Games 2026 in October.

Pranavi Urs finishes T-24 at Investec SA Women's Open; Diksha Dagar fades

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA ■ Cape Town

Pranavi Urs carded 1-under 72 to finish as the top-Indian at tied-24th in the Investec SA Women's Open golf tournament, even as compatriot Diksha Dagar (76) slipped on the final day in Cape Town.

Pranavi and Diksha finished T-24th and T-37th, respectively, while Avani Prashanth (77) was T-57th. Three other Indians in the fray, Vani Kapoor, Tvesa Malik and Hitaashee Bakshi, had missed the halfway cut.

Meanwhile, England's Esme

Hamilton earned her maiden LET title with a two-shot victory. Hamilton fired a final round 71 (-2) to beat Cara Gainer and Pia Babnik for the title following an epic battle with compatriot Cara Gainer.

A former SA Open winner, Diksha, opened with five pars before she bogeyed the sixth and the ninth. On the back nine, she birdied the 11th but double bogeyed the 15th for a disappointing finish.

Pranavi, who has come close to a title a few times, including at the Indian Open, teed off from the



back nine and had two bogeys and one birdie on the stretch.

On the second nine, she birdied three times between the first and the fifth, but gave away a shot on the eighth and dropped out of the Top 20.

Avani had two birdies, two bogeys and two double bogeys. It was a wet, windy final day at Royal Cape Golf Club as Hamilton grabbed a two-shot victory with a 15-under par total. The win is Hamilton's first on the LET in just her 23rd

start after joining the circuit as a rookie last year.

Tied with Slovenia's Pia Babnik heading into the final round, and one clear of Gainer, Hamilton bogeyed the third before racing into a two-shot lead with birdies at the fifth and sixth as Babnik dropped a shot at the first.

However, at the challenging ninth, Gainer produced a clutch birdie, and Hamilton carded a double-bogey. This produced a three-shot swing, and the two were tied at 12-under par at the turn.

PV Sindhu begins tenure as BWF council member

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA ■ Horsens (Denmark)

Two-time Olympic medallist PV Sindhu has promised to represent the voices of the shuttlers from across the globe in her tenure as Badminton World Federation (BWF) Council member, a rare role for an active player.

One of the most accomplished players in the sport's history, Sindhu has assumed a full voting position on the BWF Council following her election as Chair of the BWF Athletes' Commission in December.

After completing the formal vetting process, Sindhu officially entered the BWF Council at the end of 2025. She made her first appearance before the global badminton membership during the Annual General Meeting here on April 25, marking the beginning of her tenure.

"It is a true honour and privilege to take on this responsibility within the Badminton World Federation and to represent the voices of athletes from around the world. "Badminton has given me so much, and I feel deeply grateful for the opportunity to contribute to the sport in this capacity," she said in a release.

Her presence within the BWF Council is particularly significant as it remains rare for an active athlete competing at the highest level to simultaneously hold a voting position within badminton's global gover-



nance structure. In this role, Sindhu will help ensure that the voices, experiences and priorities of players are represented at the highest levels of decision-making.

The BWF Council plays a central role in guiding the strategic direction and governance of badminton worldwide.

As a voting member of the BWF Council, Sindhu will participate in discussions and decisions on matters that shape the future of the sport, bringing the perspectives and experiences of elite athletes directly into the heart of global badminton leadership.

Her elevation to the BWF Council reflects the trust placed in her leadership, experience and understanding of the sport at the highest level.

Simons to miss World Cup, Spurs' season with ACL injury

STEVE DOUGLAS ■ London

Netherlands midfielder Xavi Simons will miss the World Cup as well as relegation-threatened Tottenham's final Premier League games of the season after rupturing the ACL in his right knee.

In an emotional post on Instagram, the 23-year-old Simons — one of the best Dutch players at the European Championship in 2024 — said he is "heartbroken" and that "none of it makes sense."

Simons screamed in pain and grabbed his knee following a challenge by Wolverhampton defender Hugo Bueno in the second half of Tottenham's 1-0 win on Saturday that renewed the

team's hopes of staying in the top flight. He was carried off on a stretcher.

On Monday, Tottenham confirmed Simons ruptured his anterior cruciate ligament and will undergo surgery "in the coming weeks."

"Everyone at Tottenham Hotspur sends Xavi our love and support — we will be with him every step of the way," the club said.

In his Instagram post, Simons wrote: "My season has come to an abrupt end, and I'm just trying to process it."

"All I've wanted to do is fight for my team, and now the ability to do that has been snatched away from me ... along with the World Cup," he wrote. "Representing my country this summer... just gone."

"It'll take time to find peace with this, but

I'll continue to be the best teammate I can be. I have no doubt that together we'll win this fight."

Tottenham remained in the relegation zone, in third-to-last place and two points from safety, despite its first league win in 2026, and is in big danger of losing its top-flight status for the first time since the late 1970s. Tottenham has four games left this season.

Simons, who joined from Leipzig for 60 million euros (\$70 million) in the offseason, hasn't been a regular starter for the Spurs but has been in the lineup in recent matches under newly hired manager Roberto De Zerbi.

He helped the Dutch reach the semifinals at Euro 2024 and was expected to be key for the team at the World Cup, where they're in a group with Sweden, Tunisia and Japan.



RCB thrash DC by nine wickets

AMANPREET SINGH ■ New Delhi

Royal Challengers Bengaluru rode a storm of sheer pace fury to annihilate Delhi Capitals by nine wickets in their IPL clash here on Monday, after unleashing a powerplay spell so vicious that it virtually ended the contest within the first three overs.

It was carnage of the highest order, a powerplay ambush so brutal that the Delhi Capitals never quite recovered as RCB unleashed a devastating new-ball spell to script one of the most dramatic openings in the IPL history.

Josh Hazlewood (4/12) and Bhuvneshwar Kumar (3/5) turned the powerplay into a demolition act, ripping through Delhi with two ruthless three-over bursts that left the hosts gasping at 13 for six.

Only Abhishek Porel (30), David Miller (19) and Kyle Jamieson (12) reached double-digit scores. The home team scored eight fours and a six.



All Delhi could manage was 75 in 16.3 overs but eventually deflected the ignominy of posting lowest IPL score. RCB had managed 49 in 2017 against Kolkata Knight Riders.

Chasing a modest target, RCB openers Virat Kohli (23) and Jacob Bethell (20) ensured

a smooth start.

There were no hiccups except that Bethell was done in by an exceptional catch by T Natarajan off Kyle Jamieson.

Devdutt Padikkal scored a fluent 34 as some solid RCB batting took the game away from Delhi in no time..

Kohli's trademark composure combined with Padikkal's free-flowing strokeplay made the chase a mere formality as the duo raced past the finish line with ease in 6.3 overs, capping off a dominant night for the visitors.

The packed house came to

watch their favourite batter but Kohli didn't get the opportunity to enthrall his fans much due to a small target. The local boy, ended the match with consecutive sixes off T Natarajan.

From the dizzying high of piling up 264 in a batting spectacle that still somehow ended in defeat against Punjab Kings, the fall for Delhi was dramatic. The same batting unit that was brimming with intent suddenly appeared tentative, brittle, and out of answers, undone by relentless pressure and disciplined bowling..

It was a stark reminder of the format's unforgiving nature, where dominance can swiftly give way to disarray, and confidence can evaporate almost overnight.

The RCB bowlers reduced Delhi to survival mode inside the first three overs, their relentless accuracy and movement turning the contest one-sided almost instantly. (PTI)

Langer defends sending Pooran to face Narine in Super Over



PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ Lucknow

Lucknow Super Giants head coach Justin Langer defended sending out-of-form Nicholas Pooran to face Kolkata Knight Riders' star spinner Sunil Narine in the Super Over of their IPL match, saying the team management thought the explosive West Indian batter was the best option despite his lean run.

Pooran, who has laboured for runs this IPL season with 22 being his highest, got out first ball, bowled by Narine and LSG ended up at 1 for 2 in the Super Over. KKR needed just one ball to win the match.

"Good question. We knew that Sunil Narine had bowled it, and if you look at Nicky's (Nicholas Pooran) record, he's seen Sunil Narine more than anyone in world cricket. So we felt that he was still the best option," Langer said at the post-match press conference.

"I know he hasn't hit his form yet, and Nicky will be the first to admit that, but we thought if anyone can handle a Super Over, it's Nicky Pooran. You back your best players. He has struggled, but if you look at all the numbers, no one plays Narine, the world-class off-spinner, better than Nicky. It didn't come off, unfortunately," he added.

There was also a bit of history. The lone maiden

Super Over in the history of T20 cricket was bowled by Narine in the Caribbean Premier League (CPL) in 2014, and Pooran was one of the batters who got out without scoring in that instance also.

"There's probably no greater T20 player (than Pooran) currently in the world over the last few years. It just goes to show he's human, and you can't fake confidence. We all try to. You can look confident, but confidence comes from getting your processes right," Langer said.

LSG captain Rishabh Pant had also defended the choice of Pooran to bat in the Super Over.

"We had a discussion as a group, and the name that came up was (of) Nicholas Pooran's (for Super Over). He might not go through the best form of his life, but at the same time, you will trust your player in a hard situation like this," Pant said at the post-match presentation. Langer admitted that his team could not adjust to the black-soil wicket on offer on Sunday.



"It's frustrating. I said after the last game I thought the wicket was very good on the red soil, and it was fast and bouncy. It's really exciting for cricket, and we didn't adapt today to the black soil, which was slower and lower and spun a little bit.

"So, it's frustrating. We're not adapting to the conditions as well as we should be." The former Australian batter was all praise for Mohsin Khan, who picked up 5/23 for a lost cause.

"I said earlier, I thought he (Mohsin) and Prince would soon play cricket for India. And the thing about Mohsin Khan is, he is an incredible athlete.

"He's done some great work with Bharat Arun. He spent — what a lot of people don't know — a few months at Bharat's academy in Chennai leading up to this... he worked hard, and he's getting fit.

"That's why he was so disappointed when he hurt his quad after the first game, because we can see how valuable he is.

"We haven't had him much for the last two seasons, and it's a great thrill for us to have him in the team, and it wouldn't surprise me if it's a great thrill for India to have him in their team in the not-too-distant future," he said.

Langer rued his side conceding 43 runs in the last two overs on a "pretty low, tougher batting wicket."

Keshav Maharaj replaces injured Mitchell Santner in MI's squad



PRESS TRUST OF INDIA ■ Mumbai

South African spin-bowling all-rounder Keshav Maharaj on Monday replaced New Zealand's Mitchell Santner in the Mumbai Indians' squad for the remainder of the Indian Premier League.

Santner has been ruled out owing to a shoulder injury, which he sustained during the team's last match at the Wankhede Stadium against Chennai Super Kings.

"Mumbai Indians (MI) have signed South Africa spinner Keshav Maharaj as a replacement for Mitchell Santner, who has been ruled out of the Indian Premier League (IPL) 2026 owing to a left shoulder injury," the IPL said in a statement.

"Santner sustained the injury during MI's last home game against Chennai Super Kings while attempting a catch near the boundary."

"Maharaj, an experienced left-arm spinner, recently featured in the T20I series against New Zealand. He has featured in two IPL matches, representing Rajasthan Royals in 2024. He joins MI for a fee of INR 75 lakh," it added.

Santner took a fine diving catch to dismiss CSK's Kartik Sharma off Jasprit Bumrah, but in the process hit his shoulder and head on the ground. He was later replaced by Shardul Thakur as a concussion substitute in the game.

MI head coach Jayawardene had informed that Santner was taken for scans after he felt not being "stable".

"I think he hit his head first, neck, obviously the shoulder as well. He went for a scan because once he got back, he felt dizzy, so he was lying down. Yes, the ice (pack) was there for the shoulder.

RR need something special against unbeaten Punjab Kings

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ Mullanpur

Riyen Parag, a captain short of runs, will need to lead from the front to challenge a peerless Punjab Kings in their Indian Premier League match on Tuesday.

In the Shreyas Iyer-Ricky Ponting era that began last year, the Punjab Kings have scripted a sensational turnaround, making them the most consistent and assuring unit in the competition, attributes they longed for ages.

Virat Kohli owned the tag of chase-master with his remarkable consistency over the years, and now Iyer too is on that path. As a leader and batter, he has displayed commendable calm in high-pressure situations to help the Punjab Kings stay unbeaten in the tournament thus far.

Iyer has led brilliantly, but the team as a whole too has functioned like a well-oiled unit. Last season, they managed to defend the lowest total in IPL history, and on a scorching Saturday in New Delhi, Iyer and Co. gunned down a record 265-run target with ridiculous ease.

The six wins in seven games (one washout) have also been made possible by the destructive opening duo of Priyansh Arya and Prabhsimran Singh, who put their team on course for a historic



chase at Kotla by hammering 116 runs in the powerplay.

Punjab Kings bowlers took a beating in that match, but considering the batting-friendly conditions and small ground dimensions, they could not be blamed much.

Playing their last game of the season here before hosting their final three league games of the season in Dharamsala, Punjab Kings will be expected to steamroll the Rajasthan Royals. The Royals

have lost momentum in the middle phase of the tournament, having won their first four games.

While teen sensation Vaibhav Sooryavanshi has produced jaw-dropping performances, the team has not been able to maintain consistency.

Eight games into the season, captain Parag has failed to deliver in the middle order, collecting just 88 runs in eight innings at an underwhelming strike rate of 112.82. The pressure on him is mounting with every game.

Fitness only hurdle for Mohsin Khan's India debut: Irfan Pathan

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA ■ New Delhi

Former India pacer Irfan Pathan believes fitness remains the only hurdle between injury-prone left-arm seamer Mohsin Khan and an India debut.

The 27-year-old from Uttar Pradesh, standing at 6ft 3in, has been in impressive form, picking up nine wickets in his last four matches, including a five-wicket haul for 23 runs against Kolkata Knight Riders on Sunday.

Highlighting Mohsin's ability to strike in maiden overs, JioStar expert Pathan said: "...whenever he bowls a maiden over, he always ensures to

get the wicket of the batter. He did the same thing against Vaibhav Sooryavanshi last time and now against Tim Seifert; the same plan worked.

"When he dismissed Seifert, a run was taken through a leg bye, but Mohsin bowled well and took the wicket. He has bowled three maiden overs this



season, and one of them was a wicket-keeper against a batter like Vaibhav Sooryavanshi.

"That shows the high quality of Mohsin Khan. If he manages to stay fit, no one can stop him from playing international cricket for India. His fitness is the only roadblock as he stays injured for long periods."

Pathan, however, pointed to recurring injuries as a concern.

"It is unfortunate, but his bowling action puts a lot of strain on his body. A few seasons back, a hand injury kept him out of many games. Lucknow Super Giants supported him a lot during that phase and helped him recover," he said.

England set to play tri-series with Sri Lanka in Pakistan



PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ Karachi

England are set to feature in a triangular one-day series with Sri Lanka in Pakistan as part of their preparation for next year's ICC 50-over World Cup.

A reliable source close to the Pakistan Cricket Board said on Monday that after

long negotiations, the England and Wales Cricket Board (ECB) had finally given their approval to participate in the triangular series.

PCB has already secured Sri Lanka Cricket's agreement for the triangular series, tentatively scheduled for December-January.

"The PCB is likely to hold matches at just two venues,

Lahore and Karachi, but dates and venues would be finalised soon," the source said.

The PCB had also held a T20 tri-series late last year as preparation for the ICC World T20 Cup, with Pakistan, Zimbabwe and Sri Lanka participating after Afghanistan pulled out its team at the last moment.

Bangladesh beat NZ by 6 wickets in T20 series opener

ASSOCIATED PRESS
■ Chattogram

Tawhid Hridoy's half-century led Bangladesh to a six-wicket victory against New Zealand to open their T20 international series on Monday.

Hridoy finished 51 not out from 27 balls, including two fours and three sixes. He shared a 57-run partnership with Parvez Hossain and another 49 with Shamim Hossain in an unbeaten fifth wicket to help Bangladesh race to victory.

New Zealand posted a challenging 182-6, after 51 apiece from Dane Cleaver and opener Katene Clarke, and appeared set for victory as its bowlers checked Bangladesh top order batters, leaving the hosts 77-3 in the 11th over.

But Hridoy's calculated aggression helped Bangladesh reach 183-4 with 12 balls to spare.

Leg-spinner Ish Sodhi, the only holdover from New



Zealand's recent World Cup campaign, led the visitors' early charge with 2-40.

Hridoy then counterattacked to bring the asking run rate under control with support from Parvez Hossain, who made 28 off 14 balls. After his dismissal, Shamim Hossain came in to hit

an unbeaten 31 off 13 balls.

Bangladesh captain Liton Das won the toss and put New Zealand into bat first. Clarke and Cleaver shared an 88-run stand for the second wicket after opener Tim Robinson was run out for a duck in the second over.

SLC board calls special meeting on Silva's future



PRESS TRUST OF INDIA ■ Colombo

Sri Lanka Cricket board has called for a special Executive Committee meeting on Tuesday to discuss the future of the current chief Shammie Silva after the country's president Anura Kumara Dissanayake called for a new administration to take over.

Dissanayake has already made it clear that he wants Silva to make way for a new administration to run cricket.

Sources said that the Executive Committee members could decide to resign en masse, which would allow for the calling of a fresh election for office bearers.

Silva has his current term until May of 2027, but faces calls to relinquish office.